

Dutch Academy

Football Coaching U14-U15



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DUTCH ACADEMY FOOTBALL COACHING (U14-15)

Functional Training & Tactical Practices from Top Dutch Coaches



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Coach Profiles



Andries Ulderink - Assistant Manager at Reading FC and former AFC Ajax U21 Head Coach

- UEFA Pro Licence
- 2016 - Present: Assistant Manager at Reading FC
- 2014-2016: AFC Ajax U21 Head Coach
- 2013-2014: AFC Ajax Scout
- 2012-2013: AGOVV Apeldoorn Manager
- 2011-2012: De Graafschap Manager
- 2008-2011: Go Ahead Eagles Manager
- 2005-2006: De Graafschap Academy Director



Han Berger - Chairman of the Dutch Professional Coaches (CBV) and former Netherlands U21 Head Coach

- UEFA Pro Licence
- 2015 – Present: Chairman of the Dutch Professional Football Coaches (CBV)
- 2009-2015: Australia National Team Technical Director
- 2005-2008: De Graafschap Technical Director
- 2000-2003: FC Utrecht Technical Director
- 1998–2000: Netherlands U21 Head Coach
- 1993–1995: Sparta Rotterdam Head Coach
- 1983–1986: FC Groningen Head Coach



Henk Mariman - Former Club Brugge Academy Director and AFC Ajax Assistant Academy Director

- UEFA A Licence and TVJO PRO (Professional Academy Director Course)
- 2013 - Present: Head of Football Development at DoublePass
- 2011–2012: Club Brugge KV Technical Director
- 2007–2011: Club Brugge KV Academy Director
- 2004–2007: Germinal Beerschot Academy Director
- 1999–2004: Germinal Beerschot / Ajax Assistant Academy Director
- Coached Mousa Dembele, Jan Verthongen and Thomas Vermaelen



Louis Coolen - Football Consultant / Teacher KNVB (Dutch Football Federation) and former Zenit St. Petersburg Academy Director

- UEFA Pro Licence
- 2017 - Present: Football Consultant / Teacher KNVB
- 2016 - 2017: Roda JC Technical Director
- 2011–2015: Zenit St. Petersburg Academy Director
- 2008 - 2011: Konoplev Academy Tolyatti (Russia), Academy Director
- 2005–2007: FC Eindhoven Head Coach
- 2001–2005: Roda JC Assistant Coach
- 1996–2001: Helmond Sport Head Coach

Tactical Patterns & Practice Format

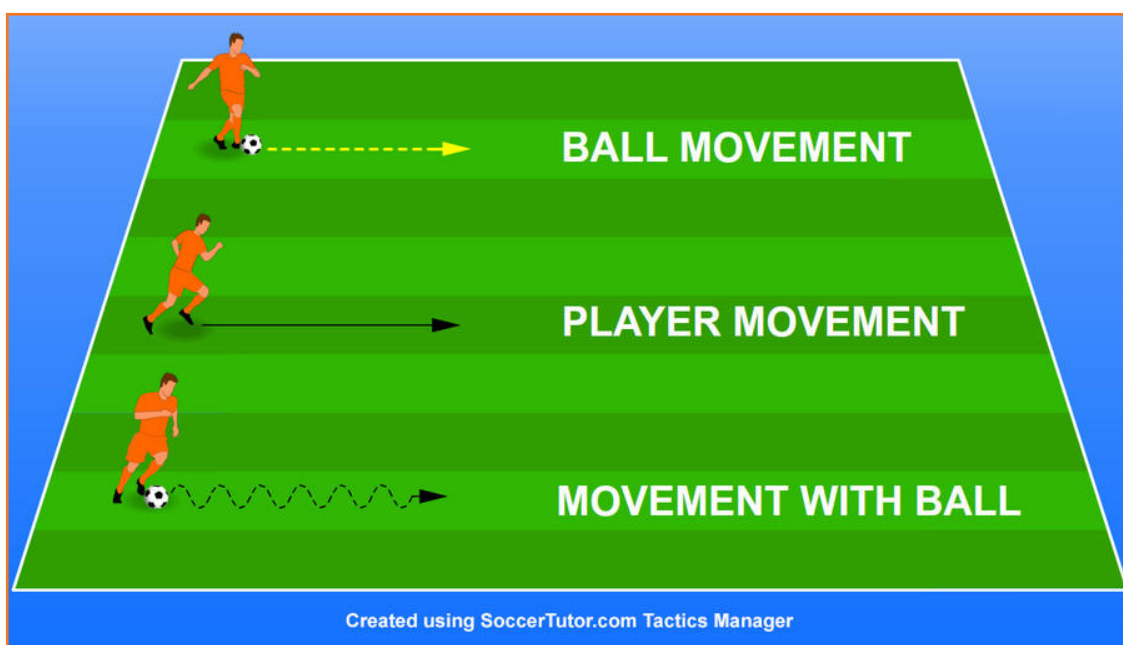
Each tactical pattern of play includes clear diagrams with supporting notes:

- Name of Tactical Situation
- Description of Tactical Situation and Pattern of Play

Each practice includes clear diagrams with supporting training notes:

- Name of Practice
- Objective of Practice
- Description of Practice
- Variation or Progression (if applicable)
- Coaching Points

Key



Basic Principles



OUTLINE OF REQUIREMENTS

- Training sessions using the 4-3-3 formation.
- Determining players' positions within a system.
- Tactical instructions for each position.

CONTENT OF TRAINING

- Number of sessions per week = 4 (+ match)
- Duration of each training session = 75-90 minutes.
- Functional acts during the match and basic passing practices.
- Positional play with basic practices such as 4 v 3, 5 v 4, 6 v 5.
- Individual training.
- Small sided games from 4 v 4 to 9 v 9.
- Start training in defensive and midfield lines (from 6 v 4 to 8 v 8).
- 4-3-3 match-specific training (basic formation).
- Transitions: Learn the basic principles during match-specific practices and 4-3-3 system training.
- Dynamic stretching and stability exercises during warm-ups.

CHAPTER 1

AGE SPECIFIC CHARACTERISTICS

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Age Specific Characteristics (U14-15)

Summary of Age Specific Characteristics (U14-15)

- Eager to learn.
- Easily distracted.
- Stagnation or decrease in coordination.
- Growth spurt (sensitive/prone to injuries).
- 'The reasons' (why) become significant.
- Pre-adolescence: Stubborn, resistance against authority, provocative, conflictive.
- Overestimation of oneself.
- Development of other interests and hobbies. Football has the potential to get a whole different perspective in life.
- In this phase, the intellectual learning ability is bigger than the physical learning ability.

Under 14-15 year old players would like to play football all day long, which indicates that they are enjoying the game. They are very eager to learn, but they are also easily distracted.

The second year players (U15), but also the first year juniors (U14), will start to experience some physical difficulties. What seemed to be second nature in the past has suddenly become rather challenging, with coordination and balance most affected. The growth clearly has an effect, and for the coach and staff, it's important to stimulate the boys in a positive way. If you don't, then the boys will start to doubt themselves and take a different attitude. The player must get the feeling that he's being stimulated as an individual, as well as part of a group.

A distinctive characteristic of players at this age is that the abstract mental capacity develops itself and personal opinions arise. This means that 'the reasons' (why) become significant. As a coach you need to have a deep understanding for the inconsistency that occurs during this time. When you are guiding them, you must take the discrepancies within this group into account, on a physical level, as well as socially and emotionally.

A younger player (U12-14) is often insecure and this means you have to stimulate him regularly and provide clear instructions. The older player (U15-17) becomes more independent and wants more responsibility. This in turn means that you can give them the initiative more often, so the responsibility is shared.

Players Coaching on the Pitch

Under 14-15 players are characterised by huge differences in the mental and physical sphere. Players also have to become aware of the need for mutual collaboration to perform well. By now they have sufficient experience playing on full sized pitches, so they can look beyond their own positions.

Mentally, the players have to be aware that as a team, they have to promote an invincible mentality. They need to learn to coach each other on the pitch. Coaching means supporting, helping each other, and announcing when your teammate has somebody close behind him or when the ball has to be passed back. You would perhaps think that's obvious, but for this age group it isn't. Also pay attention to correcting and stimulating each other. A player is allowed to voice his opinion if the ball gets lost while he was available to receive it.

A lack of coaching can be twofold. On one hand you have to deal with the personality of the boy; he might be timid, shy and will therefore not express himself dominantly. Thus in general it's about the self-confidence of the team. If several players lose their self-confidence, then basically there are only a few resources available to get them back on track, through hard work and luck. By remaining positive during coaching, rewarding them appropriately, being complimentary and working hard, the self-confidence will be regained.

A victory can have an extremely positive effect and lead to changes. On the other hand, the lack of mutual coaching could also be a technical problem.

If somebody experiences too many difficulties with controlling the ball, turning and passing, then this also influences the right moment to coach. It certainly isn't easy to tell someone within two seconds what he has to do if he needs five seconds for the act alone. Therefore, repetition and practice are essential.

From Training Ground to Matches

Eventually you would expect that whatever the players learn in specific training sessions would also be visible during competitive matches. The younger the player, the more difficult this connection is. Take the transition from attack to defence after losing possession as an example - players have to make the choice between applying pressure directly and dropping back. The players, sometimes by negligence, will make the wrong decision every now and then, but this is just part of their development. The more repetitions of game situations and good coaching the players have, the better their decision making will become.

Physical Growth and Growth Spurts

As a coach, you have to be very alert to the people that are going through a growth spurt. Growing pains affecting the knees are extremely common. In this case, the player has to reduce their physical load. If the pain increases even during moderate jogging, then perhaps the player needs to cease participating in practicing sports temporarily. In consultation with a physiotherapist, you would then have to look at how to increase the load at some stage. 'Pain' is the key indicator so the player has to communicate clearly regarding his status.

Due to rapid growth spurts at this age, many players will start to become tall and thin, experiencing difficulties with their agility, running and turning. This makes them prone to injuries. It is also common that players remain small for a long time, which causes a shortage during physical duels. As a coach, you have no influence over this and this problem will always persist with players in this age group.

You have to pay attention to the work/rest ratio during training to prevent players from experiencing

permanent damage caused by their rapid growth. In addition, you should make use of coordination and running sessions if possible. Also, beware that you should not promote a player who has grown rapidly to an older age group too quickly, even if he looks ready physically, as this is not always the case.

We see a trend that the growth spurt occurs at an increasingly younger age. Generally, the growth spurt occurs between the age of 12 and 14, but this is not always the case. The criterion that you can rely on is the growth of one centimetre per month. If a player grows more, then their training load should be reduced. It may even be necessary to reduce the amount of training sessions you have in a week.

The period after the summer break is also an important measuring point. Youth players often grow a bit more than average during holidays, which causes their load capacity to be temporarily lower. As a coach, you have to take this into account during pre-season. By reducing the load (temporarily) for such players in July/August, you can prevent any avoidable injuries.

It's important to realise that the players who grow the most during the summer break are much more likely to get injured. Therefore, you have to provide a customised solution. For those players who are experiencing a growth spurt, static stretching will also play a role. We do not believe this method of stretching has any use during a warm-up before training and matches, but during rapid growth periods, it can be useful to remove muscle tension.

If a player moves up to an older age group at a younger stage, then the load versus load capacity has to be monitored closely. For example, in the beginning he shouldn't train twice a day. The intensity of the training has increased for him and often that step is already big enough. After a while you can align this to the rest of the group. The judgement of the coach determines this.

A player with growth problems is a clear example of a player with a (temporarily) lower load capacity, so it's sensible to let this player train once or twice less per

week to prevent overload. Sometimes it is common for a player with growth issues to only train twice a week throughout the whole season. It's better to accept this concession than to risk injuring the player and rendering him unable to train for months as a result of problems with parts of the body, such as the patellar tendon (knee ligament) or heels.

Periodization

Before the growth spurt takes place, you can also certainly apply the periodization model; only then it becomes underload, i.e. not the fitness. On one hand you let the players get used to the way of training in advance and on the other hand you assure yourself of having a variety of training content to offer. Then we're talking about the change between big and small practices.

On the basis of these general guidelines, each coach obviously has to customise this for their team. Sometimes a particular situation demands completely different things than the planned fitness incentive. The principle is that, so to speak, the fitness 'exit level' of one season already provides direction to the 'entry level' of next season. By applying this structured method, football players will become even stronger from one year to the next. The player must be given the chance to grow therein. A central periodization programme throughout the whole youth academy is the future.

Dealing with Criticism

The mental aspect within the Under 14-15 age group could be improved sometimes. The players at this age really begin dealing with criticism. In this age group they will start to speak up for the very first time and the players will dare to voice their opinions. It's nice if they receive compliments or get to hear what they're doing well, but they also have to be aware of their weaknesses and how they can improve. Therefore, the coach plays a significant role. It's important as a coach and staff to be a positive stimulant for the players individually and the team as a whole. On the other hand, players also have to become a bit tougher if they want to reach a higher level.

Constructing the practices with competitive elements increases the enjoyment and the dedication the players have. Use many practices consisting of positional play and small sided games, which eventually produce a winning and losing team. Then you will notice that the losing side will complain a lot and that they will point fingers at each other. These are very interesting moments! If this happens, then get the group together and let the losing team do the talking. Where did it go wrong? What was the cause? What can you do individually and as a team to improve this? During these moments, the players will be confronted with themselves. Subsequently, the coach can see who make use of the information and who doesn't.

The same principle applies during the post-match discussion. Especially after games that were lost, players first tend to point fingers at everything but themselves. The coach ability of players varies a lot. Some respond quite rapidly and show that they understood the message; while for others this process will not go as smoothly. A player for instance, has to improve the way he calls for the ball. Only calling for the ball isn't sufficient, even though he thinks it is. It can take a considerable amount of time before he becomes aware to distinguish between the run towards the ball and a deep run. The coach in this example then also has to make his teammates jointly responsible by letting them coach. Sometimes this is too much to ask for, because they're still mainly busy with carrying out their own, individual task. The coach needs to understand this. It is about using your best judgment for each situation.

Teams in this age group are often inconsistent. Against the stronger teams, the coach doesn't have to motivate anyone but against weaker opponents the players sometimes tend to think too easily about it. Then you make it unnecessarily difficult for yourself. And if a game isn't going well, you must at least work hard for the team. Then the question becomes about whether that characteristic is present in someone naturally or not, but everybody can at least give it a try by working hard and not being shy about it.

Team Development

The game of football becomes increasingly complex for players at Under 15 level. Whilst they have been busy technically during their early years, the tactical aspect will now come into play as well. In addition to the development of an individual player, the team development becomes increasingly important (communication/coordination). Each player must know what his task is for each position and how to operate in his line and within the team. The training often consists of possession games, where you attempt to improve this collaboration. We also make sure not to forget about continuing our specific technical training. We work in blocks for a couple of weeks. Each of these blocks gets linked to a theme, such as ball control/mastery, receiving, ball-striking technique, defending etc. That's how we try to prepare the players during training to the best of their abilities for what's yet to come.

As the season progresses, the coach should try to make the players increasingly responsible with his coaching. The 'match problem' will be transferred to them more often and he allows them to find a solution themselves. For each player, it differs enormously for how they deal with this. Sometimes you should give them an assignment as a group during training or outside. As a coach you can then observe the different roles in the team very well. Who is the leader? Who follows? This is always very interesting. If the 'leader' also coaches independently and organises the team well, then it could be the case that he's fit to be named captain.

The individual development on a technical, tactical, physical and personality level remains the principle. At the start of the season, we can set up a personal development plan by creating a couple of objectives for each individual player. Make players aware that just being talented isn't enough. You really need to have the will and ambition to succeed as a professional football player.

The first-string players always need to feel the pressure that they have to perform, or else another player will take their place. A player, who is often

a substitute, mainly needs to be told why he's a substitute and what he could do to earn a spot in the first eleven.

We evaluate players over a full season. At the end of the season, we decide whether the player in question can continue his training. This ensures everyone gets an equal chance.

Solving Problems Themselves

Within the academy level there shouldn't be any talk about championships, as long as the teams can't be relegated. The main focus is the development of the players and in particular the one or two talents in the team who have the potential to reach the first team. With U15 players, however, it is extremely difficult to determine who will 'make it' and who will not.

The coach can see how someone develops throughout a whole season. Under the coach's guidance, each player has to take responsibility for himself. He shouldn't only follow everything the coach says. Give the players sufficient room to talk and speak up for themselves. A good coach also wants to know how the players think about football, what their perception is and how they look at problems and solutions in relation to football.

Assessing Individual Development

The assessment of the individual development of talented players takes place by means of an **age-specific football report card**, which is linked to the football learning plan. This way a uniform method arises in the coaching staff of the football academy, in regards to looking at and assessing talented players.

The most important objective of the football academy is the individual development of the player. In the junior teams of the academy, the talent development is mainly focused on technical improvement and developing creativity. The basic principles are:

- Learning to perform while having fun
- Continuing to develop technique
- Teaching basic attacking and defending tactics

On a tactical level, the team is encouraged and it is key to make sure that they get the space needed to play football (keeping the pitch big with coordinated runs and movement). From a defensive perspective, we pay greatest attention to putting the opposition under pressure collectively as a team. The practices have to be intensive and challenging, so players are constantly stimulated.

Furthermore, it's important that match-specific elements are trained. The practices are therefore often linked to finishing on goal. During sharp small sided games (where many 1 v 1 duels occur) the players are being encouraged to develop themselves. In each practice they should be able to score in a big goal with a goalkeeper.

Improving young players doesn't happen naturally. Some key conditions to continuously stimulate their development at an early age are:

- **Top Sport Rhythm** - Young players are in need of a steady daily rhythm for their diet, workload and rest (hours of sleep), which all play a key role. For example, players are not allowed to attend a first team game if they have to play a game themselves the following day.
- **Always Train Sharply from an Early Age!** - By demanding the maximum from players in a fun environment, players become better. For instance, small sided games shouldn't be played without an objective in mind. The winners will always be rewarded. This way their match mentality (the will to win) gets stimulated.
- **Display Enjoyment! (Coaches & Players)** - The players spend a big portion of their youth at the club. Of course, enjoyment should come first. Training and playing matches therefore have to be exciting, so the players and the coaches have to promote this.
- **Top Sport Culture/Atmosphere at the Training Ground** - Talented players also have to be encouraged off the pitch. The urge to perform and improve (investing in yourself) should be a given from an early age. Training hard and taking care

of yourself in a healthy performance-orientated atmosphere is therefore a never-ending objective in the football academy.

- **Optimal Secondary Conditions** - Important secondary conditions are the educational and medical supervision. Eventually what matters is that the individual talent can be developed in practice on the pitch. Qualitative and enthusiastic coaches and a practice-orientated working method in the academy are therefore the most important secondary conditions to improve player performance.

Rules/Discipline

Under 15 players can already be quite outspoken. The players display clear physical differences, have an increasing will to win and develop their own identity. Furthermore, they form their own opinions. Together with the team, the coach can sit around the table to put the rules, penalties and rewards on paper.

The players should come up with the rules themselves, along with some fitting consequences. At that moment the coach isn't the leader of the conversation, but instead the supervisor. He only gets involved in the conversation if he thinks that not everyone contributes in the thinking process or if they have forgotten the rules. Ultimately, almost the same rules will be on paper as the ones the coach would have thought of. Only the penalties will perhaps be slightly different. The team can for instance earn something by winning three times in a row or by keeping a clean sheet for a couple matches. The players also determine when someone should be a substitute as punishment. For example, if they don't attend training or if a teammate hasn't trained hard enough. With this, make sure that the subject of bullying gets included in the rules. Since you hardly get in the locker room as a coach, your view on what actually happens in there is limited. At this age, bullying is something that occurs frequently. That's why it's important that it's being discussed. The players get the responsibility to inform the coach once something happens in this area, and should feel very comfortable to do so.

The Importance of Discipline

Discipline is required to achieve success, even at this age. Agreements shall be made to reach a certain objective. The coach should be clear about this aspect in his story towards the players. At the start of the season, agreements will be made and these must be honoured. The coach monitors this process. Discipline, not only on the pitch, but also outside i.e. being on time, good behaviour when travelling, cleaning your boots etc, are essential.

On the pitch, the balls need to be pumped and we need enough cones and bibs. A coach should also provide clarity regarding the practices as to why they are doing this practice, and how it relates to matches.

It is important to be clear with players so they understand your decisions. Why are you playing in a certain position? Why are you on the bench in a particular game? If this is all in order, then you have discipline and clarity. If the player knows where he stands, then it's also easier for him to be disciplined.

This is the age when influencing youth players' social behaviour and mentally starts. The player will develop a unique personality with his own ideas and is eager to work in his own way. Social norms and values within football are important. We talk about the conflicting interest between 'talent' and 'difficult'. The player who's most developed, who's most important in your team, who delivers the best performance when it comes to getting a result in the game, that's the player with 'talent'. 'Difficult' in this context means a disturbing social element. For instance, by not honouring agreements or by inflicting damage to the roles other players have within the team. What matters here is that each player with more or less talent should adhere to the agreements. If a player doesn't comply with the agreements on the pitch, then you can't win matches.

It is becoming more apparent that players that have the mentality to play the game have the best odds of succeeding in football. These kids have, by trial and error, shown to be able to fulfil the agreements that are asked of them.

Guidance

When guiding 13/14/15 year old talents it is important that you treat everyone equally, especially when dealing with disappointments. The 'top talent' of this crop will be there eventually anyway. What really matters is the work with players that still have some margin in their development, but who often can't function optimally due to other conditions. The top talent need others to reach the ultimate goal. Often the bar gets set higher for that extremely talented player by putting him in an older age group.

A strong decisive factor in the development process of a youth player is the parents. The chance of succeeding is generally higher if the parents of a player stay in the background and support their child without pushing them too much. It's often counterproductive if the child gets pushed too much by their parents. The family situation can also be decisive. The number of broken families is high these days. These players only get little or no support at all from home. For these players in particular, a social role is reserved for the coach.

CHAPTER 2

TRAINING / COACHING

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Training / Coaching

- More targeted training on the tasks and roles of players.
- More training on the tactical aspect and technical training has to become mainly functional.

From this age (U14-15 level) we focus our training more on the tasks and roles of the players, based on the four main moments in football. To teach juniors how to recognise football-specific situations quicker, it's important to provide a direction in the practice.

A 5 v 3 possession game isn't devised purely to pass the ball around, but to align the practice immediately by using formations. For instance, 'imagine' four defenders and a midfielder against three attackers - the two centre backs could learn how to push forward. By challenging the players to find solutions, they have to focus continuously. The players shouldn't only be aware of what their tasks and roles are, but also those of their teammates. This allows them to solve football-specific situations faster and they also learn how to read the opposition's game.

As a coach you should never criticise a solution from a player, but instead offer him an even better solution. At this age sometimes they are very sensitive to criticism, causing them to hide next time and show little initiative in future. Therefore, try not to pause the training sessions too often to correct the players. An additional problem which can occur from this is that the concentration levels quickly drop. Juniors recognise situations quite fast, so supported coaching or coming back to it later is sufficient. In advance of the training session, announce what the football problem is. The remarks of the coach during training will then be recognised sooner. A player has to think about what he's doing:

- Why does he have to make the pitch smaller by pushing inside?
- Why does he have to make a preliminary action?

The coach makes this happen by allowing the initiative to come from the players themselves during

training and the match discussion. You have to pause the situation at the moment it has gone wrong, then they will remember that moment better and be less inclined to make that same mistake again in the future. To keep the training sessions organised, they train with a problem definition. During the match many things will go wrong. What went wrong during the match is very familiar for the players. This is what the coach bases a training session on, and the situation from the match will be simulated by using practices in which the players slowly attempt to find the solution to the problem.

Stability Exercises

The warm-up of training sessions at the start of the week is the perfect time to perform stability exercises with the players. This mainly involves muscles where players get most of their power from, i.e. Pelvic girdle/hip muscles. You can do this with certain exercises with or without the ball. For example, two players give each other a hand and one of them has to shield the ball, while the other attempts to steal it. Alternatively, a pair have to push or pull each other over a line; here you can think of the defender sitting low, one foot in front and one foot behind.

Tactics

We have to start developing the players tactically. Our training should now be much more focused on the tactical aspect, and technical training should be primarily functional. Small sided games offer the best learning moments in relation to technique. The players immediately have to deal with full resistance, forcing them to have good ball reception and to turn correctly. This way they can run up against the ball directly and control or pass in tight areas. During small sided games it's better to use a 6 v 5 rather than 9 v 9. This makes it clearer and less crowded. With fewer players on the pitch, it then also becomes less difficult to touch upon a specific subject. If you're working on defending with one or a maximum of

two lines, then it is more ordered. Once the numbers increase, for example, the players would then also have to pay attention to the upcoming midfielders and full backs. Or it could be the case that the midfielders have already intercepted the ball, and the defenders don't have to take any action.

Practicing Technique

The players are at an age where the coach can expect them to react after the explanation. However, these players are eager to learn and prepared to go the extra mile for each other. It's true though that the physical and mental differences can be quite big. Technique has an essential importance. By using many passing and ball striking practices, the player can perfect his ball control. The next step is to play a possession game, starting with little resistance and making it increasingly difficult each time. We do this until there is no numerical advantage anymore and we can play a small sided game.

The speed at which a player can execute his move determines the operational speed of the player. An action could be a passing move, but also turning away from an opponent. The most important basis for training the operational speed is through positional play, whereby you can adjust the resistance levels if desired. The level of resistance determines how a player has to control the ball or process it any further.

Vision is necessary to perform certain actions. For instance, when a full back has to make the decision to push inside or to mark the opponent, then he must have the vision to make the right choice. The vision of a player is often a natural talent, but especially at this age it can still be developed with specific training. Here again, positional play is a good training method. It is essential that the coach guides the players and clearly explains what the purpose is. For example, when pushing inside, the coach announces where, when and how they should push inside to close down the space. Passing and ball striking is an important item when precise build-up football has to be played. By going through many of these types of practices, you improve the ball striking technique. You can then train on short, as well as long passes by varying the distances.

From the second year on in this age group, the increased focus in the football academy will be on the good (functional) use of technical skills in match-specific situations. The 'loose' technical skills have to be transformed into more functional 'match technique'. In addition to the regular group training sessions, there will be individual (technical) sessions planned to accelerate this learning process with talented players. This way the talented players in the football academy receive even more time and attention to targeted training and make certain specific technical skills their own. More training moments and lots of repetitions and ball touches simply produce results faster. The talent has to invest in himself with the support of professional youth coaches and challenging exercises. It often occurs that the youth players who develop the quickest are those that arrive earlier at the training centre. These are also good occasions to work with the players individually. Practice, practice and more practice! The individual training can certainly play a key role and helps in the following ways:

- Pure ball control.
- Feints and moves to beat defenders.
- Ability to use both feet for all technical actions.
- Finishing on goal.
- Specific football skills throughout the positions.

The Importance of Crossing

One of the regular subjects we present to the forwards is that the wingers have to be able to cross the ball to the strikers after good combination play. They need to have the strength to cover long distances and short sharp bursts. The players have to execute the technique with an increasing speed and resistance each time.

You give the wingers less and less time to think about a move, so it has to become automatic and that's a matter of repetition. The most important comments from a coach regarding the technique of a cross starts with the control of the ball. The player has to ensure that the ball goes forward. He should keep his foot above the ground, because then he can control the direction of the ball more easily. At the moment

he wants to kick the ball, his supporting leg has to be pointed towards the goal. This way he's already turned and his leg has an easier follow-up. The shoulder also has to turn, because then there is more power from the player's body used and the ball is struck with even more speed.

An example of the way in which we increase the difficulty level step by step:

- We first teach the players to cross a ball without pressure from an opponent. First use a stationary ball, followed by a rolling ball and a dribble.
- Introduce a defender to give some resistance. This starts with 50% pressure and gradually increases more and more.
- If the players are still capable of executing it well under this pressure, then we will link multiple techniques to each other. First, the player performs a preliminary action to get away from the opponent (checks away from marker before moving to receive) and then someone passes the ball to him. The player then needs to receive the ball so that he is facing forwards - he can then approach his opponent and try to beat him in a 1 v 1 situation before crossing.
- To make this even more difficult, we provide the defender with multiple ways to apply pressure so the forward has to pick from several solutions. Instead of controlling the ball, he can play a one-two combination and make a deep run to receive back and deliver a cross.

In the long term, there is more to it in regards to tactics. But the technical execution of the cross remains the basis of the training and development. One player might be further in this process than the other, so for the coach it is important to provide the individual with the right pressure to achieve the optimal learning result. This could occur by taking a step back regarding the methodology or by taking the player apart from the group and work on the cross individually.

Individuality

During specific training sessions, there is a lot of attention reserved for the individual. You will have a lot of one-on-one contact and you will learn to know the personality and motivation of each player. The discipline that the players need to have to continuously work on their weaknesses and to perfect their strengths is also a development of their mentality. This is important for the players, but in addition they should also pay more attention to each other. During some practices, a player has to 'adopt a supporting role for his teammate'. Then it's not about 'you' for a second, but about your teammate.

It's the job of the coach to keep this within borders. You can do this by switching the tasks within a practice in a timely manner or by giving both players the possibility to score.

Guided Coaching

Within the game concept, communication now becomes very important. It's the first step towards collaboration within a team, and carrying out the tasks in your position that are demanded within the game concept. As a coach, you're inclined to foretell everything to the kids. You strive for perfection too much. You then forget that a child learns just as much by making mistakes as by achieving success. The explanation of a practice can best take place by showing an example, by not telling each player what to do, but by executing the whole practice in slow motion. The players are 'do and watch kids' and not listeners. Guided coaching is therefore the keyword. Let them carry out the practice and guide one or two players as much as possible within the execution of the practice. A football problem will then be made visible within its task and position. If a practice is executed correctly a couple of times, then take a step back and observe whether the exercise is performed correctly without guiding them. If a player is able to learn this way, they will develop faster.

How to Train for Success

In addition to guided coaching, identifying success is essential for kids of this age. Therefore, every action that has been carried out correctly also has to be guided by the coach.

This way you create a climate where youth players accept it even if you criticise them as a coach. The players will only accept "You're not doing it right" if the successes of an action were rewarded repeatedly. This makes it loud and clearly audible to everyone. In other words, during coaching you penalise frequently, but you reward the players even more often. Regularly we ask the question, "Why do we say you're not doing it right?" - Then we expect the answer; "You're doing that to make us better players".

It has to be exciting for the players

The perception of the players is the foundation of each method. The way of training must encourage players.

Mainly match-specific practices

Match-specific practices are practices with real resistance (opponents, teammates, defined space) and form the basis in the learning process of young football players. However, isolated technical practices (passing, ball striking, ball control practices) are also essential. The key is to combine both with each other. When we ensure isolated technical practices are geared towards match-specific practices, then we can speed up the development process.

A limited number of practices per session

A youth coach shouldn't lose too much training time. If he opts for too many different practices, then this will be at the expense of the training time. Youth players need time to get used to a practice. Sometimes you only see a substantial return at the end of the practice.

It is better to repeat certain practices frequently. It is also best to reduce the number of practices used during training. The training time in a football club is often strictly defined (limited number of pitches, various training sessions after each other). When too many practices are used in a training session,

the yield disappears like snow in the sun. A training session should contain a maximum of 3 or 4 practices. Simple practices reach their essence sooner and guarantee more touches of the ball for each player.

The practices should be extended procedurally over a certain period of time

If we want to influence the development process in depth, then a process-driven build-up should be present. By gradually extending the practices through the training sessions, more time will be available for the substantive aspect. It's better to opt for practices that lend themselves to be extended over a certain period of time.

Starting each training session with new practices doesn't produce sufficient return. Each practice has to be repeated a number of times to offer a certain development effect.

The coach has to be able to easily increase or decrease the level of the practices

The level of the practice should be easy to modify. This can be achieved by:

- Altering the resistance; increasing number of teammates/opponents, amend the space, time etc.
- Altering the organisation (slightly).

The technical and tactical content has to be tailored for each age group

The technical approach of, for instance, 'the cross' looks different with 10 year old players compared to 18 year old players. For younger football players, the focus will be mainly on short crosses. The older players can move through this part completely and practice crossing from the sideline, for instance.

CHAPTER 3

TECHNICAL TRAINING

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Technical Training Methods

We should always place technical training in a broader context. It's not only about the technical skills. You could divide the methods in youth football into two large groups:

1. The players should learn how to pass, receive, dribble, feint and turn etc, in isolation during the first phase (without real resistance). The emphasis lies completely on the technique.
2. Another method focuses mainly on match-specific practices with real resistance (opponents, teammates, time, space, etc.).

What is the Right Method?

The key in the learning process of youth football players lies within a tuned combination of both of the methods above - each have their pros and cons. The bottom line is to link the benefits of one method with those of the other method. Individual training of technique has advantages including the number of touches the players get of the ball. Youth players are definitely in need of technical training. However, we need to describe the specific conditions to integrate the technical training accurately. The transition from more isolated technical practices (such as pass and move practices or practices with passing patterns) to practices which require vision and awareness is important and the ratio between both practices has to be fitted in with the right proportions.

There are two main concerns when training technique. The first; technique starts from the perspective of a match. The second; each player has his own football individuality. The use of technical skills in a football match always starts from the vision of the players. We must not lose sight of this. The observation and control throughout the brain during a match differs a lot from the control when training the technical skills in isolation. In practice, you'll notice that youth players will experience difficulties making the 'technical' translation from isolated practices to the match.

A practical example is a player with the ball at his feet. His direct opponent applies pressure on the ball. In the corner of his eye the player sees another teammate and an opponent. The player observes

the football situation and sends a signal to his brain. The brain makes a choice and immediately after, it sends signals to the muscles through the nerves. Subsequently, the muscles carry out the commands from the brain. When practicing this scenario during individual training, the control looks completely different. The player opts for an individual play. In this practical example, the player dribbles towards a cone and performs a feint in front of the cone. There is no insightful observation here. The control of the brain isn't based on an insightful football situation that requires vision. The player gets ordered to perform a certain move and subsequently executes this repeatedly. No vision or awareness comes into play here. The command from the brain only focuses on the execution of the technical skill.

But can't we train technical skills in isolation? Of course you can! Learning the technical skills without a direct opponent is a required element in the development of young football players. There are many moments in which we can offer practices without an opponent. One interesting way is to give the players homework exercises. However, in practice, this is insufficient on its own - the players are also in need of a coach who encourages them and corrects them within a game-like exercise, to improve their decision making.

In the initial phase of a practice, technique can be practiced perfectly without any opponent. As long as there is sufficient training time available for the practices with opponents and teammates, there is no problem as you can offer a progressive session where the resistance levels are increased throughout. Opposed practices should prevail during training!

Individual Qualities (Individuality)

Every football player has his own 'football individuality' and specific qualities for a particular position. The qualities that a player has are decisive for the way a player carries out his way of playing. Qualities such as tactical vision, mental strength, motor skills and speed provide the player with the talent for a certain position. Also characteristics such as the build of a player and physique help shape his 'player profile'.

This football individuality means that players aren't equally receptive to all skills. Certain technical skills are developed easier with some players, whilst others may find them more difficult. There are good practical examples to show this:

1. A player with less pace/speed will often have more difficulty beating an opponent in a frontal 1 v 1, thus when training the frontal 1 v 1 duel he will be less receptive to it.
2. A 'running player' (a dynamic player who is comfortable running with the ball at his feet) will be easier to train in skills that are useful for this particular attribute or these related actions, compared to his receptiveness when it comes to training a long pass for example.

The football individuality also ensures that players are fit for a certain position. One player might be more suitable as a midfielder, whilst the other is better off being a winger. Around a certain age (12-14 years) it more or less becomes clear what position a player is eligible for. Every player should get the chance to develop his 'own' creative added value, which is focused on his own football individuality and position. In practice, this doesn't mean we're only giving them attacking impulses, but we're also offering them the skills that are useful within several lines and positions. It's basically customised technical training. Do we pin down youth players from an early age to a particular position and the corresponding technical skills then? Of course not!

During the learning process of a youth football player, we go from general to very specific. At the younger ages (U-9, U-11 and U-13) it's about the technical skills of the various positions, and the different skills that apply to defenders, midfielders and forwards are addressed. From age 12/13 to 14 the football individuality of a player more or less becomes clear and the specialisation process slowly takes off. Then, more specific technical skills for their own position are offered.

Vision

You can't detach technique from vision. Technical training is still too often seen as a separate part. It's not only about a poor technical execution in a match - it's always about a combination of vision and technique. The focus is usually weighted

heavily on the isolated training of technical skills. That's not where the solution to the problem lies. Recognising situations and being able to revert to the right technique - this is what the starting point should be. When training technique, you start the game. It's about the game intentions. For example, when building up from the back, it's necessary to play the forward pass as soon as possible or search for the open player. During the match, the players will be confronted with teammates and opponents. With movements alone, you will not get there in a football game. Moving away from your marker (into space) and the way in which you make yourself available (check away before moving to receive) are often decisive. The same goes for details such as the way you pass or receive the ball. A player can play a pass to retain possession, hold on to it until more teammates are available or play a first time direct pass to try and create an opportunity.

Simply teaching players some 'moves' exclusively is too short-sighted and does not portray a true image of the game. Technical training needs to include practical, functional scenarios that replicate competitive match play with active opponents.

Individual Development

Fundamental technical actions such as a good forward pass, opening up to receive on the half turn, beating an opponent in a 1 v 1 duel etc - these are all stimulated too little. Because of this, you get 'one-size-fits-all' players and too few players actually stand out! - Youth football is too much like an individual sport.

We still have a long way to go in the process of individually developing our own talented players. The aim is to depart from the individuality of the player, to encourage them and to address the key areas of attention. For example, you need to start working with your striker to receive the ball in deep areas. If he struggles with receiving the ball with his back to goal, then he should be encouraged and developed, even if the result of the team suffers in the short term. That's what you call developing players individually!

Training Game Intentions

In youth football, we have to start by teaching the game intentions. For instance, when training build-up play from the back, you dedicate a couple of weeks to this game intention, laying a particular development foundation where all technical and tactical focal points of the build-up are offered, focused on the entire individual development of the players. The coach can then focus easily on the objectives and the common thread. When training football-specific problems in relation to the match, it is common to see that less important aspects get trained constantly, but in the meantime the important development moments, typical for this age group, are overlooked. Too often the training of a football-specific problem revolves around the result. You must pay more attention to training the game intentions. It's easier to follow certain age-specific objectives within a certain style of play when you only judge yourself by the problems relating to the match. Only once the players have a sufficient foundation and have mastered 11 v 11 play, is it interesting to analyse football-specific problems and address things specifically. Offering targeted technical and tactical training year after year ensures more depth in their development.

In practice, you often see drills/practices that are too far removed from the match. There are no positions, the direction of play is unclear and where the practice

is trained isn't related to the match-specific situation. These practices aren't recognisable enough.

Importance of Combining Technical & Tactical Training

Training youth players within an 11 v 11 setting must have a clear relation to the game system and the team's specific style of play. There is a big difference between the style of play of adults and that of kids - training the style of play with adults is more focused on defining tasks and functions in support of the result and style of play training in youth football means stimulating all technical and tactical aspects in relation to the individual development of the players.

In addition to developing all aspects of the style of play, it's also essential to offer supportive technical training. A coach, who starts with training build-up play on Monday, could for instance offer a training session on Wednesday, where several technical skills from the build-up are offered. This allows the players to develop their technique for build-up play in much more depth and also ensures an easier translation of the skills to the style of play. 'Training youth players in 11 v 11 is mainly style of play training, supported with technical training'. Offering training regarding the style of play and functional technique gives the players many learning moments. Furthermore, the coach should make sure that there is enough balance - freedom of movement and experience are also an important motivation for youth players. Also a nice tournament practice or a challenging finishing practice has a huge impact!

You don't just develop technique by training the technique specifically. When offering technical practices, two aspects often get overlooked:

1. **The functional training of technique.**
2. **Translating technical skills to the match.**

The coach spends hours and hours on repeating movements, but often you barely see the results during the match. Techniques are often trained without a purpose, but more like motor therapy! Teaching movements and technical skills is an interesting topic for the younger players (7-9 year

olds), but once a certain motor level has been reached, it's mainly about the functional translation of the skills to the match. Too often players have to practice skills that have no relevance to their technical, tactical or physical abilities. A small agile player makes use of other skills compared to a bigger, stronger player. The coaches first have to analyse the individual skills of the players, then they can move forward with this knowledge. In practice, attention often only gets paid to the skills that the coach wants to offer and not the skills that a player possesses or the abilities he has. For example, a player with an efficient scissor move to beat a defender, should be further encouraged to perfect this movement!

Making the Difference

Skills that make a player a world-class football player become clear during the 1 v 1 duel. Every good player will have good conditioning (including speed), technical skills (under pressure from the opposing side), tactical vision (making the right decisions) and a good mentality (personality, attitude). A world-class football player will however, stand out even more with his technical dominance. Then we are specifically talking about the technical moves, which top players use to make the difference in a match.

A coach should highlight the right focal points at the right time within the different age groups. If you have a team of players that require a lot of structure, but you give them complete freedom, then it will most likely end up in a big mess. However, a group with extensive experience at a high level could be given a bit more freedom. Better coaches could also distinguish between the various types of leadership styles within the group. Training specific tasks might be the interest of one player, while another player benefits more from allowing creativity. This is the so-called instinctive feeling of the coach - not too difficult, nor too easy. It's important that the players have sufficient experiences of success. Then the self-confidence and the personality of the player grows, which makes it more likely that he dares to take the initiative.

Progressive Training Sessions

Translating the match-specific situations to the training session and match needs to happen very accurately. By employing several steps and incorporating the order of these steps carefully into

each other, the step-by-step progressive session arises. Within isolated training of technique, the foundation is the feeling for the ball (control of the ball). It is important to be practicing with both feet and with many repetitions. Next, attention gets paid to passing accurately and receiving the ball correctly.

1 v 1 Duels / 4 v 4 Small Sided Games

For the youngest players, the ball alone is already sufficient resistance in the early development stages. Training the technical skills is a necessity to be able to dominate the 1 v 1 duel and eventually within full match play (11 v 11) once they are older. From this point, increasing the resistance is very important. Small sided games (4 v 4) is an excellent way to train this age group. Again, it's nothing more than a tool. In the several organisational practices, you can highlight various focal points with big goals, where they can finish a lot. With these games, plenty of cutting and turning movements, and short passes occur. Alternatively, you can play in lines to encourage the 1 v 1 duel. As a coach you have several tools, an armoury of practices, at your disposal. This may involve individual training, group training or small sided games.

The basic principle is the match, 11 v 11, containing the technical, tactical, physical and mental elements, which should all be taken into account when it comes to the development players. It really depends on the player or the group, their age and level. Whatever the practice is that you have picked, you can decide to work with a lot of structure or choose to give the players lots of freedom. If you want to be assured of many repetitions, then a fixed template could do the trick. At that time this calls for a more authoritarian style. In contrast you can have a more relaxed style as a coach and make use of Q&A. Alternatively, you can apply both approaches in different training sessions.

With high level players, it's best to first start without resistance. You should be suggesting movements and observing whether it's something for them. If not, then you should discard these, which is no problem since the move doesn't fit to this player. Subsequently, you focus on the movements, which do fit to the player. Very soon the passing of the ball is included, so the player first controls or rebounds the ball. After this, you demand more when it comes to the pace and you make the translation to their actual position on the pitch.

PROGRESSIVE TRAINING SESSION EXAMPLE

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Progressive Training Session Example: Building Up Play with the Full Backs

It's clear that building up play is only one part of the game, but this is our focus for this example session. The position of full back plays a key role here, which often includes contesting an opponent 'frontally'. You can make up all types of variations, including different positions, different movements and opponents applying pressure from all sides.

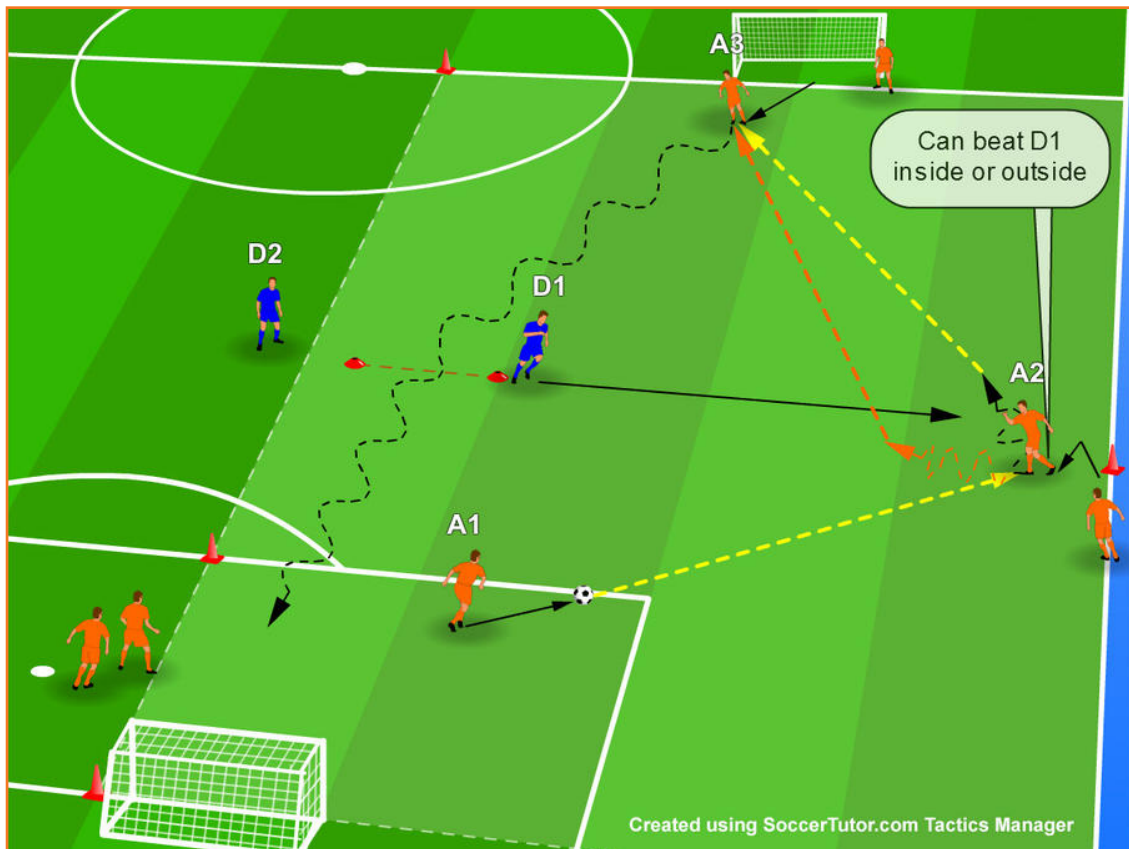
In a small sided game, you will notice which actions the players carry out during the build-up with the ball, as well as without it. It is known that it then comes to key elements such as receiving the ball, feints, passing, rebounding the ball etc. However, we must also focus on the preliminary action - accelerating and moving into space.

What conditions do we have to create now to train all these actions?

We don't only have to train the technique, but all actions. The main purpose then is training the efficiency and not the 'style'. The technique is only a tool and can't become an end on itself. Furthermore, there must be a relation with the game intention, which is scoring goals. During the practice, you have to consider the right place on the pitch, the right direction, depth in the game and a relation with the relevant position.

Within these conditions, you have to train the mentioned actions. However, there is still room for offering a passing move as a practice. First we have some passive resistance from a defender because the player with the ball still has to make decisions quickly. You can start with a big distance in front of the defender, so the player with the ball has more time. At every level we can start this way. The resistance gets increased gradually during training. On the following pages we present a progressive session to work on the full backs' role in building up play from the back.

Building Up Play with the Full Back (Step 1): Functional Training



Objective: We use functional training to work on building up play from the back via the full back.

Description

Using 1/4 of a full pitch, we play in a continuous sequence with at least 2 players in each position.

1. Player A1 (centre back) places the ball on the edge of the penalty area and stands 1-2 yards away.
2. To start the practice Player A1 'picks up' the ball by means of a preliminary action e.g. using the bottom of his foot to roll the ball towards himself and to open up to the side.
3. Player A passes the ball to the position of the right back (A2). A defender (D1) moves to press at that moment. The right back (A2) passes to A3 right away or can go outside or inside with the ball to beat his opponent. If the right back beats the defender, he then passes to A3 (midfielder).
4. A3 stays in an advanced position, controls the ball and dribbles through the gate and to the start (A1).
5. A1 moves to the A2 position / A2 moves to the A3 position and the sequence continues with the next player.

This is a progressive practice, so we can adapt the instructions we give to the players and/or the rules to increase the difficulty. These variations are detailed on the next page...

Variations

1. Instruct the defender (D1) to be passive.
2. Vary the speed at which the defender approaches the right back to increase/decrease the difficulty.
3. Vary the distance the defender starts the approach to close down the full back.
4. Show various moves to beat defenders and let the 'full back' practice them to beat the defender on the outside.
5. The full back has to beat the defender on the inside or outside with a specific move e.g. feint and cut.
6. The defender (D1) is fully active and tries to win the ball. If he is successful, he can then score in either of the 2 goals. A1 defends one goal and A3 defends the other.

Coaching Points

Make sure that the focus is also on vision and awareness, not just the technical execution:
When do you have to pass? When is it better to go alone?

Centre Back (A1):

- 'Pass the ball in front of the right back.'
- 'Play it hard and accurately.'
- 'Pass it sharply.'

Full Back (A2):

- 'Move away from the line.'
- 'Check away from the cone before moving to receive.'
- 'Receive in motion with the ball.'

Midfielder (A3):

- 'Stay up there.'
- 'Receive in motion with the ball.'

Dutch Academy Football Coaching (U14-15)

Building Up Play with the Full Back (Step 3): Small Sided Game (3 v 3 + GKs)



Objective: We use a 3 v 3 (+GKs) small sided game to work on building up play from the back via the full back.

Description

In this progression of the last practice, we add another defender (D3), so now each orange player has a direct opponent to close them down. The practice starts with the goalkeeper's pass to the centre back (A1).

The orange team build up play through the full back (A2) and try to combine and score in a 3 v 3 situation. They must now focus on getting past their direct opponent - with a pass or by running with the ball.

The blue team contest their direct opponents. D2 moves from the side to contest the centre back (A1), D1 does the same as the previous 2 practices by moving to close down the full back (A2) and D3 is positioned behind the midfielder (A3).

The blue team try to win the ball - if they are successful, they then try to score in the other goal. When an attack is finished or the ball goes out of play, start again with the orange team's goalkeeper.

Coaching Points

1. Encourage the players to only build up play from the back via the full back (A2).
2. Keep encouraging the players to get past their opponent (not exclusively by dribbling).

Building Up Play with the Full Back (Step 4): 6 (+GK) v 4 Positional Play



Objective: We use fully competitive 2 v 1 / 2 v 2 play to work on building up play from the back via the full back.

Description

Using half a pitch, we practice building up play from the back.

The orange team have a goalkeeper, 1 centre back (4), 2 full backs (2 & 3) and 3 central midfielders (6, 8 & 10). Their aim is to build up play from the back (focusing on playing through the full backs) and trying to score in one of the small goals on the halfway line.

The blue team have 1 striker (9), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 2 central midfielders (6 & 8). Their aim is to press their opponents and disrupt their build up play - trying to win the ball and then score in the goal past the goalkeeper.

When an attack is finished or the ball goes out of play, start again with the orange team's goalkeeper.

Coaching Points

1. Encourage the players only to build up from the back (no long passes).
2. Keenly observe the players' decision making and coach them throughout.
3. Make sure the players build up play through the full backs.
4. Keep encouraging the players to get past their opponent (not exclusively by passing).
5. Also encourage the players to try and create space by switching the play from one full back to the other (using the full width of the pitch).

PROGRESSIVE TRAINING FOR 1 V 1 DUELS

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Progressive Training for 1 v 1 Duels

Attitude

Attitude is key to the conviction of the player at the moment an action is carried out. For a part this is natural, but certainly it is open for improvement as well. The better a player masters his moves to beat an opponent, the more self-confidence he will have. He needs to promote this in everything he does.

Position

The decision and action the player takes depends on the position of himself, the ball, his opponents and his teammates. Based on all these aspects the player must set up 'a plan'. This plan has to be created within a split second.

First Touch

If the ball gets played to you, the first touch has to be good. Otherwise it will be difficult or impossible to make a good individual play i.e. beat the defender.

Direction of Play - Decision Making

As soon as the player has full control of the ball, he needs to make a choice - What direction will he go?

Will he attack the opponent (with the ball immediately or is he going to benefit from the space he gets instead?

The space, the distance to the goal and movements which the player is capable of performing, are aspects that are decisive. For instance, if you're within 'shooting range', feint to shift the ball to your weaker foot and then make a quick movement to your strong foot to finish and score.

Controlling the Pace/Tempo

As a forward, your job is to dictate the pace. Don't leave this up to the defender. You should have the initiative and maintain it throughout.

This doesn't always necessarily mean that you have to run with the ball. It could also entail a quick movement, followed by an explosive run into space. This type of player receives the ball in the most unexpected areas of the pitch.

Movement

During the action, you have to have the technique to combat all situations. The opponent could be right beside you or approaching you from an angle. He could also be behind you or perhaps you might even confront him 'frontally'.

The more and better you can practice performing all the different types of moves to beat defenders e.g. the cut, the scissor, side step etc, the more options you have for each different situation and the less predictable you become. Your opponent knows this and you will also be more convinced of it every time. Those are the moments when your conviction on the pitch increases.

Final/End Product

You don't perform a move to beat a defender just for the sake of the move, but rather with a certain goal in mind. Ultimately, goals have to be scored. The decision has to be made in the moment for that specific situation:

- If you are in a central position in a 1 v 1, can you create space and shoot?
- If you are tightly marked, do you pass the ball first time and then move into space to receive back?
- If you are out wide, can you beat the defender on the inside or outside to create space for a cross?
- If you have limited space and are marked tightly, do you force a free kick, corner or penalty?

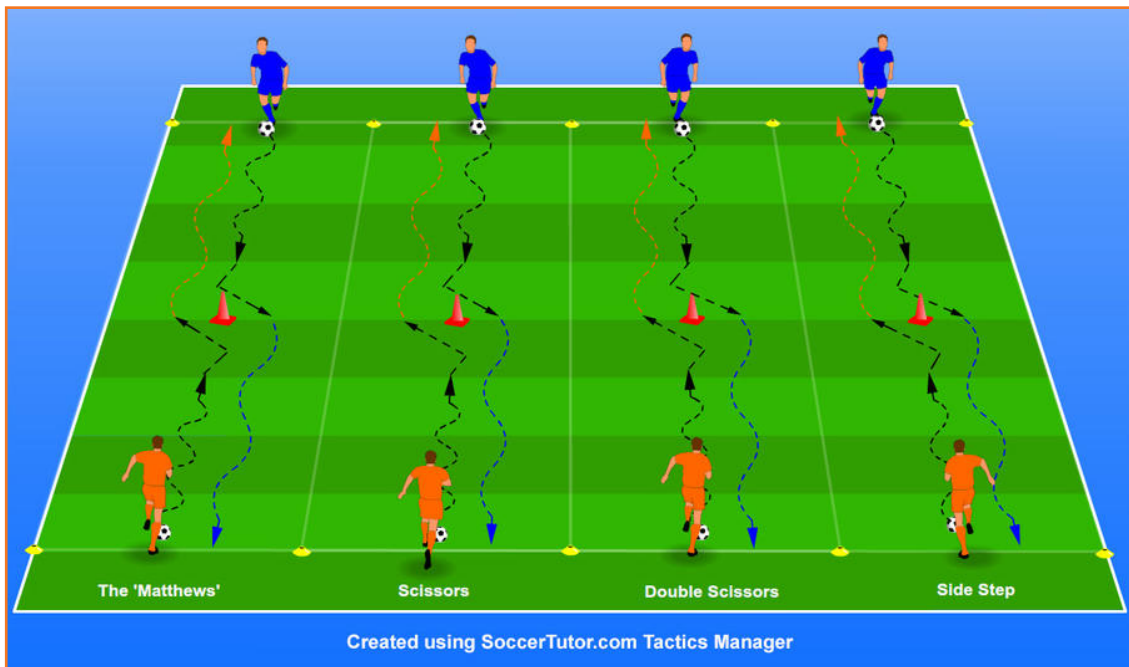
Tips for Technical Training (U14-15)

1. In every practice, the coach can adjust the level of difficulty. By doing so, he can make the practices easier or more difficult during each training session.
2. The coach can mutually change the order of the practices. He could opt for starting a training session with a vision and awareness practice which allows the players to make decisions freely. This would provide them with the chance to come to learn themselves before the more structured training.
3. By mixing the practices up, such as with and without an opponent, the translation to the match is stimulated in a positive way.
4. It's essential that you give the players homework. They could for instance practice 5 turning movements (in pairs or against a wall) at home. During training, the coach can then immediately start with some functional practices.

Training should comply with the following requirements:

- The technical skills we train should have a relation to the style of play.
- The main focus should be a match-specific situation and not on just technique or movement.
- The trained skills must be useful for competitive matches.
- The skills should have an added value for the players and a forceful nature.
- Technical skills should be part of the 'toolbox' of the forwards, midfielders and defenders.
- It's not only about the actions with the ball but also without the ball.
- The practice has to be orientated with the correct direction of play.
- If possible, the practice has to take place in the right area of the pitch.
- There should be positions.
- There should be a step-by-step plan.
- There should be a transition to the match.
- The technical skills should be offered under varying conditions.

Moves to Beat a Defender (1 v 1) with the Opponent in Front



Objective: We work on mastering 4 different moves to beat defenders with the opponent in front.

Description

We mark out 4 channels (2 x 6 yards each) with a cone in the middle and we have 4 pairs working at once.

Each player has a ball, moves forward towards the cone and then performs a move to beat a defender towards the right. Finally, they run with the ball to the end. The players then repeat the same in the opposite direction.

You cone is used to give the players a feeling for the distance during the movement - where to start the movement and where to end up.

We practice 4 different moves to beat a defender:

1. The 'Matthews': Feint to go one way with the inside of the foot and then take it away in the other direction with the outside of the same foot.
2. Scissors: Step over the ball with one foot to feint to go one way and then use the outside of your other foot to take it in the opposite direction.
3. Double Scissors: Step over the ball twice e.g. left, then right foot, before then taking the ball away with the outside of the left foot.
4. Side Step: Step behind the ball (diagonally sideways) and drop the shoulder to feint to go one way and then use the outside of the other foot to take the ball in the opposite direction.

Variation: Have 1 ball for each pair and remove the middle cone. The players alternate between being the defender (passive) and the attacker. Confront your teammate and perform the specific move (e.g. The 'Matthews' at the right time.

Coaching Points

1. The coach first demonstrates how to perform the 4 different moves to beat defenders front on or he can nominate a player to do this.
2. Keep increasing your demands from the players - higher pace, more explosive post-action, increase the distance, combination 2 of the moves together.
3. Make sure to go in different directions, or else you'll clash.
4. 'Perform the movement with conviction!
5. 'Be confident in yourself. You will improve if you keep practising.'
6. 'Make sure you're explosive to take the ball away after the movement.'
7. 'Drop your shoulder, bend your knees. Right, left, right and gone!'
8. 'Finish the movement correctly. Yes!'

Moves to Beat a Defender (1 v 1) at Different Angles in a Continuous Practice



Objective: We work on mastering moves to beat defenders at different angles.

Description

We mark out 4 channels, approximately 5 x 15 yards (depending on the age/level of the players). We start with 4 orange attackers (each with a ball) who are facing 4 blue defenders. There are also 3 additional defenders (D2, D4 & D6) who start next to the attackers and the rest of the orange players wait at position A1 with a ball.

All 4 orange attackers play a 1-2 combination with the defender, receive back and then confront their opponent, perform a move to beat the defender and dribble to the end. The blue defender moves forward to apply pressure but is passive, so runs back with the attacker after his move so that he is forced to retain a high pace.

After getting around the first opponent, the attacker then dribbles the ball diagonally in the opposite direction to confront the next opponent e.g. after beating D1, A1 then confronts D2 who moves forward. This is a continuous sequence as shown - the orange attackers move through the channels and the blue defenders retain their positions. When an orange attacker gets to the end (after beating D7), he moves to the A1 start position.

Increase the resistance of the defenders gradually throughout to make the practice more competitive.

Coaching Points

1. Ensure you approach the defender from a different angle each time.
2. Keep the ball close to your feet when dribbling. Tick, tick, tick and then at the right moment you make the move you've planned to beat the defender.
3. The move to beat the defender has to include a feint to go one way before changing direction.
4. Once you've started your move, then there is no turning back. You must then keep a high pace.

Receive, Dribble & Beat a Defender on the Flank in a Passing Combination Practice



Objective: To improve long passing, the first touch of the winger and beating a defender in a 1 v 1 duel.

Description

In the area shown, we have 2 central midfielders (6 & 8), 1 attacking midfielder (10), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). We also have 6 mannequins to act as obstacles/defenders for when the winger receives.

The practice starts with No. 6 who passes to No. 8. No. 8 then plays a long pass to switch the play to the left winger (11) who must control the ball well and be instantly ready to dribble forwards. He practices his moves to beat defenders e.g. cut, step over etc. The striker (9) checks away from the cone and the winger passes to him. The No. 10 does the same, receives the next pass and passes back to the start position.

Run the practice on both sides. No. 6 plays a long pass to the right winger (7). You can have an extra winger on each side as shown and the players take turns.

Variations

1. Players are not in fixed positions, but instead, let them rotate (move to next position after each sequence).
2. The winger who's 'resting', could also function as a (passive) defender.
3. Add a goalkeeper. The winger crosses the ball into the penalty area and the No. 10 and striker (9) make runs into the penalty area to finish.

Passing, Receiving, 1 v 1 and Finishing in and Around the Penalty Area



Objectives

To improve quick passing around the penalty area, attacking in 1 v 1 duels and finishing on goal.

Description

In this practice we mark out a box (8 x 8 yards) with 1 blue defender inside. We also have a goalkeeper and 6 orange attackers. 5 orange players start in the positions shown (A to E) with 1 waiting on the other side.

The practice starts when A passes the ball to C. Player B acts as a defender and moves to apply pressure - C receives and turns to drag/take the ball away from B and pass to Player D in the centre.

Player D passes to E who must then enter the 8 x 8 yard zone with the ball, beat the defender in a 1 v 1 duel and then try to score past the goalkeeper.

The defender is 100% competitive and tries to win the ball. He remains the defender until he wins the ball. When he does win the ball, he moves to position A (the player who lost the ball becomes the defender).

Alternate playing on the left and right side - just mirror the same positions.

Variations

1. Increase the size of the defender's area to make it more difficult for the attacker and reduce the size of it to make it easier.
2. A plays a 1-2 combination with C under pressure from B and then passes to D.

Winning a 1 v 1 Duel in the Centre and Finishing on Goal



Objective: To improve attacking in 1 v 1 duels with an opponent in front and finishing on goal.

Description

Using half a pitch, we have 1 large goal with a goalkeeper at one end with 2 blue defenders either side. We also have 2 small goals on the halfway line along with 4 orange attackers in the positions shown.

The practice starts when a defender plays a long pass to an orange winger and he passes to one of two teammates in the centre. The attacker who receives the pass confronts the defender and tries to score. If the defender wins the ball, they can either try to score in a small goal (1 v 1) or pass back to the goalkeeper.

The first pass should alternate between the left and right side. The defenders take turns and the attackers rotate positions. Keep track of the score for every 4 balls to see if the defenders or attackers win each mini game.

Coaching Points

1. Call for the ball aggressively and full of conviction. The one who passes the ball to you shouldn't be hesitating about where you want to receive the ball. The answer is always "right here!"
2. Receive so you take the ball with you in a forward direction. You want to score as soon as possible. Know what you want to do - for the defender it will be a surprise.
3. Call for the ball everywhere. Don't limit yourself each time to the same direction. If a pass isn't accurate, then use your creativity and solve the new situation quickly.

Winning a 1 v 1 Duel on the Side and Finishing on Goal



Objective

To improve attacking in 1 v 1 duels from the wing, with an opponent in front and finishing on goal.

Description

This is a variation of the previous practice. We now have 1 defender on each side of the goal and a third on the edge of the penalty area.

The defender who plays the first pass now has a choice:

1. Pass directly towards a winger on the halfway line and then move forward to defend in a 1 v 1 situation. The extra defender on the edge of the penalty area does not take part.
2. Pass to the defender on the edge of the penalty area. He then passes to an orange attacker who receives and passes out wide to a winger. The winger then faces the defender on the edge of the penalty area in a 1 v 1.

In both situations, there is a 1 v 1 situation. The winger who receives the pass confronts the defender and tries to score. If the defender wins the ball, they can either try to score in a small goal (1 v 1) or pass back to the goalkeeper.

4 V 4 SMALL SIDED GAMES

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4 v 4 Small Sided Games

Many world class players gain their basic skills by playing football on the streets when they're children. With 4 v 4 small sided games, you can simulate street football. Small sided games are perfectly suitable to apply all sorts of technical moves. The 4 v 4 game offers the following benefits for the players:

- Many touches for every player.
- A clear-cut game situation, which is suitable for learning and applying technical movements.
- A continuous alternation between attacking and defending.
- An attractive and motivating environment, which inspires the players to be creative.

You have to organise the small sided games in such a way that players will get sufficient experiences of success regarding the aspects you would like to train.

By making a simple adjustment in the organisation or rules, you can easily influence this as a coach. Here are some examples to change the dynamics of small sided games:

1. Individual Play with Dribbling End Zones (Page 46):

Mark out 2 end zones and the teams score by dribbling into it. This encourages the players to use technical movements to beat their opponents in 1 v 1 situations.

2. Shooting and Finishing with 2 Goals +GKs (Page 47):

We play with 2 large goals and goalkeepers within a small area. This encourages the players to shoot often, so they are constantly practicing their finishing.

3. Passing and Possession with 4 Goals (Page 48):

Set up a rule whereby a team can only score after completing 5 consecutive passes. While individual plays were the norm at first, now it suddenly becomes a 'passing game'.

The principles that are learnt within 4 v 4 small sided games are also of great importance to football at the highest level. For example, you often see a team that doesn't have possession shift in a very disciplined manner towards one side of the pitch. The solution for the team in possession is often for a player, with one movement, such as a change of direction or a cross pass, to shift the game at once. These fundamental ideas can start to be taught in these 4 v 4 small sided games.

4 v 4 Small Sided Game (1): Individual Play with Dribbling End Zones



Objective: To improve individual play - dribbling and moves to beat defenders in 1 v 1 duels.

Description

Using a 20 x 35 yard area, we mark out two 5 yard zones and play a 4 v 4 small sided game.

The practice starts with one player who passes to a teammate from the end zone and then moves into the middle zone. We then have a 4 v 4 situation within the 20 x 25 yard middle zone. The aim is to use individual play, beating opponents in 1 v 1 situations to dribble past them and into the end zone to score.

If the ball goes out of play, then start again with one player passing from the end zone. If a team scores they move back towards their goal line, and play starts again with the team that conceded.

Make sure to play in short intervals as these games are intense and the players need sufficient rest.

Variations

1. You can play 3 v 3 or 5 v 5.
2. You can simply have lines to dribble across instead of end zones.
3. Apply a time limit for the attacking team to score - if the time elapses they give possession to their opponents.

4 v 4 Small Sided Game (2): Shooting and Finishing with 2 Goals + GKs



Objective: To improve shooting and finishing under pressure of time and space.

Description

In this variation of the previous practice we use the same area (20 x 35 yards) but we remove the end zones and replace them with 2 large goals and goalkeepers. The practice starts with one of the goalkeepers and the aim now is to score in the goals.

If the ball goes out of play, then start again with the goalkeeper. If a team scores they move back towards their goal, and play starts again with the team that conceded.

Make sure to play in short intervals as these games are intense and the players need sufficient rest.

Variations

1. You can play 3 v 3 or 5 v 5.
2. Apply a time limit for the attacking team to score - if the time elapses they give possession to their opponents.

4 v 4 Small Sided Game (3): Passing and Possession with 4 Goals



Objective: To improve passing, receiving, movement and combination play within a small sided game.

Description

In this 4 v 4 small sided game we use a 40 (width of side with goals) x 25 yard area and have 4 mini goals in the positions shown.

The practice starts with one of the players from the end-line and he passes to a teammate. The teams play a normal directional 4 v 4 game, but they must complete 5 consecutive passes before they are allowed to score in one of the 2 small goals.

If the ball goes out of play, then start again with a player from the end-line. If a team scores they move back towards their goal, and play starts again with the team that conceded.

Make sure to play in short intervals as these games are intense and the players need sufficient rest.

Variations

1. You can play 3 v 3 or 5 v 5.
2. Apply a time limit for the attacking team to score - if the time elapses they give possession to their opponents.

CHAPTER 4

THE MATCH: POSITIONAL ROLES AND REQUIREMENTS

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The Match

From the Under 14/15 level we let the players play in their best positions, so they can develop themselves to the optimum level. Thus a centre back will almost no longer get into a position where he has to deliver a cross, but he will get in positions where he has to give a cross-field pass to the winger.

For each position on the pitch, a few different technical and tactical basic skills apply. Each player gets assessed as to whether he possesses these skills and what his strengths and areas of improvement are. We certainly don't forget about the strengths, because this is the specific force of a player and he needs to further expand this. These are the positions in our 4-3-3 system:

- 1 x Goalkeeper
- 2 x Full backs
- 2 x Centre backs
- 2 x Central midfielders
- 1 x Attacking midfielder
- 2 x Wingers
- 1 x Striker

If you train the technique, it has to be functional with a focus on the specific position. Furthermore, it's important that as many match-specific situations get trained as possible, whereby a player plays in his best position as much as possible. With smaller groups, you're able to train in a more focused way. The advantage is that you can link technical skills to tactics. The recognition will be much bigger, which causes the return in a match to be significantly higher. As a coach, you have to capitalise on this by creating situations where players have sufficient learning moments with technique and tactics combined in one single practice.

Vision and Awareness

Teaching kids tactical vision is one of the most difficult things. Some see 'it' a bit, while others don't. For a large part vision is an instinctive matter;

feeling for the space, situation, ball, teammates and opponents. This can be improved by training a lot, with many possession games and small-sided games. It's good for players to hear instructions at the right times e.g. when they have to take a little step to the left or the right, accompanied with an explanation as to why it's better. Subsequently, they need to be reminded of it often during similar situations that follow. Here as a coach, it's important you practice situational coaching. A player has to be reminded during the situation of his lack of vision at that very moment. Then the following coaching points will arise: ***'Stop, now you're already standing there. You had to stay away longer and run up towards the ball only now!'***

In the following situation, you try to be ahead of the moment in the coaching: ***'Stay away, stay away and now you come!'*** Again the next step is that the player recognises the situation himself and acts correctly in a tactical sense. If this happens, then obviously this has to be rewarded enthusiastically.

Using Tactics Boards

You often hear from the side "He's not seeing it..." That is often a conclusion in retrospect, but how can you be ahead of this and enable him to see it now? As a coach, of course everything depends on whether you see it or not.

The process of transferring and teaching is difficult and requires a lot of time, effort and repetitions. To support the players, the coach can choose to work with a tactics board during the match discussions. Depending on the cognitive level of the kids you work with, you can provide a lot of clarity and benefit from visualising certain aspects.

Here again, the art is to keep it as simple and clear as possible (one or two main aspects each time). If you have a piece of paper full of arrows and lines, then the players will not make much progress. Let them actively think about it and come forward with

possible solutions as well. Ultimately, the goal is to make them understand it. Reserve some time for this, maybe even before training.

The Transition Phases

As a coach, you will notice that the players will experience quite a few problems with the transition from defence to attack and more so the transition from attack to defence. Often, this is a mental issue, which fits to the age group of 13-15 year olds. Players think about a missed opportunity or an action for too long. Making them aware of these moments has an important place during the training sessions, in addition to training the technical skills. The 4-3-3 player positioning system is ideal for them. They can easily get into the necessary organisation, which is demanded after the transition. The players should hereby develop a feeling themselves on why that transition phase is so important. As a coach, that's the biggest problem that has to be solved.

Clarifying why a quick transition is important can be difficult to explain, especially from attack to defence. The key is to be extremely clear here:

- What's being asked from the players when they have the ball?
- What's being asked from the players when the opposition have the ball?
- And how do I get the desired organisation as soon as possible?

A player also has to sense what's needed by taking the opposition into account. If you play against a better opponent, then a different organisation is needed than when you're the better team. The players will understand this. You can progress a lot if you clearly make those agreements visible and frequently reference them during training sessions.

Thinking as a Team

The involvement of the player has to be increased by encouraging them to think laterally regarding the objectives for the team and the way these goals can be achieved. The training sessions are an effective

means. The players have to be aware of what they train on, so that they know what they are busy with. This increases their motivation to put in a good effort. In training you have to act motivated and fanatically, because you are also expecting this from the players. However, do monitor whether players feel safe or 'secure' on the pitch. It is important to create an atmosphere where the players are not afraid to make mistakes.

Also, during the matches, the coach may expect them to think about the various other positions on the pitch as well. They shouldn't limit themselves to their own position.

Positional Roles and Requirements

The choice for a certain style of play and formation has consequences for each line, when we have possession of the ball as well as when we defend. The next step is the consequences that all of this has for every player in a specific position in a certain age group. What skills does a player need to excel while playing in his position? We then end up with the competence profiles for each position. In our opinion, it's good to make youth players aware of the tasks and functions that belong to a certain position. The older a player becomes, the more aspects will be added.

By tracking your players' progress in detail, you can then talk to the players about this in a very structured way. Beforehand, the player in question and the coach compare and discuss the results of the assessment. This often leads to very interesting and in-depth football conversations. At such an

evaluation conversation you will soon discover if the self-image of the player is realistic. In professional academies coaches and the scouting department makes use of information from the 'player-tracking-system' (Spelersvolgsysteem - online tool to follow players). It's an instrument to speak the same football language or to look from the same point of view at football, and in particular to the players. The coach and scout now know what is minimally important for each position. Players can be trained and players can be targeted to fit the portrayed picture.

The competence profiles are a result of the style of play and are drafted for each age group and position. It's a resource for every coach. What does a player of a certain age have to know or be capable of? As a coach of a certain age group, you have to know which aspects need to be worked on.

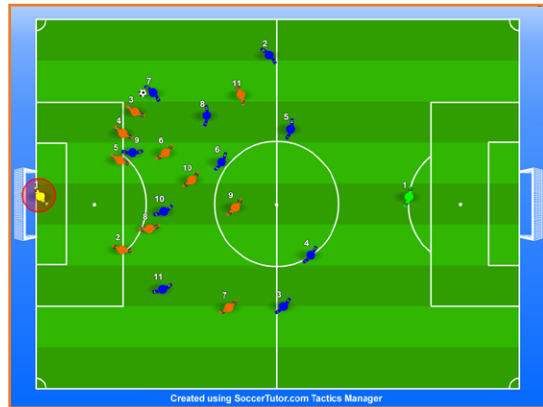
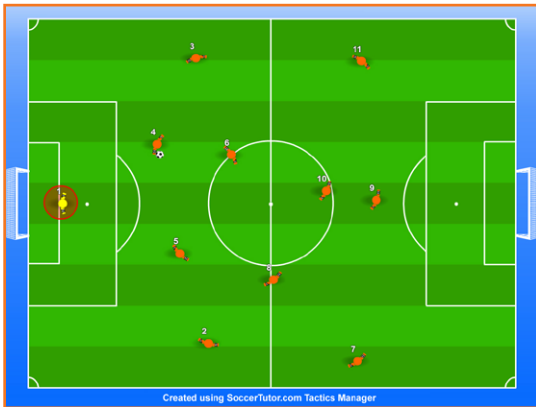
4-3-3 Formation



The positions are based on a 4-3-3 formation and the numbers refer to a specific position.

- 1:** Goalkeeper
- 2/3:** Full backs
- 4/5:** Centre backs
- 6/8:** Central midfielders
- 10:** Attacking midfielder
- 7/11:** Wingers
- 9:** Striker

Requirements for Goalkeepers (1)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Able to start the build-up play with a targeted throw or by rolling the ball out.
- Capable of receiving a back-pass.
- Able to control the ball with the right and left foot in a way that enables him to continue the build-up by using a short or long pass.
- When kicking the ball out of his hands, he can continue the game in a good way with a dropkick or volley.
- Quick to recognise potential 1 v 1 situations.
- Able to execute skills, turns etc with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Knows to position himself in a way that enables him to respond well to balls played into the box.
- Knows how to position himself during crosses from the side.
- Is able to execute all technical actions under pressure from one or more opponents.
- Makes the right decisions when trying to intercept long balls.

- Is able to force the opponent to make a difficult decision during the 1 v 1 duel with the goalkeeper.
- Positions himself correctly during a defensive free kick.

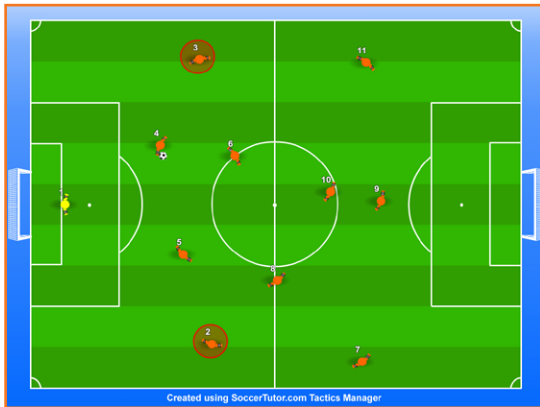
Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Knows how to deal with setbacks with the help of the coach.
- Able to provide his teammates with targeted instructions.
- Displays confidence and wants to keep a 'clean sheet' at the expense of everything else.

Requirements for Full Backs (2 & 3)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Knows where to be positioned during the build-up.
- Able to continue the build-up by using longer passes along the ground or in the air.
- Sees the right opportunities to push up into midfield.
- Good technique to cross the ball.
- Has the urge to continue attacks and keep making better choices with the ball.
- Able to apply all technical skills with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Capable of playing man-to-man defence.
- Capable of preventing/blocking crosses.
- Knows to position himself correctly, so that he can make the right choice to mark an attacker closely, push up or track a run.
- Knows to position himself correctly, so that he can intercept passes to his direct opponent.
- Knows how to make the pitch smaller by pushing inside/covering in a three-man or four-man defence.

- Knows how to position himself during crosses from the other flank.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

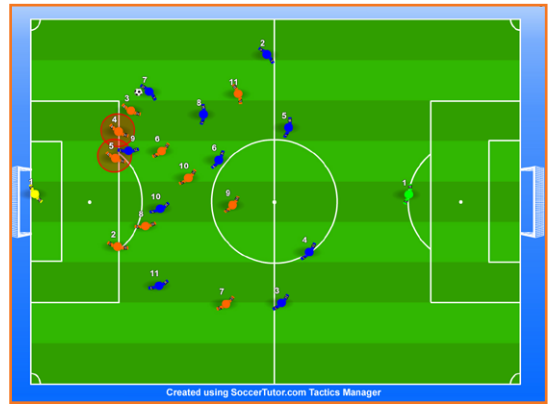
Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Ability to keep going despite minor setbacks.

Requirements for Centre Backs (4 & 5)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Knows where to be positioned during the build-up and is aware of his role in the organisation.
- Sees the right opportunities to push up into the midfield.
- Able to continue the build-up by using longer passes along the ground or in the air.
- Makes the right choices with the ball to continue an attack.
- His tactical vision ensures that he often makes the right decisions.
- Able to apply all technical skills with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Capable of playing man-to-man defence.
- Able to make the right decision as the free player:
 1. Push into midfield to mark players or provide cover.
 2. Push forward to intercept the ball when an opposition midfielder moves forward to receive.
 3. Remaining in position on the last line of defence.
- Knows to position himself correctly, so that he can make the right choice to mark an attacker closely, push up or track a run.

- Knows to position himself correctly, so that he can intercept passes to his direct opponent.
- Knows how to position himself in the correct way for crosses from the flank.
- Develops knowledge and skills against playing systems with one or two strikers.

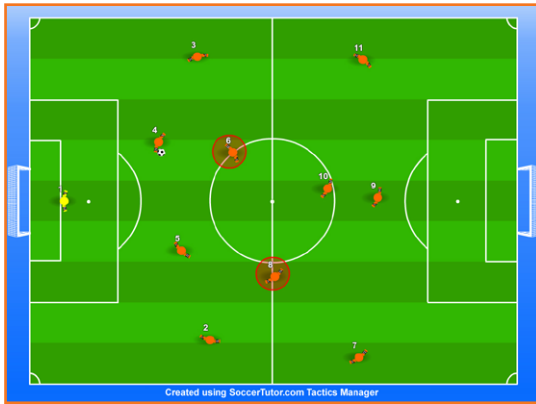
Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Coaches his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Ability to keep going despite minor setbacks.

Requirements for Central Midfielders (6 & 8)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Knows to perform a preliminary action and call for the ball at the right time (check away from marker before moving to receive) during the build-up from the back.
- Can create space for the ball or shield it during a duel + picks his moments to go deep.
- Able to continue an attack with well weighted passes or through balls.
- Can continue the build-up by using longer passes along the ground or in the air.
- Can shoot from distance with good technique.
- Able to create space and opportunities with good combination play.
- Able to perform all technical actions with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Collaborates with the centre backs to let them take over the marking of a midfielder who moves forward. They do not join the defensive line but remain in position.
- Able to hunt down the opponent at the right time and apply pressure.

- Able to get in front of an opponent at the right time.
- Frequently intercepts balls based on his vision and awareness of where passes are being made.
- Knows how far he has to cover and sees when he has to push forward.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

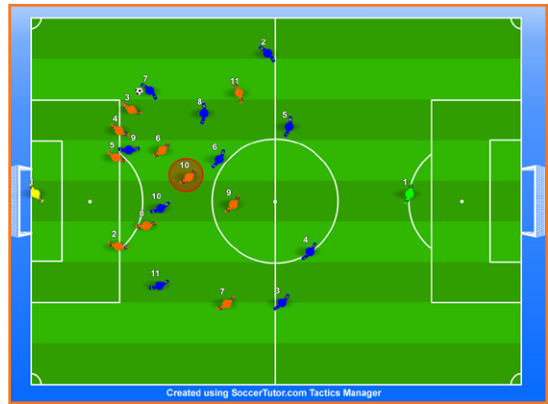
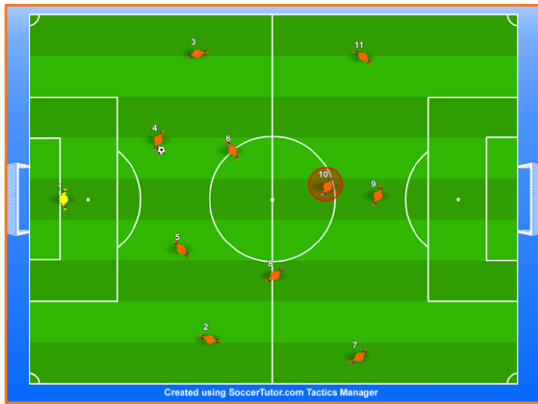
Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Not easily disturbed or distracted and always smart on the pitch.
- Able to deal with setbacks with the help of the coach.
- Coaches his teammates.

Requirements for Attacking Midfielders (10)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Can control/process the ball in such a manner that he makes the right choice regarding the opponent and the space.
- Sees the solutions before he receives the ball and has an eye for 'third man situations'.
- Ensures a good follow-up in the final stage of the attack by creating space for the ball, turning or shielding the ball.
- Ensures he's available to receive the ball in the final stage by using intelligent runs.
- His actions must lead to opportunities for himself and the team.
- Has the vision to make the right tactical decisions.
- Is capable to perform all technical actions with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Is able to direct the build-up to the flanks together with the forwards, or force the opposition to play the long ball.
- Recognises the right moment to apply pressure/hunt for the ball.
- Wins his head-to-head duels.

- Sees through situations during the build-up of the opposition and manages to gain possession this way frequently.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

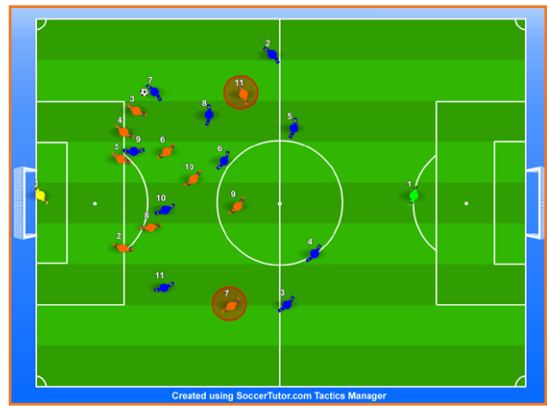
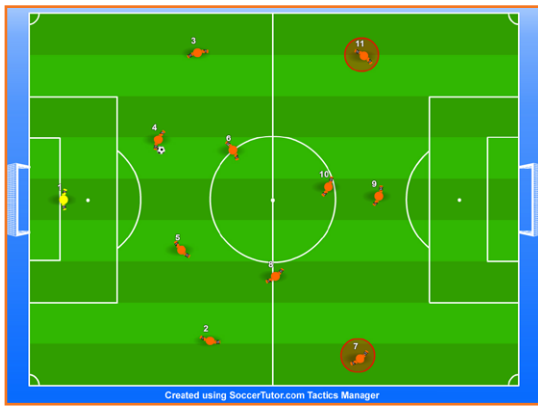
Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Ability to keep going despite minor setbacks.
- Has an above average game intelligence.
- Takes the initiative to get in possession of the ball constantly.
- Coaches his teammates.

Requirements for Wingers (7 & 11)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Manages to be available to receive the ball by employing various runs.
- Can control/process the ball in such a manner that he benefits from it, regarding the opponent and space.
- Able to get past a player on the inside and outside. He should then subsequently manage to provide a pass/cross or a through ball.
- Has the 'drive' to finish himself.
- Based on his vision, he should be able to make better decisions each time.
- His actions must lead to opportunities for himself and the team.
- Is capable to perform all technical actions with both feet.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Defending

- Knows when and how far he has to 'tilt' towards the direction of play.
- Is able to direct the build-up to the flanks together with the attacking midfielder (10) and other forwards, or force the opposition to play the long ball.

- Wins his head-to-head duels.
- Sees through situations during the build-up of the opposition and manages to gain possession this way frequently.
- Develops knowledge and skills playing against different systems/styles of play.

Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Ability to keep going despite minor setbacks.
- Takes the initiative to display his creativity.
- His creativity leads to an interesting turn or move to beat a defender, more often than not.

Requirements for Strikers (9)



Building Up Play / Attacking

- Sees the solutions before he receives the ball and has an eye for 'third man situations'.
- Available to receive the ball during an attack by using good movement and runs.
- Ensures a good follow-up in the final stage of the attack by creating space for the ball, turning or shielding the ball.
- Able to create opportunities for his teammates with and without the ball, which includes choosing the right position in front of goal and good collaboration with the attacking midfielder.
- Has scoring ability.
- Has the vision to make the right tactical decisions.
- Capable to perform all technical actions with both feet.
- Develops the knowledge and skills of playing against another system/style of play.

Defending

- Able to direct the build-up to the flanks together with the attacking midfielder (10) and other forwards, or force the opposition to play long balls.
- Recognises the right moment to apply pressure/hunt for the ball.

- Sees through situations during the build-up of the opposition and manages to gain possession this way frequently.
- Wins his head-to-head duels.
- Develops the knowledge and skills of playing against another system/style of play.

Physical Conditioning

- Has to manage to get through the growth spurt with as few physical complications as possible.
- Learns how to deal with his body to prevent getting into any states of imbalance.

Personality Traits

- Open to coaching from the coach, other staff members and his teammates.
- Very motivated to improve himself.
- Ability to keep going despite setbacks, such as .
- The seemingly easy ability to score goals.

CHAPTER 5

STYLE OF PLAY

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Style of Play



The Playing System (4-3-3)

We rely and use the 4-3-3 system for our training. The players have already gained some individual defensive experience by this age and are ready for development in a four-man defence. The fact that they often play with 4 defenders in adult football makes this choice logical.

Our preference is also to use 3 forwards, because the set of skills in this formation is at its highest point (if the implementation is coordinated). Forwards who are trained in a positioning system with 3 attackers are also easier to transform to a system with 2 attackers at a later date. In a 4-4-2 formation, the 2 attackers sometimes function too much as runners. The open spaces on the flanks stimulate these runs.

When developing attackers, it's not only essential that they are able to make deep runs, but also learning how to play with their back to goal is fundamental. In essence, there isn't much of a difference between 2 or 3 attackers. If the coach doesn't use his players too much as runners in a 4-4-2 formation, then this choice isn't a problem. Especially in the older youth teams, the players should be capable of functioning in both positioning systems (4-3-3 and 4-4-2).

The implementation of the midfield is also subject to further discussions. We assume a triangle with the point forward (1 attacking midfielder). A triangle with the point backward (1 defensive midfielder) also offers plenty of options. This is mainly the coach's choice depending on his thoughts and the players at his disposal.

As a tip we can share that the younger age groups (12-14 years old) are in need of structure. In these age groups, where teaching the 11 v 11 system is the main focus, it is best to choose one formation to work on. In the older age groups, the choices can be determined by the qualities of the players.

Writing down the playing systems is quite theoretical. More important is how it's executed. One would think that the choice for a 3-4-3 formation is attacking, however, even with this system it could be played very defensively. Playing with 3 forwards doesn't necessarily guarantee attacking football. For instance, the wingers could play 'deep' and mainly attack on the counter. In other words, the style of play heavily determines the development of young football players. Basing the player positioning on the way of playing, we call that the style of play. To the chosen playing system (3-4-3, 4-3-3, 4-4-2) you link the style of play.

Choosing and training a style of play with youth players looks quite different from doing so with adults. In adult football the style of play is often in service of getting a result. Youth football players have to mainly develop themselves individually. Developing a style of play for youth players has nothing to do with 'tactical training' of adult players. Tactical training is often done with the opponent in mind. This can limit and restrict players to tight defined tasks or specific assignments, which can hinder their expression, creativity, individuality and therefore, their development.

Enabling Expression & Development

Training the style of play with youth football players includes the development of technique and vision and awareness. It is mainly about expanding the football ability. Imposing restrictions should never be the case when training young football players. On the contrary, the players need to be encouraged to take more initiative. Results don't play a role in this at all.

The primary focus is the individual development of the player. Each player has his individuality, his way of playing. This is the starting point when training the style of play. The coach analyses his players and stimulates them, always looking to try out different options. In each age group there is sufficient room to grow, however, the implementation will be tighter

with the older players than with the younger players.

We are generally an advocate of dominance, thus a positive influenced style of play. The players shouldn't sit back behind the ball to then simply launch counter attacks, because the best results can't be achieved that way. We want to dominate the ball and the game. The basic formation is 4-3-3, with a centre back pushing up through the centre and into midfield as much as possible. For players in this age group it's recognisable.

It's important that you teach both centre backs to push up. Too often you notice that there is one man-marker and one player who builds up play. Make sure both centre backs are equally involved. The midfield basically plays with 2 behind and 1 in front. In the front line we opt for 3 forwards, of which 2 are wingers. The player positioning there is often very organised and recognisable for the players. If the opposition opts for the same style of play, then you'll get many 1 v 1 situations on the pitch. This often reduces the amount of expansive football, but it's important - every football player will have to deal with 1 v 1 situations sooner or later, so there is nothing wrong in devoting attention to this.

An important factor for the players to learn is making the pitch big when in possession and making it small when defending.

What does the team have to do if we have the ball, and what does that mean for every individual player?

Wingers are positioned as wide as possible and the striker as deep as possible etc. With a few basic agreements you can make clear what the intention is.

What happens when the opposition have the ball?

Terms like pushing inside (squeezing) to make the pitch smaller and close down space, and providing cover for teammates. You can help youth players by instructing them how far they have to push inside. The players will start to recognise this better and better, because their orientation on the pitch increases. The basic principle is focused on applying pressure on one side. The players need to learn to force the opponent to the flanks, prevent a forward pass, and push players up through the centre to press. We purposely don't train transition play at this age.

However, in this age group the transitions can still be decisive for the result in a match, so they have to be in control of the basics first which are building up, attacking and defending:

- Attacking football.
- Creativity and initiative in all positions.
- Dominance in 1 v 1 duels (attacking and defending).
- Targeted build-up play from the back.
- Defending as a tool and not as an objective.
- The main focus is the individual development of the player!

CHAPTER 6

BUILDING UP PLAY

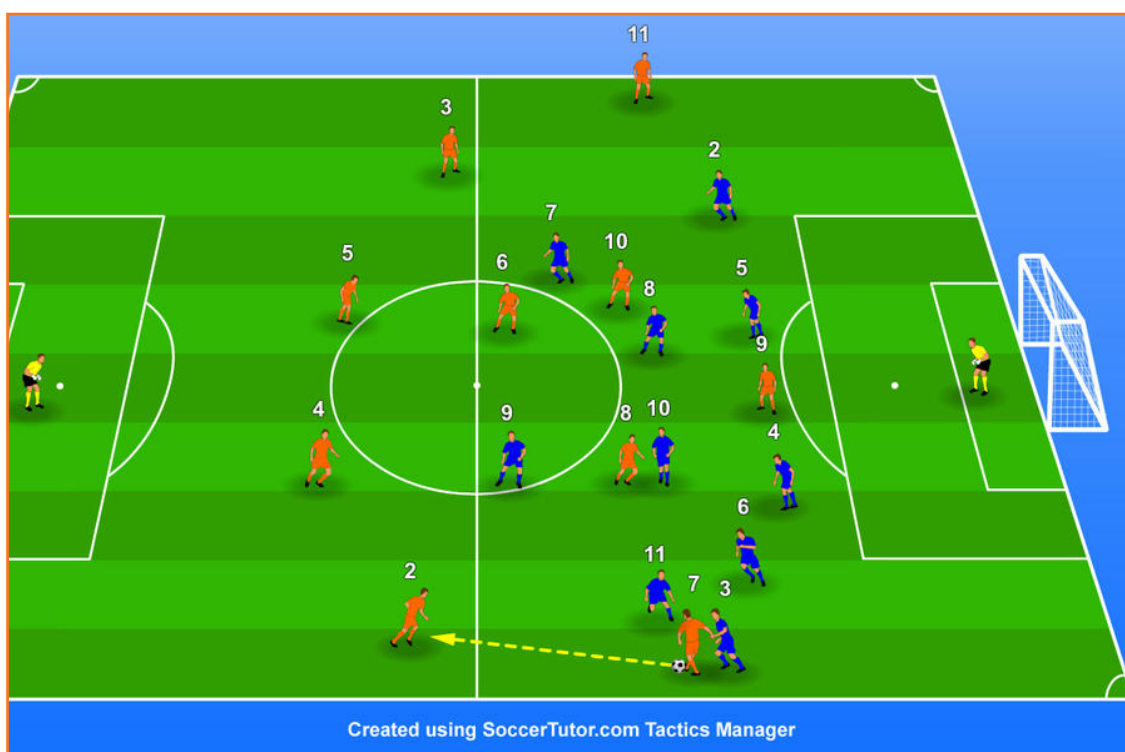
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Building Up Play

The Build Up is Not Just in Your Half - it Lasts Until the Moment a Player Faces Goal and is able to Create an Opportunity (Attack)

First of all, it's useful to determine what we mean by 'building up', since there is always a grey area where building up shifts to attacking. In any event, it's not true that the build-up always takes place in your own half and the attack is always in the opposition's half.

The build-up will turn into an attack from the moment that a player (with the ball at his feet) is positioned facing the opponent's goal and able to create an opportunity. Until that point, we are building up play.



In the diagram above we provide a very realistic example to clarify this situation. Although we have possession in the opposition's half, we are still in the build up phase, and have not started our attack.

The opposition decides to drop back deep into their half while we have possession. In this example our winger (7), deep in the opposition's half, has to play the ball back to the full back (2) on the halfway line, so we're still building up play.

The winger (7) was positioned with his back to goal or at best turned 90 degrees. There is no directly promising situation whereby the player with the ball can move towards the goal of the opposition to be an attacking threat.

Positional Roles when Building Up Play



Building Up Play

When coaching building up play, we can name a few important aspects for the whole team which are mainly important for players who are just starting to play 11 v 11 football on a full pitch. Depending on the level, as a coach you can continue with the details per line and per position. As a team, we have to keep the pitch as big as possible. There should be a good division of players across the pitch, as shown in the diagram.

Positional Roles

- **The centre backs (4 & 5)** are positioned apart.
- **The full backs (2 & 3)** are in advanced positions.
- **The 3 midfielders (6, 8 & 10)** make sure they are positioned somewhere between the forwards and defenders, because they are the 'link-up players'.
- **The wingers (7 & 11)** move towards the sideline to make the pitch as wide as possible. They don't always do this as they can be more flexible but it will be the most common occurrence - depending on the type of build up.

- **The striker (9)** will be positioned as advanced as possible and try to get the defenders from the opposition to follow him.

Building Up Play from the Back

As a starting point we would like to build up play from the back. It's important to mention this, because it isn't obvious for every club, team or coach. After all, you can also decide to play the long ball quickly and mainly focus on the second ball.

We want to build up play and therefore positional play is necessary. The team aims to play a forward pass from defence, create a numerical advantage in the midfield with a defender pushing forward or create a 1 v 1 situation up front. We will analyse these tactics on the following pages because they can easily be recognised by the coach and players, and they make it clear that we don't build up for the sake of building up, but rather we have a goal in mind.

The Role of the Defence

The Defensive Line's Positioning when Building Up Play



When building up play from the back and trying to play forward passes, there are a couple of basic principles.

- 1. The four defenders should never be positioned statically in one line.**

(No.2 follows on the next page)

As shown in the diagram, the full backs are positioned higher up than the centre backs. This means that more triangles can be created and more dynamic play occurs naturally.

In this example the full backs push higher up the pitch, taking their direct markers (blue wingers 7 & 11) away - this creates more space for the centre backs to pull out wide and receive the pass from the goalkeeper. The blue striker (9) is not able to cover both centre backs so at least one is left free.

The same principle of not being in one line can also work with just the centre backs. If one of them drops a bit deeper, the opposition's striker might follow him, creating space for the other centre back to then receive.

A centre back can also push up through the centre during the build up play. It can be particularly useful if the full backs drop back to get into a better position to receive the ball. If the full backs' direct opponents (the wingers) follow them, there will then be more space created for their teammates to exploit.

Receiving with the Correct Body Shape, Communication and Accurate Passing



2. Players should receive the ball in such a way to be able to immediately play a forward pass.

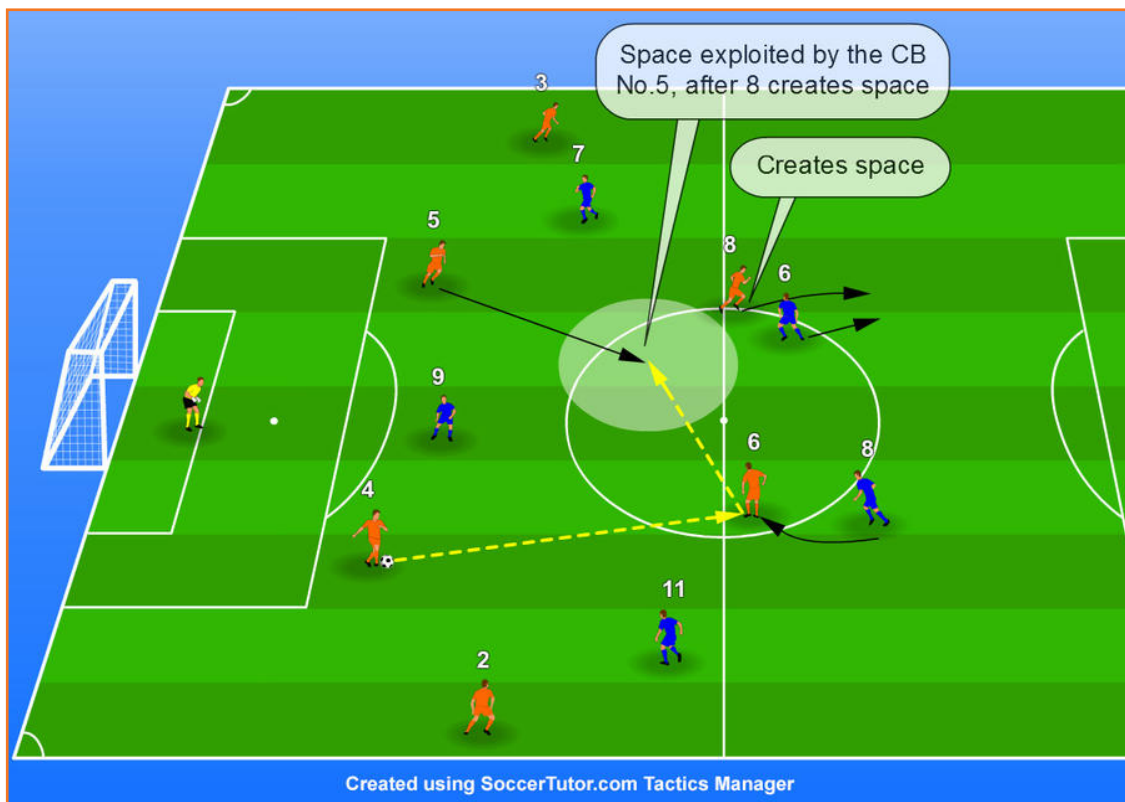
When receiving a pass, players need to use the correct body shape, with their posture angled towards the direction they want to go.

During youth games, you often see that the full back controls the ball played to him from the centre towards the sideline with his back foot, which limits his options for the next pass. He is then often forced to pass the ball to the winger along the same sideline, and his options will then be very limited as well. It is therefore better to continue building up (going backwards if necessary) and playing to a winger or forward higher up the pitch. In this example the right back (2) passes back inside to the centre back (5), who is then able to play the forward pass from a better position with more options.

The communication with players in front of you is key to this process. Hopefully your teammates are comfortable with the ball and able to look up when controlling it. We also find it is very important that youth coaches give players the freedom to pass the ball to players who are marked. You can teach them to pass the ball to the correct side of their teammate. For instance, as shown in the diagram, the striker (9) is marked from behind to the right, so the pass from the centre back (5) should be aimed to the striker's left. Communication is required for this and this can be in verbal or non-verbal forms.

The Role of the Midfield

Creating Space for the Centre Back to Push Forward into Midfield (1)



Here we are looking at how to create a numerical advantage in midfield when building up play from the back. In these examples we show how to create space for a centre back to push forward and receive.

One central midfielder has to drop back at the right moment to create a 'triangle' between the 2 centre backs and himself, while the other central midfielder moves to create space for the centre back who will move forward.

In the diagram example, the first central midfielder (6) drops to receive a pass from the centre back (4). At the same time, the other central midfielder (8) moves forward to create space and takes his direct marker

away. This creates space for the other centre back (5) to move into and No.6 plays a pass back into his path.

The orange team now have possession with a numerical advantage in midfield and can look to attack the opposition.

In contrast to this situation, you often see that the midfielders receive the ball when the opposition forwards have not started pressing yet. In this situation the opposition forwards would be in deeper positions and the midfield would be more congested. The pitch then becomes very small and there is little space available for the centre back to push up.

Creating Space for the Centre Back to Push Forward into Midfield (2)



The back line should be capable of making the right choices with the ball and collaborate with the central midfielders (6 & 8).

In this example, No.8 pushes forward (and takes his marker with him) when the left back (3) has the ball. The opposition's striker is next to our centre back No.5, which enables the other centre back (4) to move forward and receive the pass in lots of space in the centre of the pitch.

The forward players need to learn to read and predict when this situation is about to occur and make the necessary movements to try and receive the next pass in a 1 v 1 situation up front.

Creating Space for the Centre Back to Push Forward into Midfield (3)



The centre backs (4 & 5) need to be able to recognise the right time to push forward. Before this can happen the central midfielders (6 & 8) need to be aware to first create space. This can be achieved in many ways and different players/teams can have their own way of doing it. The most important factor is the awareness among young players that space has to be created.

A centre back can push forward with the ball at his feet (as shown in the diagram) or without the ball. In the example shown in the diagram, the central midfielder (6) moves out wide and is followed by his direct marker. This enables the centre back (4) to carry the ball forward into midfield.

The pushing up of a centre back is a focus point in this age group. However, this should not be the same player for the whole season. This should be alternated between No.4 and No.5.

Creating Space for the Centre Back to Push Forward into Midfield (4)



Give your centre backs 6-8 weeks of practising pushing into midfield during training. After this period, they can then try to utilise this tactic in competitive matches.

Our preference is to gain a numerical advantage in midfield with the centre back being the player to push forward and not so much by a full back. This is because the opposing wingers are still strictly focused on their direct opponent at that age, and it would therefore be hard for them to receive in space without being tracked. Of course it's not forbidden, but it's not the focus point. If a full back has won a duel and he's able to leave his direct opponent behind by dribbling in, then that can only be a good thing!

The Role of the Attack

Creating a 1 v 1 Situation in the Front Line

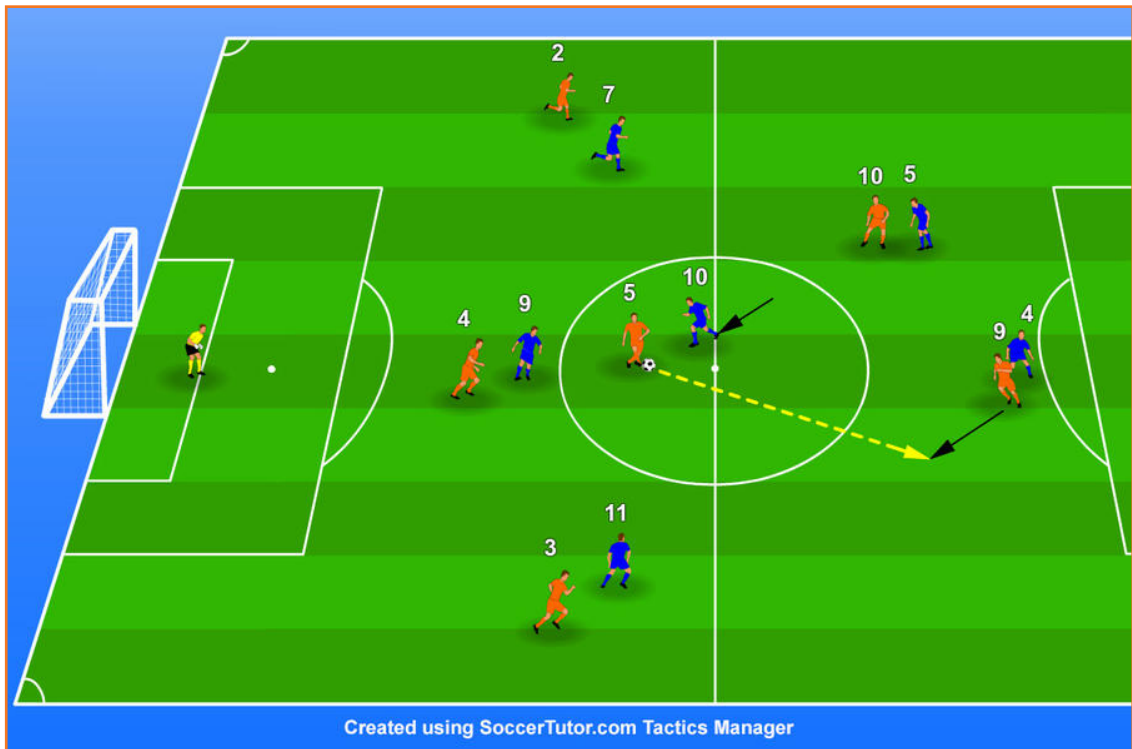


In this example, the centre back (4) has successfully received the ball in midfield. We have a numerical advantage in the centre of the pitch. Most often in this situation the opposition have to sacrifice their open player to go and close down the ball. In this example No.10 moves forward to contest the centre back (4). This can then lead to creating a 1 v 1 situation in the front line.

The basic principles here are:

- The striker has to be a good target-man (as advanced as possible).
- If a striker positions himself into a 1 v 1 in the front line, then the team must try to pass to him as quickly as possible.
- The striker has to constantly be aware so that he can receive the pass during those moments.
- You have to try to make the players aware to create this situation by coaching them - you can then expect them to recognise the situation better each time.

Using the Striker as a Target Man

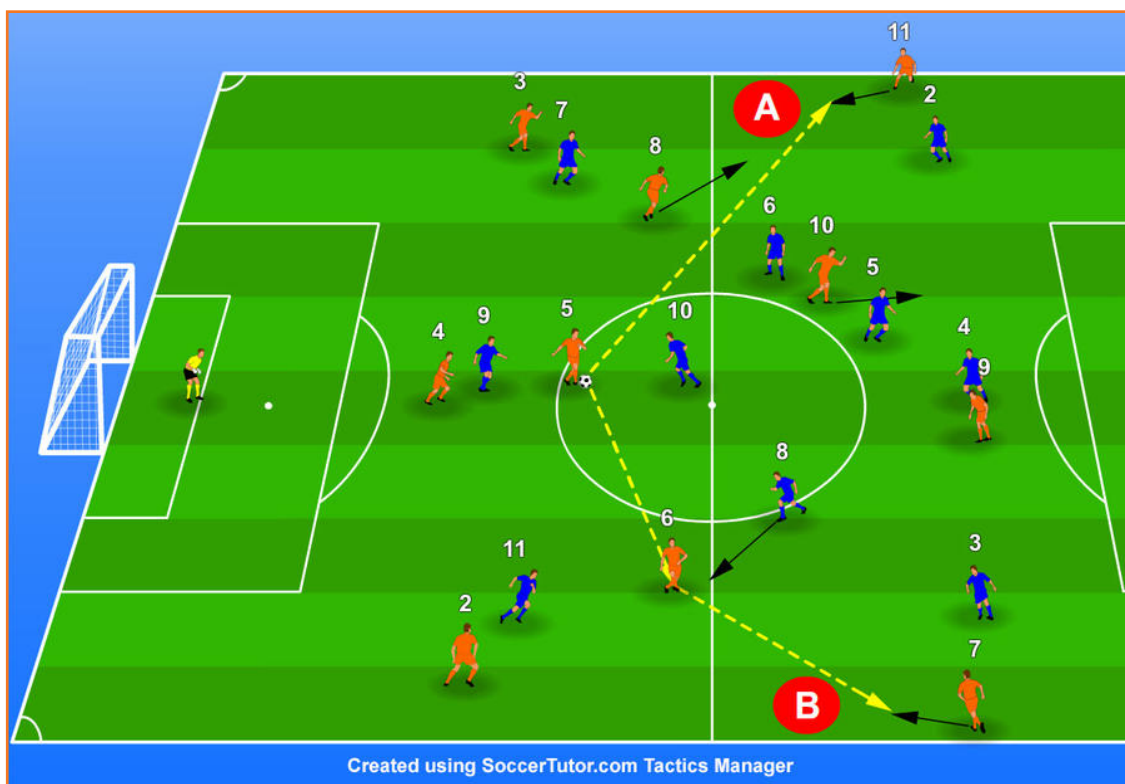


In this situation, our centre back No.5 has received the ball in midfield. The striker (9) is being man-marked and drops back to receive.

The striker checks away from his marker before moving to receive at an angle. He hopes to receive the ball with some time and space in a 1 v 1 situation. From this point the team can create goal scoring opportunities in the final third with good support play and runs in behind the opposition's defensive line.

If the striker remains tightly marked, he looks to retain possession for his team first.

Wingers Getting in Position to Receive the Ball



The wingers (7 & 11) should remain wide in the build up phase and in position to receive the ball. Even if we have a 1 v 1 situation in the front line, it's important that the wingers keep the pitch wide initially to create space for themselves and others.

Well-intentioned and enthusiastic young players sometimes have the habit to go inside during those moments (too) early, causing them to actually close down the space. At this age, it's often necessary that the coach keeps stressing the importance of keeping the pitch big and wide during the build-up. The key point to get across to your players is that it will result in more time and space for the attack in the end. The opposition have to cover more ground and become less compact, making it easier to exploit the spaces in between them.

In the diagram both wingers are positioned out wide when the central midfielder or centre back has possession of the ball. They drop back at the right moment, well timed to receive the pass out wide.

Building Up Play: Key Points

Other points of attention for the players regarding the build-up are:

- **Depth is more important than width:** We don't build up just to be building up, but we actually want to go forward. A sideways or backward pass can be an excellent option if it leads to playing the ball forward afterwards, but if it's possible to go forward directly, then we prefer to see that.
- **Everybody participates:** This includes the goalkeeper. He's allowed to play a dominant role in the build-up. After all, he's often an 'open player'. When the goalkeeper passes the ball to a teammate during the build-up, he shouldn't think that his job is done. Don't expect the impossible from a goalkeeper though - not every 11 year old goalkeeper is capable of playing the ball to the striker.
- **All players (including defenders) should dare to call for the ball and try to find individual solutions:** Especially with the younger players, as a coach you have to create an environment where players are allowed to make mistakes. Only then will they dare to perform individual actions to achieve a better football situation. If you react in a negative manner at the time a player loses possession during the build-up, or allow his teammates to do that, then that situation will never be present.
- **The wingers and striker need to keep the pitch as big as possible:** They should call for the ball at the right moment by means of a well-timed run. Although the wingers initially start from the sideline, they are permitted to come inside. It's preferable though that they are positioned with their heels towards the sideline at the time they receive the ball, facing towards their direct opponent.
- **Checking away from your marker before moving to receive is key:** Players need to constantly repeat the pattern of checking away from a marker and then making a second movement to receive the ball in space. In youth football now, you often see that the attacking player gets in position towards the ball, but doesn't receive it. Subsequently he calls for the ball again, but unconsciously he makes the pitch smaller. It's better to first create space for yourself. For instance, walk offside first and then suddenly drop back towards the ball.

BUILDING UP PLAY TRAINING PRACTICES

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Receive and Pass with the Inside of the Foot in 5 v 2 Zones



Objective: To improve the control of the ball and the pass with the inside of the foot. This is to prevent technical mistakes during the build-up which lead to losing possession.

Description

We mark out 3 zones which are all 15/20 x 25/30 yards and they should not be further than 5 yards apart. One zone is separate to the other 2 and has a goal with a goalkeeper outside, as shown in the diagram.

The practice starts with 2 balls at once. In the top zone 5 orange players start in possession against 2 blue defenders. The orange team try to complete 10 passes (1 point) and the blues try to win the ball and score. If the ball goes out of play, then the blues can dribble the ball back in and attack.

We also have 2 other zones who play with the second ball that the coach passes in. In the first zone we have 5 blue players starting in possession against 2 orange players who try to win the ball. The 5 blue players try to complete 10 passes (1 point). The 2 blue players aim to win the ball and then pass to one of their 5 teammates in the other zone.

When a team loses possession, they then have to try to immediately close the space and try to prevent the pass to the other zone (to win possession back). If the ball goes out of play, the coach passes a new ball into one of the zones and the practice starts from the beginning again.

Basic practices like 5 v 2 and 3 v 1 are simplified practices. Coach the team in possession to reduce the number of touches they take. Coach the defending pair to work collectively, closing off passing angles and making the spaces smaller.

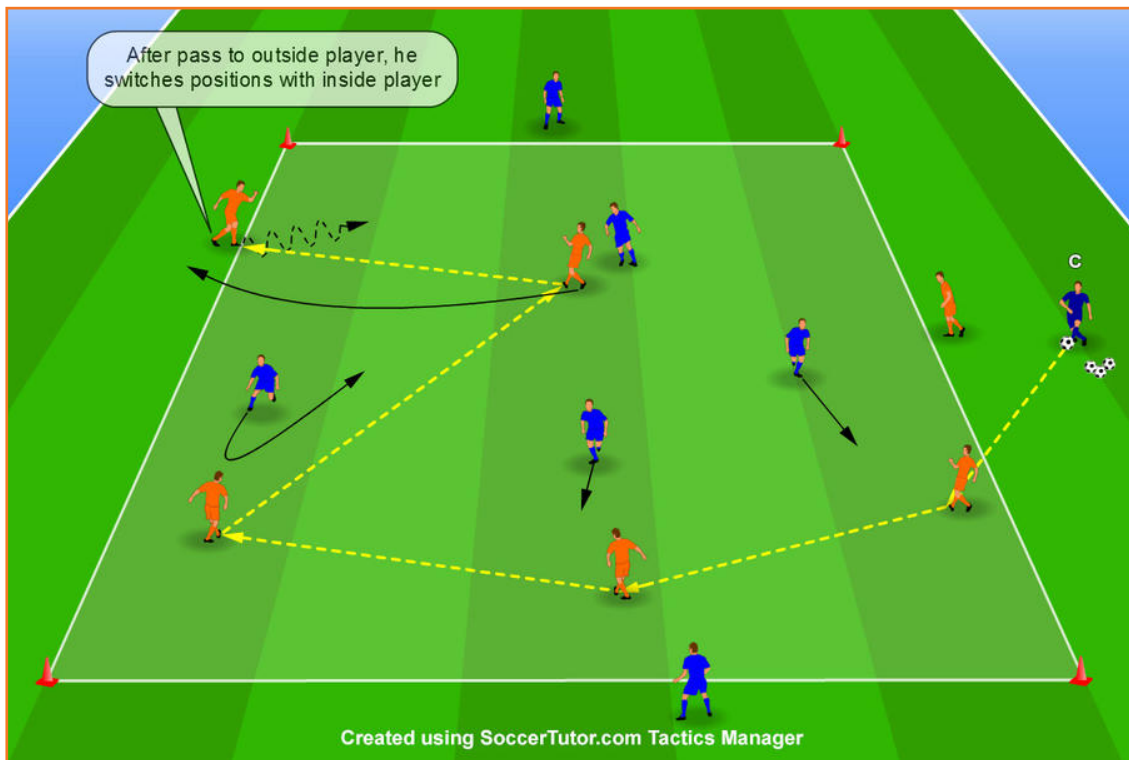
Variations

1. With the 5 v 2 situation in two sections, we have two teams of seven. Run the practice for 75 seconds and see which team completes the highest number of consecutive passes. The winners get 1 point.
2. Play 5 v 3 or 3 v 3 (+ 2 neutral players) in each zone.

Coaching Points

1. Mainly use the inside of your foot and not the toe of your foot to control and pass.
2. Approach bouncing balls with your foot above the ball.
3. Encourage the use of both feet during all technical practices.
4. Receive the ball in such a way (out in front of your body) to allow an immediate pass. Do this in the direction where the space is or where your teammate you want to pass to is positioned.
5. Ensure that the ball is always a bit in front of you, so passing and looking over the ball then becomes easier.
6. Strike the ball in the centre when passing, which promotes a better connection between foot and ball.
7. Tighten your ankle, making sure not to have a 'weak foot'.
8. Pass the ball with the right pace e.g. hard if the distance is big or if your teammate is in a situation where he could be closed down quickly.
9. Pass the ball to your teammate on the correct side/leg.
10. Always be ready (on the front of the foot, knees a little bent, half turned/open) to receive the ball.

Positioning and Movement to Receive and Pass Quickly in a 4 (+2) v 4 (+2) Possession Game



Objective: To improve positioning and movement without the ball and quick play (receive and pass).

Description

In a 40 x 40 yard area we have a 4 v 4 situation inside the area and both teams have an additional 2 players that are positioned along the outside lines in the positions shown. If you have the ball, you play 4 (+2) v 4. The coach starts the practice by passing to one team (oranges in diagram) and they try to keep possession.

Different rules for the involvement of the outside players:

1. They are limited to 1 or 2 touches.
2. When the outside player receives, he dribbles the ball inside - the player who passed the ball moves outside.
3. You can decide whether players are allowed to pass back to the player that passed to them and/or if the outside players can pass to each other.

The orange team must try to complete a set amount of passes to score a point. The blue team try to win the ball and then complete a set amount of passes themselves (with the use of their 2 outside players).

What are we trying to achieve?

We are working on developing fundamental attributes that are needed to build up play, which are moving into the correct positions (creating space), receiving on the half-turn and delivering an accurate pass.

Progressions

1. You can modify the size of the area and/or number of players.
2. You can change the unrestricted nature of the practice by limiting the players to 2-3 touches.

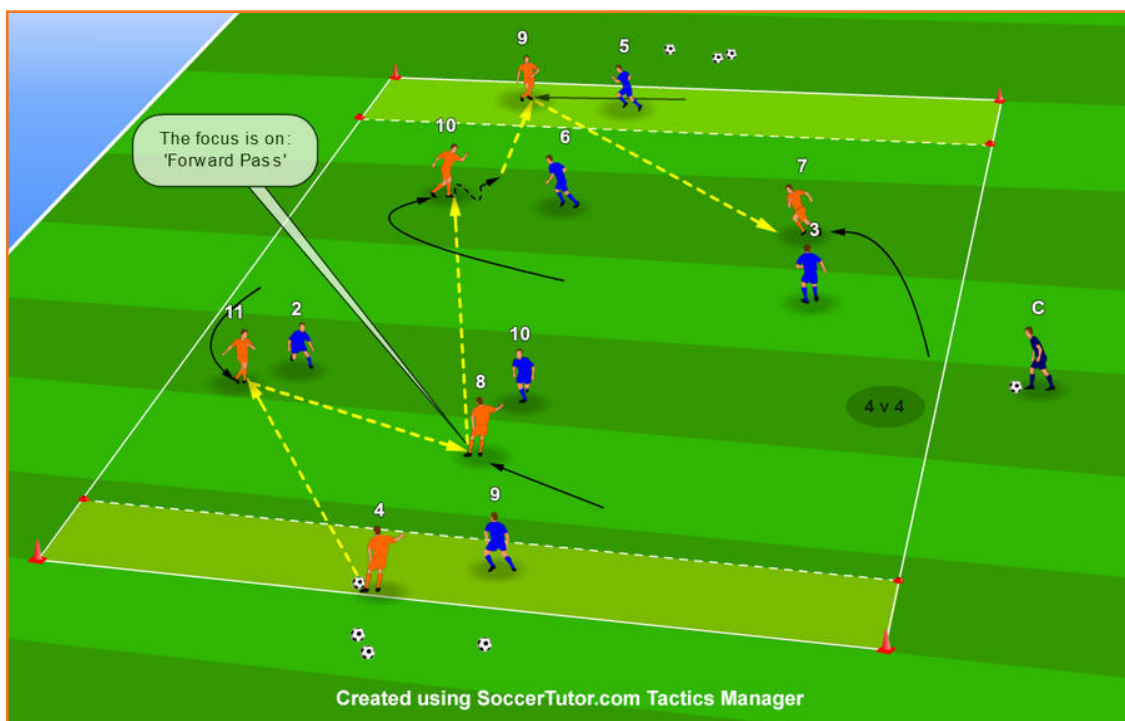
Variations

1. Remove 2 of the outside players. Just have 2 neutral players along opposite sides who play with whichever team is in possession.
2. Remove all outside players and just have 1 or 2 neutral players who play with the team in possession within the area.

Coaching Points

1. Control the ball in a way that enables you to pass it on quickly. Don't let the ball get stuck under your feet.
2. Control the ball in the movement, avoid a duel and create your own space.
3. Make space for the ball if you don't see any passing options.
4. Search for communication with the deepest positioned player and pass the ball to him on his correct side.
5. When passing the ball, hit it with the inside of your foot in the middle of the ball.
6. Move at the right moment to the left/right to open up the line as the deepest positioned player.
7. Move away without the ball to create space for a teammate.
8. Keep the spaces big at all times.

Playing Forward Passes in a 3 Zone End to End Possession Game



Description

In a 15 x 30 yard area, we mark out 2 end zones which are 15 x 3 yards. In each end zone we have 1 orange player and 1 blue player. In the middle zone we have a 4 v 4 situation - all players stay within their respective zones.

The practice starts with a centre back (orange 4 or blue 5) in the end zone. The aim for the team in possession is to play the ball from one end zone to the other without losing the ball (1 point). If they achieve this, they keep possession and try to play the ball back to the other end zone for another point.

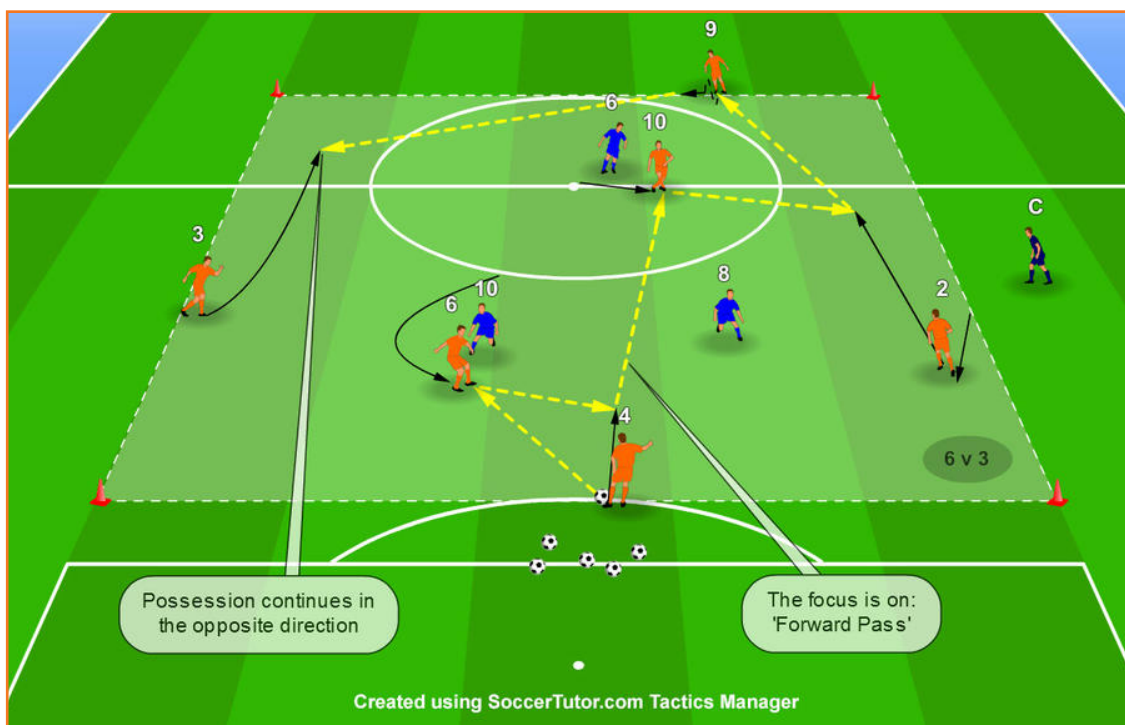
The defending team try to win the ball and then pass to one of their teammates in an end zone. They then have the same objective to play the ball from one zone to the other. The defending players in the end zones are fully active so the attacking players need to create space to receive. Start with an unrestricted game and progress to limit the players to 1 or 2 touches.

Winning Moment: The team that scores 5 points first wins.

Coaching Points

1. Play within a formation and occupy your positional role (e.g. diamond midfield).
2. Everything should be focused on the forward pass - any back or sideways passes should just be preparation for a forward pass to follow.
3. The moment to play it forward is when the defender applies pressure on the ball.
4. Players within the middle zone need to create space - check before moving to receive (lose your marker). They also need to use good positional play, making it easier to play through from one zone to the other.

Passing Forward in a Positional 6 v 3 Possession Game



Objective: We work on playing the ball forward and maintaining possession within positional roles.

Description

In the area shown we play a 6 v 3 possession game. The orange team have 1 centre back, 2 full backs (or wingers) and 1 striker who start on the outsides, with 2 central midfielders inside the area. The blue team have 3 central midfielders all inside the area.

The players who start on the outsides can move inside when they are directly involved i.e. moving to receive or combining with a teammate inside. This is shown with the centre back (4) stepping inside to play a forward pass.

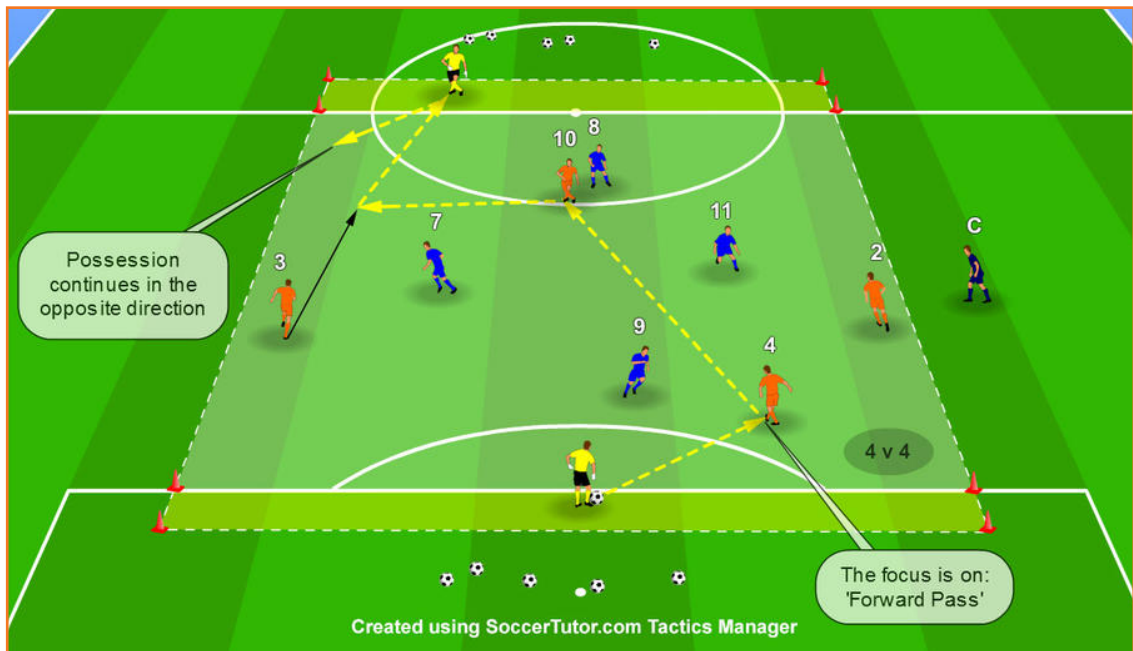
The orange team work the ball from one end to the other, trying to play forward passes. The other aim is to maintain possession. You can start without restrictions and progress to limiting the players to 1 or 2 touches.

Winning Moment: The coach keeps track of the time needed for the team of 3 (blues) to win the ball. Subsequently the team of 3 then works on improving this time.

Coaching Points

1. The focus is on the forward pass (from one end to the other). Alternate between short and long passes.
2. Everything should be aimed at the forward pass - playing it back or sideways should only be preparation for the forward pass).
3. The moment to play it forward is when the defender applies pressure on the ball.
4. Try to reach the player on the other side by means of good positional play.

4 v 4 (+2) End to End Possession Game with Goalkeeper End Zones



Objective: To develop technical skills and vision/awareness in the build up.

Description

In the area shown we mark out 2 end zones. There is a 4 v 4 situation in the main zone and 1 goalkeeper in each end zone. The focus is on playing the ball from one goalkeeper to the other using forward passes.

A goalkeeper starts the practice and passes to one team - in the diagram example the goalkeeper passes to the orange centre back No.4. The orange team try to work the ball to the other goalkeeper successfully without the opposition touching the ball (1 point). If they achieve this, they maintain possession and try to then work the ball back to the opposite goalkeeper to score another point.

The defending team (blues in diagram) try to win the ball and pass to a goalkeeper. From there, they then try to work the ball from one goalkeeper to the other themselves and score a point.

Rules

1. The defending players can only enter end zones once the goalkeeper receives the ball.
2. You can start without restrictions and progress to limit the players to 1 or 2 touches.

Coaching Points

1. Give the players set positions E.g. 1 centre back (or central midfielder), 2 full backs (or wingers) and 1 forward.
2. The focus is on the forward pass (from one end to the other). Alternate between short and long passes
3. Everything should be aimed at the forward pass - playing it back or sideways should only be preparation for the forward pass.

Receiving in Space and Passing in Midfield (7 v 7 in the Middle Third)



Objective: Focus on the attributes needed to play in midfield. Midfielders must be capable of maintaining possession, creating space, receiving and taking opponents out of the game with good a pass or by dribbling. The midfielders have to become better on the ball to provide individual solutions without losing possession.

Description: We play 7 v 7 and each player is assigned a number (1 to 7). The coach starts by passing a ball into play. During the game, the players have to pass in number sequence (1 -> 2 -> 3 -> 4 -> 5 -> 6 -> 7). If No.7 receives, that team (oranges) score 1 point - he must then pass to No.1 and the sequence starts again.

The numbers are also significant for the defending team (blues). The only way to win the ball is to dispossess the player on the other team with the same number as you. This practice is tough from a conditioning perspective so keep this in mind and allow the players to rest.

Coaching Points

1. Make yourself available without the ball and get into the vision of the player with possession.
2. Don't make the space too small and be clear in your runs.
3. Your first touch is decisive for the follow-up. Be aware of your teammates/opponents and spaces on the pitch.
4. Keep the ball away from your opponent - don't give them the chance to tap the ball away or win possession.
5. Each time you dribble, do so towards the open space/side where the opponent isn't.
6. Don't stand still with the ball at your feet and turn away from your opponent at the right moment.
7. Eliminate your opponent - cut away, use a feint or a pass + move.
8. Only play the ball once your teammate is in your sights.
9. Think one or two steps ahead. If No.3 has the ball, then No.5 should already be thinking about his movement to receive from No.4.

Passing Direct from the Centre Back to the Striker when Building Up in a 5 v 4 Practice (1)



Objective: We work on playing forward passes when building up play from the back.

Description

In a 50 x 40 yard area we divide the pitch into two sections and play 5 v 4. There are 2 small goals at one end and an end line (red dashes) at the other end.

In the first section, the 4 orange defenders play against 3 opposition forwards. In the second section, we have a striker (9) against 1 blue defender. The practice always starts with one of the orange players in between the 2 small goals.

The aim for the orange team is to dribble the ball over the end line. However, they can only do this after they have passed the ball to the striker (9) successfully within his zone. Once the striker receives the ball from a pass, then the game continues without any restrictions of movement across the 2 sections, until the ball goes out of play or a goal is scored. The striker is also allowed to directly dribble across the end line.

The blue team aim to apply pressure on their opponents to win the ball in either section and then attack to score in one of the small goals.

Variations

1. Coach the 3 blue forwards to press collectively, making it harder for the orange defenders to pass to their striker.
2. Increase the distance needed for the pass to the striker.
3. The striker has to receive against 2 blue centre backs.
4. Use a full sized goal and a goalkeeper but change to a 5 v 3 outfield situation for the build-up.
5. You can adjust the amount of players to suit your training e.g. add a central midfielder.

Coaching Points

1. Control the ball in such a way that allows you to be able to look and pass forward.
2. Make sure the ball does not get stuck under your feet as it will limit your ability to pass over a distance and to look forward.
3. Search for eye contact with the striker. Is he ready to receive the ball or is he still preparing the run?
4. Recognise the moment when the line to the striker opens up.
5. If the line isn't open, then keep the pitch big, pass the ball around at a high pace and take up good positions without the ball.
6. Rotate your body whilst looking ahead.
7. The full backs (2 & 3) have to drop back and make themselves available to receive the ball. If they do this too late then they can never have their body rotated, forcing them to play a return pass to the centre back.
8. Pass the ball precisely and with power (along the ground) to the correct side of the forward.
9. Where can we make the triangle? Where is the defender?

Passing Direct from the Centre Back to the Striker when Building Up in a 5 v 4 Practice (2)



Objective: We work on playing forward passes when building up play from the back.

Description

For this practice we mark out 3 zones on a full pitch which are all the width of the penalty area. The first zone is 20 yards long and this is where the coach starts the practice in a 4 v 2 situation. There is 1 orange attacker and 1 blue defender (behind him) in the middle zone.

The first aim for the orange team is to pass the ball to the forward from the low zone. The 2 blue players aim to win the ball and then dribble across the line to score a goal.

One player from the low zone is then allowed to move into the middle zone and create a 2 v 1 situation for an attack. As soon as this happens both players are free to move into the penalty area and try to use their numerical advantage to score past the goalkeeper.

Variations/Progressions

1. Playing 3 v 1 in the first zone to make the build-up easier.
2. Decrease the size of the 4 v 2 section to make the build-up more difficult.
3. Play 5 v 3 for the build-up including a goalkeeper or 4 v 3 (more difficult).
4. Add defenders/forwards into the middle zone.

Coaching Points

1. Position yourself well to receive the ball and be able to move away (behind) the defender.
2. Control the ball with a tight touch so you can look forward and play a pass to the striker immediately.
3. Send in a hard pass over this distance.
4. Search for eye contact.
5. Pass the ball to the striker's correct side in relation to where the defender is.
6. Join in after passing and exploit the 2 v 1 situation.

Passing Direct from the Centre Back to the Striker & Support Play in Small Sided Games



Objective: To practice passing from the centre back directly to the forward. Players need to learn to recognise the moment the forward runs off the ball and play the pass at the right time (with the correct weight). We also work on the technique and passing skills of the goalkeeper during the build up.

Description

In the diagram we show 2 versions of the same practice. In the first game we have a 4 v 4 (+GKs) situation in a 44 x 35 yard area. In the second game we have a 5 v 5 (+GKs) situation in a 60 x 50 yard area.

1. The goalkeeper starts the practice and passes to one of the two centre backs. Their aim is to pass to the striker. We have a 4 v 4 situation. The orange team try to support the forward and score. The blue defending team try to win the ball and then score themselves.
2. The goalkeeper starts the practice and passes to one of the two centre backs. Their aim again is to pass to the striker, but now we have a 5 v 5 situation with 2 wingers who provide support high up. The orange team try to score, the blues try to win the ball and score themselves.

If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, then we start the practice again from a goalkeeper.

Progression: You can adapt the practice to play 6 v 6 (+GKs) or 7 v 7 (+GKs).

Coaching Points

It is important to make the pitch as big as possible. The forward checks away from his marker and moves to receive, the wide players should move towards the sideline and the 2 central players move apart from each other.

The Centre Backs:

1. Control the ball in such a way that allows you to be able to look and pass forward.
2. Search for eye contact with the striker.
3. Pass the ball precisely and with power (along the ground) to the correct side of the forward.
4. Where can we make the triangle? Where is the defender?
5. Wait to coach the players after the pass has been played.
6. After the pass into the forward, the other centre back should move forward to participate in the attack.

The Striker:

1. Search for eye contact with the centre backs. This is decisive for the timing of the moment to call for the ball.
2. Check away from your marker before moving to receive.
3. Move away from the back of the defender.
4. Don't be tempted to come to the ball too quickly. Move away again if you don't receive the ball, otherwise the spaces become progressively smaller.

The defending team: Make the pitch small, organise to play offside or apply collective pressing.

Goalkeeper's Short & Long Distribution in a Dynamic Game



Objective: We work with the goalkeeper on picking the right passing option (short or long). The outfield players work on moving to receive and then building up play.

Description

Using half a pitch we have 1 full size goal and 2 small goals, as shown in the diagram. The orange team have a goalkeeper, the back 4, the No.10 and 1 striker. The blue team have 3 central midfielders, 2 wingers and 1 striker.

The practice starts with the coach passing to one of the centre backs, who then passes back to the goalkeeper. The goalkeeper must look to play the ball to a teammate in space. One blue opposition player must close the goalkeeper down (after the pass back) so this should always leave 1 player free to pass to.

The goalkeeper can play it short or long. The orange team try to build up play and score in one of the small goals on the halfway line. The goalkeeper can score directly with a long kick if he chooses. The blue team apply pressure and mark their opponents tightly. If they win the ball, they try to score past the goalkeeper.

Coaching Points

1. Make sure the goalkeeper plays a mixture of short and long passes to start the build up.
2. The goalkeeper's focus is on making the right decision, whether that be kicking the ball into an empty goal or finding the open player in space.

Building Up Play from the Goalkeeper through to Midfield in a 6 (+GK) v 4 Game



Objective: We work on building up play from the goalkeeper to the defenders and midfielders.

Description

Within half a full pitch, we play an unrestricted game. The orange team have a goalkeeper, 2 centre backs, 2 full backs and 2 central midfielders (6 & 8). The blue team have 3 forwards and 1 central midfielder (10).

The practice starts with the orange team's goalkeeper and the orange team try to build up play from the back. They work the ball forward by creating space to receive and picking the right passing options. If they are successful they try to score in one of the 2 small goals on the halfway line.

The blue team press the orange team and try to block forward passes and win the ball. If they are successful, they then try to score past the goalkeeper. If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, start again with the orange team's goalkeeper.

Variations

1. The orange team have to score within a set amount of time.
2. Position the 2 small goals further apart to make it easier to score or closer together to make it more difficult.

Coaching Points

1. The goalkeeper should search for the most advanced open player to build up the play as quickly as possible.
2. All players should be constantly reminded to create space and pass to the open player.

Building Up Play from the Back Directly to the Forwards in a 2 Zone Game



Objective: We work on the build-up from the goalkeeper to the defenders and then to the forwards.

Description

Using an area 10-15 yards longer than a full pitch we have a full size goal at one end and 3 small goals at the other end. In zone 1 we have a goalkeeper, the orange team's back 4 and 3 blue forwards. In zone 2 we have 3 orange forwards and 3 blue defenders.

The goalkeeper starts the practice by passing to a player within zone 1. The aim for the orange players is to pass or dribble the ball into zone 2. The 3 blue forwards try to win the ball and score past the goalkeeper.

As soon as the ball enters zone 2 there are no longer any zone restrictions - the orange team start a 7 v 6 attack and try to score in the empty goals. The blues still have the same aim to defend, win the ball and then try to score in the full size goal past the goalkeeper.

If the blue forwards win the ball in zone 1 and score, the goal counts double. If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, we start again with the orange team's goalkeeper in zone 1.

Winning Moment: We have 10 repetitions starting from the orange team's goalkeeper. The team with the most goals wins.

Coaching Point: There needs to be a high speed of play with all players always looking for the open man.

Moving the Ball Forward when Building Up Play from the Back in a SSG



Objective: To improve passing and dribbling forward when building up play from the back.

Description

In the area shown we divide the pitch into two halves. The practice starts with one team's goalkeeper (orange in diagram) and they have a 4 (+GK) v 3 situation in their own half - the blues have 3 forwards (2 wingers and 1 striker). The aim is to pass the ball to one of their 3 teammates (orange forwards 7, 11 and 9) in the opposition's half; those 3 will play against 4 defenders from the opposing side.

One orange defender is allowed to move into the opposition's half (receive a pass/dribble forward) and join the attack, creating a 4 v 4 situation. The 4 orange players try to score past the goalkeeper.

The blue team try to win the ball in both halves. If they are successful then:

1. The restrictions on movements across the halves are no longer in effect (possibly apply a time limit).
2. The blues try to score in the opposite goal.

If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, start again with the other team's goalkeeper.

Progressions

1. You can start the practice with 3 defenders against 3 forwards. This means there will be a 4 v 3 numerical advantage for the attack in the opposition's half.
2. Adapt the practice so that you have defence, midfield and attacking lines.

Coaching Points

1. Make the pitch big and stand wide, with the correct positioning and body shape which makes you available to receive the ball.
2. The centre backs can drop back into deep positions, enabling the full backs to push forward and wide.
3. Play the ball around at a high tempo.
4. Maintain good communication and eye contact with the forwards during this process.
5. Control the ball in such a way that allows you to be able to look and pass forward.
6. Recognise the moment when the line to the attacker is open.
7. Pass the ball when there is eye contact and the forward is available to receive it.
8. Pass the ball to the correct side of the player.
9. Dribble forward if the striker is marked and there is sufficient space in front of you.

Connecting the Full Backs with the Front Line in an 8 v 8 Zonal Practice



Objective: To improve the build-up play of the full backs in collaboration with the 3 forwards.

Description

We use a full pitch and mark out 5 zones as shown. The middle zone is 15-20 yards long. The goalkeeper starts the practice in zone 1 by passing into zone 2 where there is a 4 v 3 situation (back 4 vs 3 blue forwards).

The orange defenders have the following options:

1. Pass to one of the attackers in zone 4. If they are successful, 1 full back (2 or 3) moves forward to receive the pass back in zone 3. The full back combines with the forwards and we have a 4 v 4 attack in zones 4 and 5.
2. Pass to one of the attackers who drops into zone 3 to receive. 1 full back (2 or 3) can make a forward run and we have a 4 v 4 attack again.

The defenders (blue) are allowed to move into zone 3 to defend. The offside rule is applied throughout.

Variation

Have a 3 v 2 situation in zones 2 and 4 with 1 centre back and 2 full backs. This will make it easier to build up and receive a forward pass.

Coaching Points

The Full Backs:

1. Don't control the ball too far away to the side, as this will limit your options.
2. Control the ball in such a way that you are ready to play immediately - always look if you can pass the ball forward.
3. Try to pass to the striker - the eye contact between the full back and the forward are decisive for the moment of calling for the ball.
4. Search for contact with the forwards (wingers or striker) in front of you:
 - Pass the ball precisely and powerfully along the ground to a forward at the moment they move away from a defender or when they move from the side.
 - Only pass the ball to a forward in front of you if he makes a run in behind or you can pass it to his feet so he can turn and face the defender.
 - If a forward moves diagonally inside from the sideline, then pass the ball into the space in front of him.
 - Don't pass the ball to a forward's feet if he's marked closely near the sideline.
5. If you don't make an early pass, cut past your opponent at the moment he approaches you at full speed.
6. Immediately dribble into the space in front of you after cutting. A 2 v 1 situation will arise or one forward drags his marker away, making it a 1 v 1.

The Striker:

1. Search for eye contact with the players building up.
2. Recognise the moment (reception, looking around, time) to call for the ball.
3. Don't let the defender hold on to you, feel where he is positioned, use your arms to stay out of the duel.
4. Remain as advanced as possible, make yourself available by going to the right/left as much as possible instead of running straight towards the ball from a distance.
5. Make runs in behind the defender's back.
6. Make the right decisions on the ball by either shielding it or using one touch to maintain possession.
7. If a 2 v 1 situation arises, finish at a high pace but also take the offside rule into account.

The Wingers:

1. Come to the ball if you're marked closely (create space in behind) and then start to move.
2. Start the move deep, diagonally inside to receive the ball there.
3. Only call for the ball to your feet at the moment you can get free from a defender (checking away before moving to receive) and then you can confront him head on.
4. Turn and advance at the moment you receive the ball - on the half turn.

Building Up Play from the Back in an 8 v 8 Small Sided Game



Objective: We work on the collaboration between the defenders and midfielders to practice building up play from the back.

Description

In this 8 v 8 small sided game we use the area in between the 2 penalty areas as shown. Both teams are using a 3-2-2 formation with 1 centre back (5), 2 full backs (2 & 3), 2 central midfielders (8 & 10) & 2 wingers (7 & 11).

The practice always starts with the orange team's goalkeeper. The aim for the orange team is to build up play from the back using good combinations and movements to score. If they are able to build up play and score without the blue team touching the ball, the goal counts double.

The blue team aim to win the ball and then score themselves. If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, start again from the orange team's goalkeeper.

Winning Moment

Give the orange team 5-10 attempts to build up play from the goalkeeper and keep count of the score. After this reverse the team roles and give the blue team 5-10 attempts to build up play from their goalkeeper.

The team that scores the most goals after both teams have had all their attempts wins the game. Remember that goals scored by building up play (short or long build-up) from the goalkeeper without the opposition touching the ball count double.

CHAPTER 7

ATTACKING

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Attacking and Creating Opportunities

An Attack Starts the Moment a Player (with the Ball) Facing Goal is able to Create an Opportunity

The build-up will turn into an attack from the moment that a player (with the ball at his feet) is facing the opposition goal and in a position where he's able to create an opportunity.

The attack can start a little deeper, but is most often in the opposition's half. The situation may be that the opposition have pressed high up the pitch using their forwards. In our own half, we then break through the pressure and subsequently have an open player ready to receive in the opposition's half, facing their goal.

The next step is to play a pass in behind the opposition's defensive line, so we can get one of our attackers in a promising position to create a goal scoring opportunity.



In the diagram example, the central midfielder (6) is in possession and passes to the No.10. The striker (9) makes a run to receive in behind and finish on goal.

Positional Play in the Attacking Phase

All players should have the chance to join in the attacking play. For instance, a full back who receives the ball should be encouraged to participate in the attack.

Positional play is essential when attacking, as the individual solutions of a player have to be stimulated and highlighted. Cutting past your opponent, creating space to receive the ball and winning 1 v 1 duels are all examples of this. During well executed positional play, we look to create a numerical advantage in midfield or a 1 v 1 situation in the front line.

During the final stage of the attack, opportunities have to be created with the main focus on individual plays, one-two combinations, wing play and providing the right final pass/cross.



The Role of the Defence

The Centre Back Pushes Up



The centre back has 2 attacking options when pushing into midfield:

- **Play a Final Pass**

It could occur that a centre-back gets into a situation where he can provide a 'final pass' to the attacker, who in turn gets into a promising position. This can happen from your own half if the opposition presses, but also around the halfway line when put under a bit of pressure.

- **Carry the Ball Forward or Play a One-Two Combination to Join in Attack**

If our centre back who has pushed up experiences only a little pressure from the opposition, then he can decide to join in the attack. This can happen with a dribble or a one-two combination with a teammate (as shown in diagram example).

The players will have difficulty recognising this particular situation, so the coach needs to be clear and precise in his coaching, making sure not to include too much detail. An important element which requires attention when training for this situation is the creation of space by at least one midfielder (No.10 in diagram) at the same time the striker receives the ball. No.10 moves in the opposite direction, providing space for the centre back (4) to move forward and receive the return pass.

The Full Back Receives Unmarked and Carries the Ball Forward



• The Full Back Joins in the Attack

If a full back is unmarked and receives the ball in the build-up, with space in front of them, the follow-up could be a dribble, combination or pass. The players definitely need to have the freedom to go for an individual play and beat an opponent in a 1 v 1 duel.

The full backs can perform the same role if they intercept the ball from an opponent and have time to attack, especially in the opposition's half.

• The Defence Push Forward when the Other Players Attack

The players have to learn how to cope with big distances on a full pitch. Therefore, the coach should ensure that the defence (including the goalkeeper) push forward when the forwards are attacking in the opposition's half. They must not become spectators so need to close the gap to stay active and in position for the game. The coach could make the goalkeeper or one of the defenders responsible for this aspect.

The Role of the Midfield

Midfield Passing: Pass in Behind on the Flank



An important task for every midfielder is to provide the forwards with useful passes.

If the strength isn't present yet, then this will often be a pass over a small distance. However, many players will already be capable of playing a through ball or deep pass behind the opposition's defence.

In this example the winger (7) checks back and then makes a run in behind the left back (5). The central midfielder (6) plays a through pass high up on the flank and in behind the blue's defensive line.

Midfield Passing: Combination Play with the Forwards



In this diagram we show the different passing combination possibilities for the central midfielder (8).

Particularly in situations when the team have just won the ball, the midfielder can then attempt to link up with the forwards (2 wingers & a striker). As the forwards are often in 1 v 1 situations, the ball can be worked in behind the defensive line to create a goal scoring chance.

In this example, No.8 combines with the striker (9) and can then pass to either winger (7 or 11) in behind.

Midfield Passing: Through Pass Options



The main way we look to create scoring opportunities is via through passes from midfield.

By means of a through pass or individual play, each midfielder can be an immediate threat to the opposition.

In this example, No.10 has the ball and can use individual play (option 2) or play a through ball (options 1, 3 & 4).

Midfield Passing: Well Timed Pass for No.10's Advanced Run



In this example, the central midfielder No.8 has possession of the ball and has his head up, facing the opposition's goal.

The left winger (11) and the striker (9) move in opposite directions and drag away their markers.

No.10 makes a diagonal run into the space created at the right time and receives the forward pass from No.8.

Midfield Passing: Well Timed Pass for Central Midfielder's Run from Deep



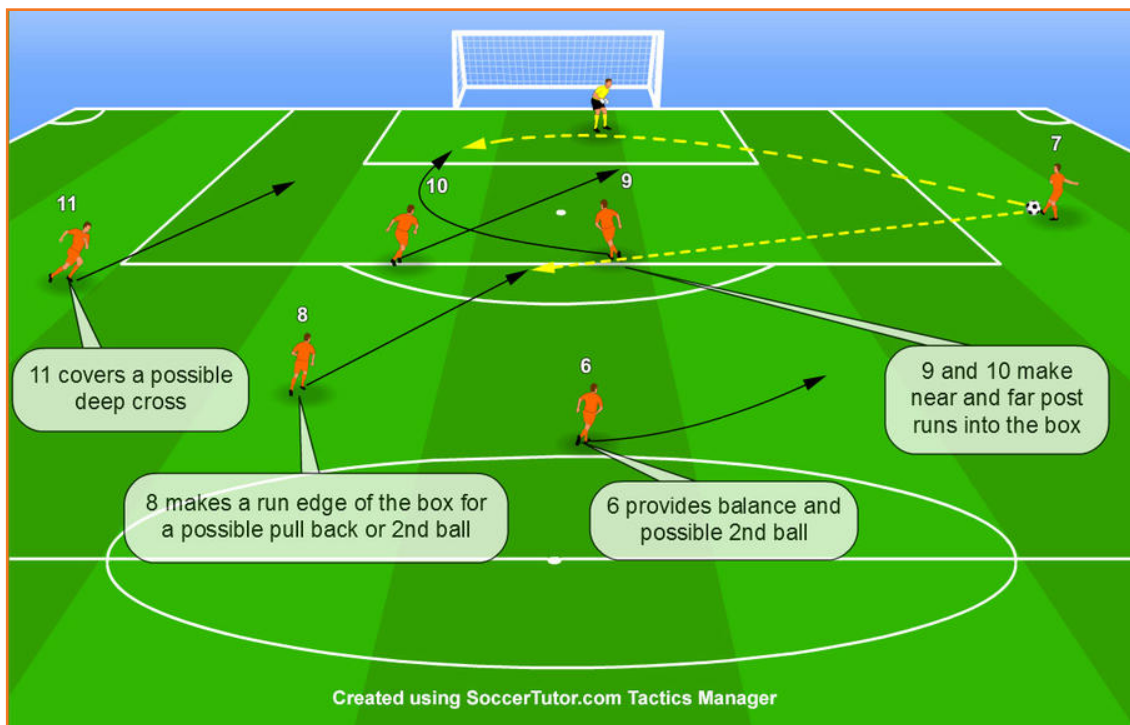
The most difficult thing about executing this is recognising 'the right moment'. The decision has to be taken in a split-second and the timing is crucial.

In this example, the No.10 is in a central position with possession of the ball. The left winger (11) drops back and the striker (9) moves towards the right side. They are both able to drag their markers away and create the space highlighted. At the right moment, the central midfielder No.8 runs forward into this space created. No.10 passes to him and he receives in a very promising position to create a goal scoring opportunity.

Sooner or later, a coach in this age group will find out which players have the feeling and vision to execute this. He should however give them the opportunity to develop themselves regarding this aspect.

During small sided games, a good youth coach can see who's playing conservatively and who does unexpected things. Initially you try to develop everything with every player at a younger age, but eventually each player wants to stay close to his natural preference.

Winger Crosses from Out Wide: Movement and Positioning



When a wide player is preparing to cross the ball into the penalty area, these are the important aspects that the supporting players must focus on:

- Front/Back Post Runs in Front of Goal:** This is normally the striker (9) and No.10 who make these runs to finish in front of goal. It is important that they communicate so that players do not make the same run. Explain to the players that they must not get too close to each other, but should rather divide themselves throughout the area. 'Pay attention to where your teammates are!'
- Occupy the Second Line:** For a ball that has been pulled back, the so-called second ball has to be won and can then be utilised by taking a shot from distance. No.8 fulfills this role in the diagram example.
- Control the Area outside the Box:** The defensive midfielder (or deepest midfielder at the time) ensures balance and collects the ball if it is cleared and tracks opposition players' runs if needed. This is No.6 in the diagram.

The Role of the Attack

Wing Play: Coming Short to Receive or Running in Behind



The 3 forwards (7, 9 and 11) should keep the pitch as big as possible. Players are often very 'enthusiastic' and ball-orientated. The downside to this is that they sometimes get in each other's way unintentionally. The basic principle we need to teach the players is to 'keep distances between each other' if your team has possession.

To teach youth players how to play football in an 11 v 11 game, playing with real wingers is preferred. That's what's most familiar to youth players. It's therefore logical that the team consciously tries to attack through the flanks. There are 2 key movements to teach wingers when their team are in possession:

- Move to Receive on the Flank:** The winger drops back towards play to receive. Depending on the situation, he can simply maintain possession for the team or turn towards the opposition goal and attack (either with a forward pass or by dribbling).
- Fake to Receive Short, then Quickly Make a Run in Behind:** This is particularly effective if the full back is marking the winger closely. The winger makes a short explosive preliminary action to drag his marker with him. He then quickly changes direction and makes an advanced run, with his opponent unable to react in time. If the defender is not marking the defender closely, then it's often better to fake the advanced run and then drop to receive a pass in space.

Wing Play: Individual Play (Outside/Inside)



It is very important for forwards to show initiative, using individual play and one-two combinations in the front line. The coach plays a big role as mistakes should be allowed as these skills are developed.

The coach should encourage his players to take the initiative and reward/praise them afterwards if they are successful or tell them it will work better next time if they are unsuccessful. You might even say that during a match, mistakes can never be made too often. This may sound a bit strange, but the underlying idea is that the coach should keep stimulating his players. At the time when this finally leads to success, you have developed players who can make the difference and force a breakthrough in a match.

In the example shown in the diagram, the central midfielder (6) passes to the right winger (7) near the sideline. As he is closed down by the blue left back (3), he can decide to beat him on the inside or outside. It is important to first feint to go one way and then quickly take the ball in the other direction.

Whether the winger (7) decides to go inside or outside may also depend on the defender's body shape. Either way, the winger will have options to create goal scoring opportunities - pass in behind, cross, shoot etc.

Wing Play: One-Two Combinations



In this example the centre back (4) passes to the left winger (11) near the sideline. He makes a movement back to drop back for the pass and then plays a 1-2 combination with the central midfielder (8) who moves inside.

The winger (11) drops back to first create an angle for the pass and the blue right back (2) follows him. The central midfielder (8) moves across and the winger plays a first time pass inside to him - the winger (11) immediately changes direction and makes a quick run into the space behind the blue right back (2). The central midfielder (8) plays a first time pass (second pass in the 1-2 combination) and the winger receives in space behind the defensive line.

From this point, the winger is in a dangerous position and can create goal scoring opportunities.

It is of course mainly the forwards that are given opportunities during an attack to provide a final pass or cross. This is why it's one of their most important tasks for which they should be assessed. Coaches have to train the players in regards to the technique of a final pass or a cross, which includes the direction, the timing and the weight of pass.

For crosses, you will also have to encourage wingers to have the 'urge' during matches to deliver crosses. They shouldn't play football dutifully on the sideline, but really have the intention to deliver the cross (or approach the goal themselves).

Midfielder and Striker Combine (Providing a Final Pass or Cross)



Although the striker often has to act as a target man for the team, you must also stimulate the players so they keep going for an individual play. The same applies to the central midfielders as well, and in particular, the No.10. It may (and will) go wrong a couple times per match but we want to encourage the players to keep trying.

In addition to the individual plays, the striker (9) should also pay attention to his teammates, and especially the combination with the No.10 which will occur often.

In the diagram example, the deeper central midfielder (6) has the ball and the striker move towards the ball (taking his marker with him) - this allows the No.10 to make a forward run into the space that he has created. If the striker's marker (blue centre back No.5) does not follow his movement, he can receive and turn.

If the passing angle was not on directly from No.6 to No.10, the ball can still be played to No.10 via a pass to the striker (9). The striker could play a first time pass back to No.6 who moves forward and then plays the pass in behind to No.10.

There are many different variations and possibilities for different combinations, which can be discussed and practiced in training.

Midfielder and Striker Combine with a Third Man Run



In this example, the central midfielder (6) passes the ball to the No.10. As the ball is travelling to No.10, the striker (9) makes a horizontal run to receive a first time pass on the run. If he has successfully evaded his marker, he can attack the goal and try to score.

- Making the Right Movements in Front of Goal:** Although you want to give your players lots of freedom, it cannot become the case that they don't have to pay attention to anything and anyone but themselves. You can definitely practice basic combinations and runs like the example above. Another example is when a player is out wide ready to deliver a cross. You can give your players instructions for different runs to make - e.g. the striker runs to the near post, the No.10 moves to the penalty spot and the winger on the opposite side runs to the far post.

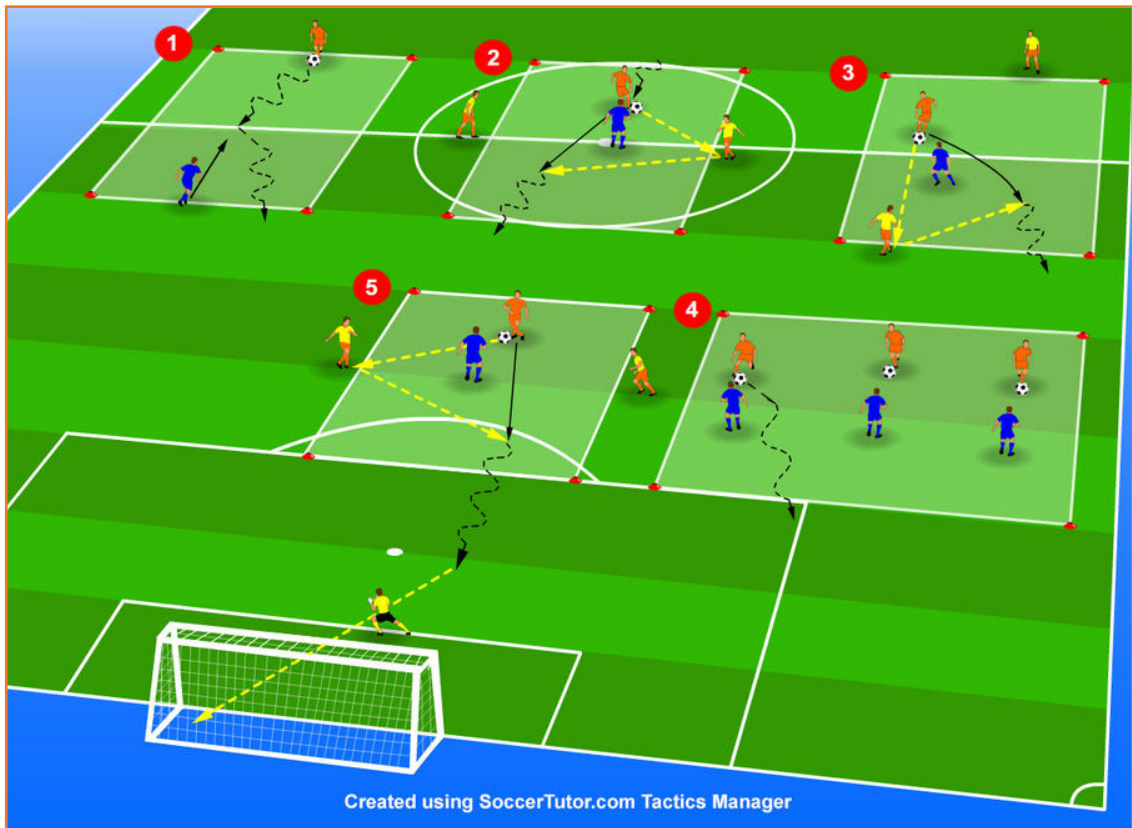
At this age group many successful attacks still depend on luck, but after a couple of years on a full pitch, the patterns will sooner or later become visible.

- Scoring Ability (Finishing):** Last but not least, always make this clear. This is the main job of the forwards when we are attacking. Finishing is defined as the forwards' expertise and is simply the ability to score goals. There is an element of instinct and natural talent, but we can also improve players considerably by training to score and coaching during matches, regarding this aspect.

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Individual Play and One-Two Combinations in a 5 Zone Warm Up



Objective: To develop beating opponents with individual play or one-two combinations.

Description

Using a full size pitch, we mark out 5 different areas as shown, with different situations. The size of the areas is key as you have to enable the 'move' to be made. If you make the pitch too small, then it will become difficult to get around somebody. The main purpose is for the players to beat their opponent or go for a one-two combination.

1. 1 v 1 Duel

Zone 1 is simple, with 1 attacker and 1 defender. Both players start on the end lines. The attacker tries to dribble past the defender and the defender tries to win the ball. The risk exists that the players don't confront each other frontally; the result is that there will be more physical duels.

2. 1 v 1 Duel (+ 2 Outside Wide Players)

In this variation of zone 1, we now add 2 players on the sides. They play with 1 touch and enable the attacker to play a quick one-two and receive in behind the defender.

3. 1 v 1 Duel (+ 2 Outside End Players)

The outside players are now at the ends. The attacker needs to pass forward and create an angle to receive back.

4. 1 v 1 Duels with Multiple Pairs in One Space.

In zone 4 we have a wider area and have 3 pairs all in 1 v 1 duels. The risk exists that the players don't confront each other frontally; the result is that there will be more physical duels.

5. 1 v 1 Duel with or without Outside Players + Finishing 1 v 1 with Goalkeeper

This is the same as zone 2, but now when the attacker dribbles through the end line, he runs at goal and tries to score past the goalkeeper.

After each zone, the pair (attacker and defender) move to the next zone. In zone 4 they move along and complete 3 duels.

Variations

1. 2 v 2 practices.
2. Small and multiple goals to score in.

Coaching Points

1. Move the ball at pace, dribble with the instep of your foot.
2. Dribble towards one side to make space for your play - the defender will have to take action (commit).
3. Look over the ball when dribbling.
4. The closer you get to the defender, the more the ball has to be tied to your feet like a string.
5. Perform a feint or pass at the right time. If executed too early, the defender will not fall for it or if it's too late, then you get too close to the defender, which enables him to intercept the ball.
6. Clarify which feints or passing moves they can use.
7. Make use of the outside players don't pass the ball from too far away (distance to the defender) because then you're not really outplaying the defender.
8. Accelerate quickly into space after you've played the ball to an outside player and receive the pass back on the move (with a directional first touch).

Individual Play in a Continuous 1 v 1 Practice



Objective: To work on getting past your opponent with individual play (and quick reactions/transitions).

Description

Mark out an area 15 x 20 yards. We have a 1 v 1 situation inside the area and a total of 4 players.

The attacker (orange) starts by running with the ball into play. His aim is to beat the blue defender, dribble the ball past him and score in the small goal (1 point). The blue defender tries to stop him, intercept the ball (1 point) and score in the opposite goal (1 point).

If the orange attacker is successful and scores a goal, the blue defender then moves to receive a pass from their teammate, as shown in the diagram. After receiving, they attack the goal at the opposite end. The orange attacker has to make a transition to defence and try to stop the blue player from scoring.

Play a maximum of 1 minute at a time as this continuous practice is very hard work. The 2 outside players then move inside the area to compete against each other.

Variations

1. Play 2 v 2.
2. Use larger goals with goalkeepers

Escape from Defender + Score 1 v 1 versus the Goalkeeper



Objective: Wrong decisions are made during the 1 v 1 situation with the goalkeeper. Because of this, not enough goals are scored. We use this practice to improve scoring in this situation under pressure.

Description

For this practice we play in an area the width of the penalty area and length of half a pitch. We mark out a square in the middle of the pitch (7 x 7 yards) and have 2 full size goals with goalkeepers.

The players start in their teams facing each other at opposite sides of the square. The practice starts when the orange player calls for the ball and the blue defender passes into the square. The blue defender can start defending from the moment he passes the ball to the attacker.

The orange attacker must then choose which goal to attack. He dribbles towards one goal and tries to score past the goalkeeper. The defender and goalkeeper try to stop him from scoring. If the defender wins the ball, he then attacks the opposite goal.

If the orange attacker is successful and scores a goal, the blue defender then moves to receive a pass from their teammate, as shown in the diagram. After receiving, they attack the goal at the opposite end. The orange attacker has to make a transition to defence and try to stop the blue player from scoring.

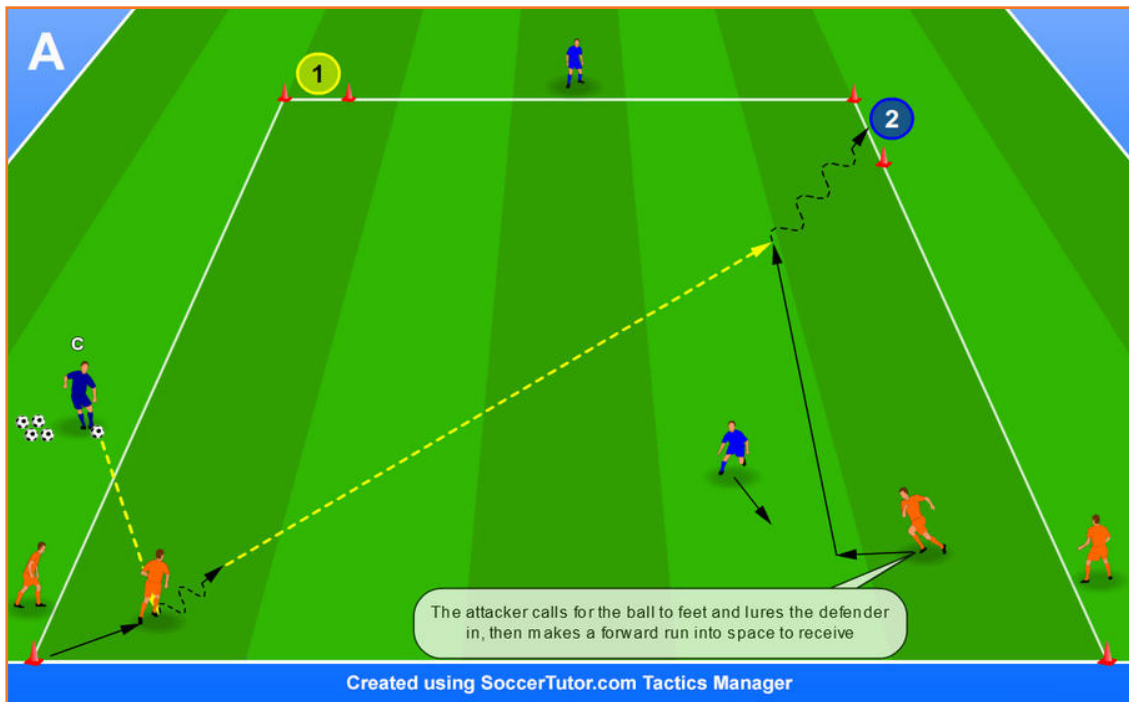
Variations

1. Adjust the distances to the goals to suit your training. You can also adjust the distance at which the defender and attacker start away from each other.
2. Starting from a different area so the players can practice this situation from different angles and distances.
3. The defender starts just behind the forward but does not try to intercept the first pass. As soon as the pass is received, the defender can then defend with 100% effort.
4. For younger players the emphasis can also be put on feints, cutting, changing direction. You can use smaller distances and smaller goals.

Coaching Points

1. From the moment the forward moves out of the square, his choices depend strongly on the situation.
2. Make sure to always shield the ball from the defender.
3. When there is space behind the goalkeeper, maintain your pace with the ball and dribble the ball around the goalkeeper.
4. If you get close to the goal and the goalkeeper approaches, then you have a number of options:
 - Shoot hard and high (goalkeepers often make themselves big with their hands low).
 - Pass the ball between the legs of the goalkeeper.
 - Chip the ball over the goalkeeper if he moves (quickly) to the ground - try to feint/fake a shot first.
5. If there is a larger distance between the goalkeeper and the attacker, shoot the ball hard and low in the corner.

Movement With and Without the Ball (A): Call for Ball to Feet + Run Forward into Space



Objective: To improve runs (movement) without the ball and running with the ball. In particular, the wingers need to learn to receive the ball to feet or make an advanced run. They need to recognise the situation.

Description

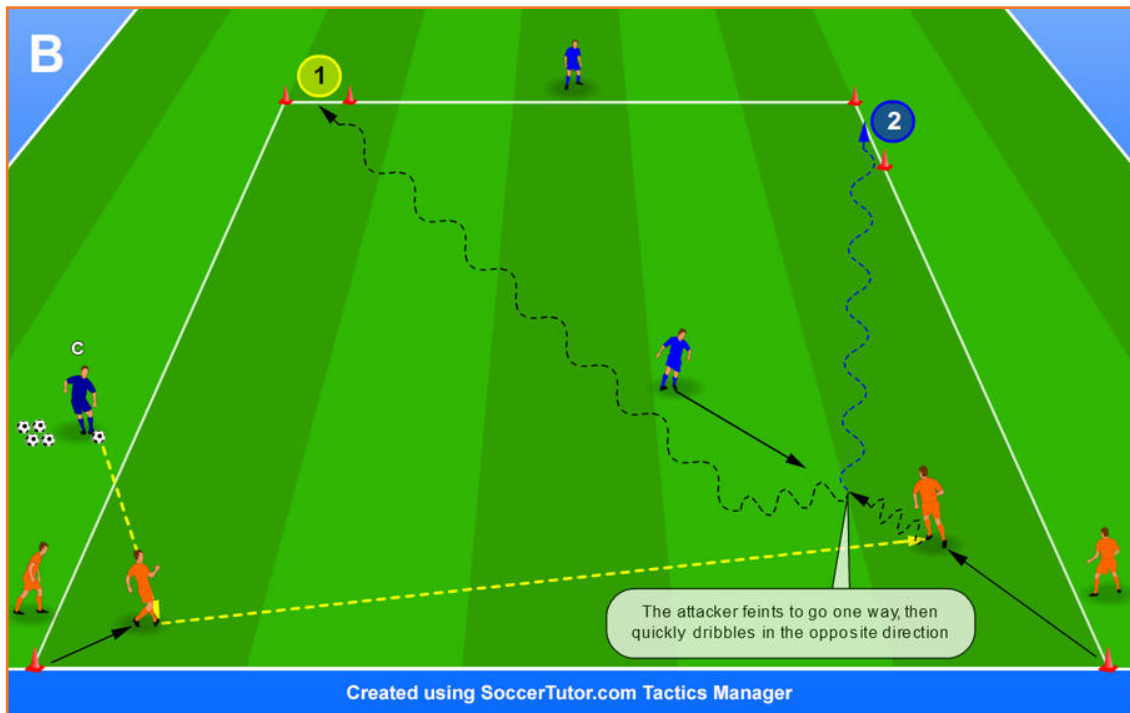
In a 25 x 35 yard area we mark out 2 small cone gates (1 & 2) in the positions shown. This set up is used to practice a series of different moves and combinations with the players' starting positions changing each time - other examples (B -> E) are shown on the following pages. There are 2 blue defenders and a maximum of 3 orange pairs - each pair consists of a defender/midfielder and a forward.

A coach starts the practice by passing into the area. The aim for the orange pair is to use their combination effectively and then dribble the ball through a cone gate to score (1 point). The 1 blue defender inside the area tries to win the ball (1 point). Depending on the situation, the forward makes a run and the player with the ball passes it to the forward. The exact instructions for variation A (above) are described below.

Instructions (A)

1. The forward is 'marked closely' by the defender and has space in front of him:
2. Act as if you call for the ball to your feet (preliminary action) and start to move towards the ball.
3. Approach the ball carefully during the preliminary action (luring in the opponent) and then sprint away.
4. You can launch yourself inside or up the sideline. Call for the ball to indicate that you need to receive it NOW!
5. The pass needs to be perfectly timed with the correct weight. Maintain the pace at the moment you receive the ball and take a tight directional first touch towards the gate you want to dribble through.

Movement With and Without the Ball (B): Receive, Feint + Dribble Past Defender



Description

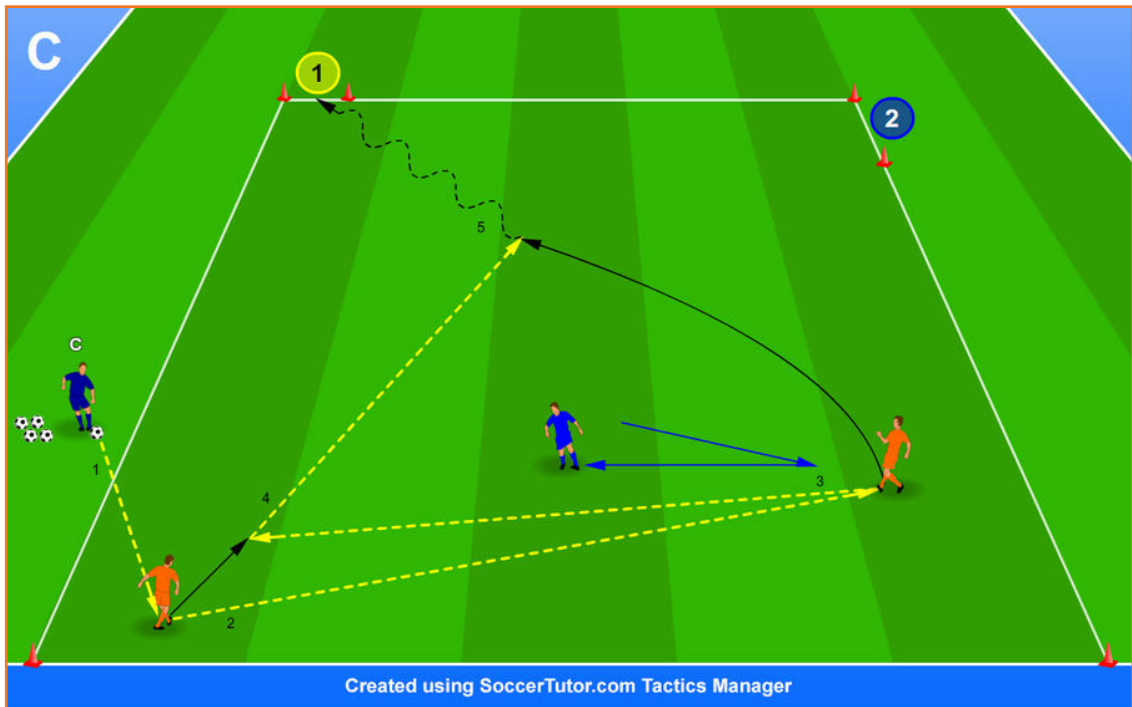
This is a variation of the previous practice (A) with the same set up. Depending on the situation, the forward makes a movement and the player with the ball passes it to the forward. The exact instructions for variation B (above) are described below.

Instructions (B)

1. The forward is not marked closely so you can't surprise the defender with an advanced run.
2. Threaten to go deep but call for the ball to your feet.
3. Control the ball in a forward direction at pace.
4. Keep the ball close to your feet at the time the defender approaches you closely.
5. Perform your feint or move to beat the defender at the right time (if the defender steps in, he shouldn't be allowed to get to it).
6. If you want to get past the defender on the inside, then first feint to go outside with the ball in order to make space for the move inside, and vice versa.
7. Once past the defender, accelerate away with the ball towards the nearest cone gate.

Variation: Add a small goal for the defender to score in if he wins the ball (or dribble across line to score).

Movement With and Without the Ball (C): Receive + One-Two Combination with Curved Run



Description

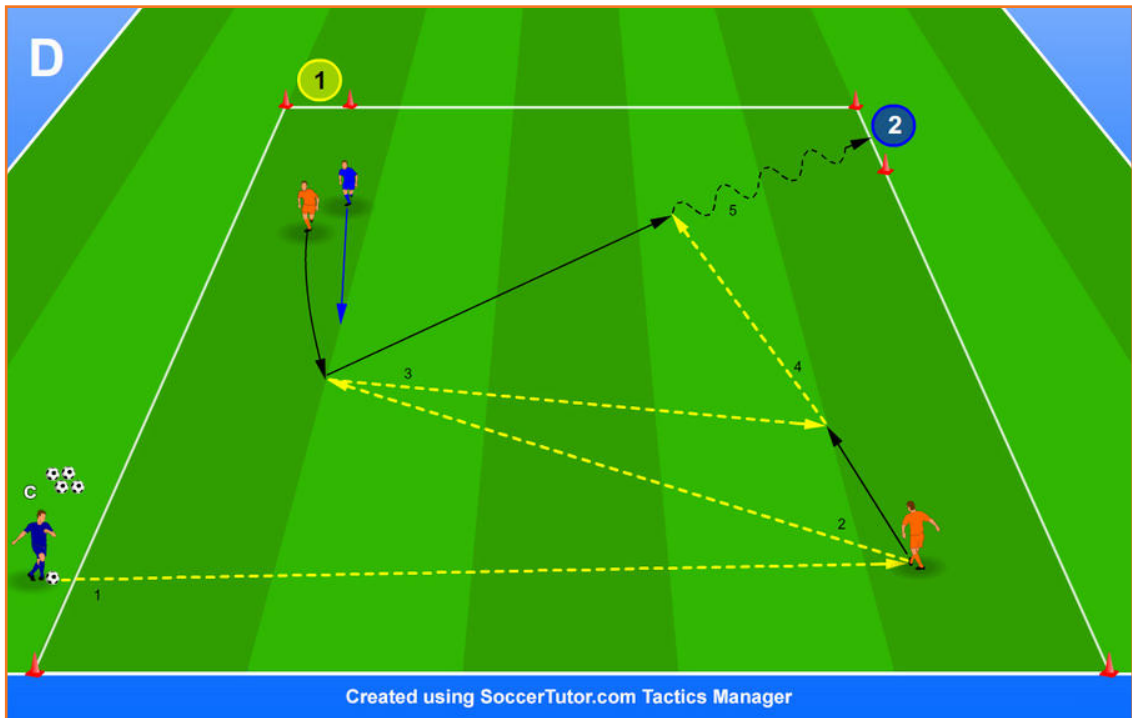
This is a variation of the previous 2 practices (A & B) with the same set up. Depending on the situation, the forward makes a movement and the player with the ball passes it to the forward. The exact instructions for variation C (above) are described below.

Instructions (C)

1. The forward is not marked closely but the defender is 'alert' and closes in directly once the first pass reaches the forward.
2. Play the ball first time (1 touch) back to your teammate, in a way that doesn't allow the defender to intercept it. The defender will be drawn to your teammate and shift across.
3. Immediately after passing the ball, make an advanced curved run into the space behind the defender.
4. The orange teammate (defender or midfielder) then plays the ball first time into the space before the blue defender is able to move into a position to intercept the ball.
5. The pass needs to be perfectly timed with the correct weight.
6. Maintain the pace at the moment you receive the ball and take a tight directional first touch towards the gate you want to dribble through.

Variation: Add a small goal for the defender to score in if he wins the ball (or dribble across line to score).

Movement With and Without the Ball (D): Drop Deep to Receive, + One-Two Combination



Description

This is a variation of the previous practices with the same set up. Depending on the situation, the forward makes a movement and the player with the ball passes it to the forward. The exact instructions for variation D (above) are described below.

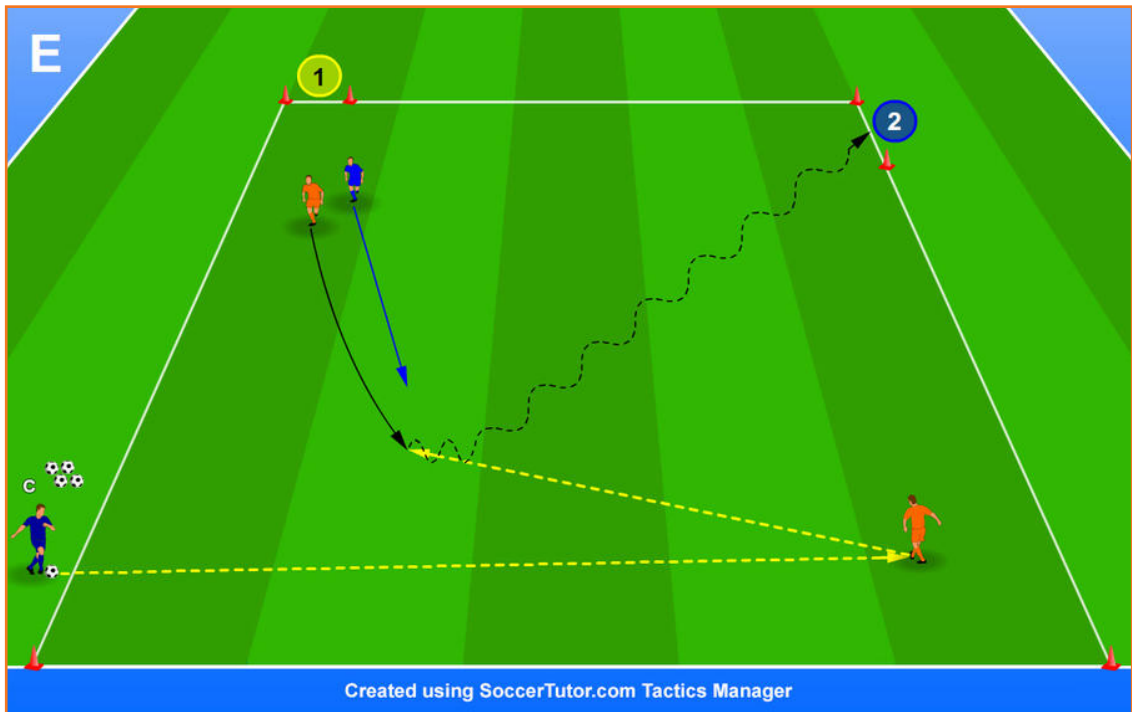
The orange forward and the blue defender start in advanced positions in this variation, as shown in the diagram.

Instructions (D)

1. As the orange forward and the blue defender are both high up, the other orange player (defender or midfielder) receives the pass from the coach in plenty of space.
2. The orange forward drops back and is followed by his marker. He calls for the ball to his feet.
3. As the defender is following closely behind, the orange forward plays a first time pass (1 touch) back into the path of his teammate. Use the inside of the foot for this 1 touch pass as it is easier to play back.
4. As soon as this pass is made, sprint away into the space as shown in the diagram.
5. The final pass must be out in front of the orange forward so he can run onto it.
6. Maintain the pace at the moment you receive the ball and take a tight directional first touch towards the gate you want to dribble through.

Variation: Add a small goal for the defender to score in if he wins the ball (or dribble across line to score).

Movement With and Without the Ball (E): Drop Deep to Receive, Turn + Dribble



Description

This is a variation of the previous practices with the same set up. Depending on the situation, the forward makes a movement and the player with the ball passes it to the forward. The exact instructions for variation E (above) are described below.

Instructions (E)

1. This is the same as variation D, but now the forward doesn't pass back. Instead he turns with the ball and beats his opponent in one move:
2. Assess where the defender is positioned - do you have to go past him on the inside or outside?
3. Make all movements at a high pace. The turn and dribble should be at the same speed as the sprint back to receive - maintain this to successfully get away from your marker and score.

Variation: Add a small goal for the defender to score in if he wins the ball (or dribble across line to score).

Receiving with Back to Goal, Turning and Finishing in a 1 v 1 Situation



Objective: In this age group, forwards struggle in and around the box when receiving the ball with their back to goal. This practice teaches them to receive a pass, hold the ball, create space, turn and get into position to finish.

Description

For this practice we play in an area the width of the penalty area and length of half a pitch. There is 1 full size goal with a goalkeeper, 2 cone gates at the sides and 2 small goals on the halfway line. The players work in pairs (1 orange attacker/1 blue defender). The pairs wait ready on the edge of the penalty area.

The practice starts when the orange attacker calls for the ball from his teammate - the blue defender marks him from behind. The orange player tries to receive the pass and then score past the goalkeeper.

The defender can initially try to intercept the pass. Otherwise he tries to hold up the attacker and prevent him from creating space, turning and scoring. If the defender wins the ball, he can then dribble through one of the cone gates (1 point) or score in one of the small goals (2 points).

If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, the attacker can then immediately request a new ball from a teammate. Play for 45-60 seconds and then the next pair enter.

Variations

1. You can perform the exact same practice with a 2 v 2 situation for 60-75 seconds at a time.
2. Remove the goals and challenge the players to dribble the ball across an end line to score.
3. Instead of a full size goal with a goalkeeper, the forward tries to score in one of two small goals.

Coaching Points

1. Call for the ball and signal exactly where you want it played.
2. Keep your body between the defender and the ball, shielding it.
3. Keep the ball in motion which forces the defender to choose different positions repeatedly and offers an opportunity to turn.
4. Use your arm to feel where the defender is and turn away from him at the right moment e.g. when you notice that he's too eager to win the ball from behind.
5. Make use of your arm to use the defender as (some sort of) a turning point.
6. Turn at once if the defender is (too) close or still - be at full speed and in forward motion.
7. If the path of the ball is free, finish!
8. Make sure to use both feet throughout the practice.

Creating Opportunities with the Striker's Back to Goal (2 v 2 / 3 v 2)



Objective

To improve the striker's play on the ball when he has his back to goal, in order to create more goal scoring opportunities. This practice is designed to improve his decision making, showing the various options.

Description

For this practice we play in the width of the penalty area and length of half a pitch. There is 1 full size goal with a goalkeeper, 2 cone gates at the sides and 2 small goals on the halfway line. We have 5 orange players (attackers) and 5 blue players (defenders). 4 outfield players and the goalkeeper participate in the practice, while the other players wait to go next.

The practice starts with an orange player from the central cone. The striker is positioned on the edge of the penalty area with a defender in his back. At the moment he calls for the ball, he receives a pass from his teammate who then moves forward to join the attack.

As soon as the first pass is played, a second blue defender can move off his cone to help defend (as shown in diagram). The striker has to then make a quick decision. Should he drop the ball back, take a touch and pass into the space out wide or control and turn towards goal himself? The aim is to score past the goalkeeper.

The first blue defender should initially allow the striker to receive the ball, although they can defend at 100% as soon as this happens. If the blue defenders win the ball, they can then dribble through one of the cone gates (1 point) or score in one of the small goals (2 points).



In this diagram we show a variation. There are 2 orange attacking players positioned out wide (wingers) and the second blue defender now starts on the central cone. The first pass is now played to the striker from a wide position and we have a 3 v 2 situation for the attack. This increases the striker's options.

The key to success in this practice is a high speed of play. Keep the ball moving and utilise the numerical advantage.

Coaching Points

The Striker:

1. You can pass the ball first time back to the player in your eye-line. Then move quickly to make yourself available for the next pass.
2. Keep your body between the defender and the ball.
3. Make contact with the defender, put your arm on the side of where you plan to turn.
4. Turn away from the defender at the moment he's positioned incorrectly in regards to you or is too eager to try and win the ball.
5. When turning, make use of a feint or movement.
6. During the 3 v 2 situation, you have to keep an eye on the other player that joins in.
7. Watch out for offside traps, especially when the defender moves forward to contest the ball.

The Support Player/s:

1. Pass to the striker in a way that enables him to keep his body between the defender and the ball (back foot).
2. Join attack after passing the ball, but stay in his eye-line. During the 3 v 2 attack (second diagram), one winger stays in the striker's eye-line and the other one makes an advanced run.

Individual Play and One-Two Combinations in a 2 (+2) v 2 (+GK) Practice



Description

We use an area double the size of the penalty area and split it into 2 zones. We play 2 v 2 (+ 2 outside players) in zone 1. The orange pair must beat the defenders with individual play or via a pass from an outside player within zone 1. Once they have done this, 1 orange player can then move into zone 2 and try to score past the goalkeeper (1 point). The defenders can only defend in zone 1. If they win the ball they score a point.

Coaching Points

1. Dribble to one side making the defender to follow, creating space to make a decisive play on the other side.
2. Make the feint or pass at the right time - if it's too far away then it's too predictable, and if you get too close to the defender he can intercept the ball.
3. Pass the ball to the outside players with the outside of the foot. You pass the ball with the outside of your right foot to the player on your right. This enables you to maintain your speed better and makes it more difficult for the defender to recognise that you will start a one-two combination. This type of pass with the outside of the foot is also more difficult to intercept.
4. Pass the ball to the outside player on his inner leg, because then he can let the roll across in front of him. The result is gaining more precious time and making it easier to pass it back.
5. Encourage enthusiasm after a successful play or score. Players in this age group need to be stimulated to search for individual solutions, even if it sometimes leads to mistakes.

Exploiting a Numerical Advantage in a 3 Team Transition Game



Objective

There is often a problem in matches during an attack or counter attack, wherein we have an advantage (1 player more) but we are not successful in exploiting the situation well to score. This practice works on this aspect.

Description

For this practice we play in an area the width of the penalty area and length of half a pitch. We have 3 teams of 3 (+ 2 GKs) and full size goals.

The practice starts with a goalkeeper's pass to the orange team who start a 3 v 2 attack and try to score.

The blue players try to win the ball and then score themselves. The third blue player waits outside with a ball at his feet but does not take part in this phase.

As soon as the orange team's attack is over or the ball goes out of play, the third blue player dribbles a new ball onto the pitch and starts a 3 v 3 counter attack for his team. When this second phase finishes, the practice starts again with the outside team (yellows) who start a new 3 v 2 attack against either the oranges or blues.

Variations

1. Start with 2 v 1 attacks and progress to 3 v 2 and 4 v 3.
2. Introduce a time limit so the teams have to score within e.g. 10 seconds.
3. You can use small goals without goalkeepers.

Coaching Points (Attack)

1. Maintain a high speed of play during the attack.
2. Don't pass the ball redundantly, look around and decide on the best ball to beat your opponent.
3. Control the ball in such a way that it creates space for the overlap - move from outside to inside to receive the ball which creates space for a teammate to run around the defender.
4. Coach the players to pass the ball to the player who makes a run around a defender (overlap).
5. When passing it to the player who makes an overlapping run, coach 'the moment' to pass in relation to the position of the defenders and the offside line. The third player should be aware of the situation and make a run in front of goal to finish.
6. When shooting, the other 2 attackers should anticipate the rebound.

Coaching Points (Counter Attack)

1. If you intercept the ball, assess your options - if you have space ahead of you then accelerate immediately with the ball at your feet.
2. If your teammate has space ahead of him, run quickly into a position that will make you available to receive the ball in the final stage.
3. If you are pressed immediately, pass the ball to a teammate or goalkeeper and sprint forward into space.
4. It is very important that the final pass is well timed and hit with the right pace in these type of situations.
5. Take the opposition's goalkeeper, who might come out of goal, into account.

Duels in and Around the Penalty Area to Create Scoring Opportunities (3 v 3)



Objective: To improve 1 v 1 play and combination play between the forwards in and around the penalty area.

Description

Here is a variation of the previous practice and we extend the size of the area, as shown. We now have a 3 v 3 situation for the attack in a third of a full pitch. The attacking team can select one 'target player' (limited to 2 touches) who the coach passes to. It's easier to change the direction of play this way and it becomes less intensive.

The practice starts when the orange striker calls for the ball from the coach - the defender marks him. The striker tries to receive the pass and then combine with the 2 wingers to score a goal.

If the orange attacking team score, the ball goes out of play or the blue defending team win the ball, the striker can then immediately request a new ball from the coach. Play for 75-90 seconds and then allow the players time to rest before restarting.

Variation: The defenders can score by passing the ball to the coach or by scoring in a small goal.

Coaching Points

1. See the coaching points for '1 v 1' on previous page.
2. Pay attention to the run of your teammate. Your aim is to get him into a 1 v 1 situation. If you're being double marked, you might even pass to him in a situation where he can finish with 1 touch.
3. Keep the ball moving at speed and stay away from the defensive line without the ball. This can create 2 v 1 situations.
4. If you receive out wide, pay attention to the position of your teammate in front of goal. He has to run into the area on time (ball between defender and goalkeeper) or pull out (ball pulled back behind the defender).

5. Continually coach the players as to whether they should pass or shoot in different situations.
6. As a winger, it is normally useful to offer an option back when the striker has his back to goal. However, if the defender marks you closely, then you can make a run in behind him.
7. If you get some space, then you're available to receive the ball to feet.
8. The striker has the choice to pass back for a teammate to shoot, pass in behind or turn and shoot himself.
9. If the winger has the ball on the sideline and is facing the goal, then as an additional option, as he can pass the ball inside to the forward and continue his movement to receive back in behind.
10. Threaten to go outside and come inside (or vice versa) with your run.

Creating Scoring Opportunities from the Flank in a 6 v 4 (+GK) Game



Objective: Creating scoring opportunities from wide areas within a positional practice.

Description

Within half a full pitch, we play a 6 v 4 (+GK) game. We mark out 2 wide zones as shown with 1 orange winger starting in each of them.

The orange team have 1 centre back (4), 2 central midfielders (6 & 8), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). The blue team have a goalkeeper, 1 centre back (4), 2 full backs (2 & 3) and 1 central midfielder (10).

The practice starts with the orange centre back (4) - the orange team build up play and attack through the flanks to create opportunities and score a goal. This is done by playing the ball wide to one of the wingers (7 or 11) in a side zone, who then attacks on the flank and crosses the ball into the penalty area for oncoming runners to finish.

The first touch of the winger is free. This gives time (and potentially space) for the winger to exploit and beat the defender, before crossing the ball into the penalty area for oncoming runners. Once the winger receives, there are no longer any restrictions in moving in/out of the side zones for either team.

Winning Moment: The blue defending team are 1-0 ahead and we play for 6 minutes. If the forwards score twice, they win. You can play a total of 4 x 6 minute scenarios.

Coaching Points

1. Play at a high tempo throughout with quick passing and movements.
2. Make sure there are coordinated runs into the penalty area to finish (near post, far post etc).

Creating Scoring Opportunities from the Flank in a 6 v 6 (+GK) Game



Objective: We work on combination play in the opposition's half and attacking from the flank with the wingers.

Description

Using half a full pitch, we have 1 full size goal with a goalkeeper and 2 small goals on the halfway line. We mark out a final zone in line with the edge of the penalty area. The orange team have 1 centre back (4), 2 central midfielders (6 & 8), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). The blue team have 3 central midfielders, 2 full backs and 1 centre back.

The practice starts with the orange centre back (4) and the orange team aim to pass the ball out wide to the winger. One of the wingers (7 or 11) or the striker (9) must dribble the ball across the line into the final zone before the team can finish their attack. The zone restrictions are removed from all players at this point.

The focus is on passing to the winger, who dribbles into the final zone and crosses the ball into the penalty area - if a goal is scored this way it counts double. If the blue defending team win the ball, they try to score in one of the small goals on the halfway line.

By altering the formation of the defending team, the difficulty level of the practice can be increased or decreased.

Coaching Points

1. The orange team want to create a 1 v 1 situation with one of their forwards vs a blue defender.
2. The forwards need to run in behind at the right time, beating the defender and attacking the space.

Retaining Possession & Attacking on the Flank after a Long Pass from the Goalkeeper in a SSG



Objective: Retain possession after a long pass from the keeper and creating scoring opportunities on the flank.

Description

Using a full pitch, we mark out our main playing area as shown. The orange team have 1 centre back (4), 3 central midfielders (6, 8 & 10), 2 wingers and 1 striker (9). The blue team defend in a 3-3 formation.

The practice starts with the goalkeeper outside of the main playing area and he has 2 options:

1. If there is space for a winger (7 or 11) then the goalkeeper opens up and plays a long pass.
2. He can also play it short to the central midfielders (6 or 8) who can then play the ball to the flank.

The aim for the orange team is to retain possession from the goalkeeper's pass and then attack on the flank to try and score. The blue team defend, try to win the ball and then score in the small goal at the other end. Have 10 repetitions starting from the goalkeeper. The team with the most goals wins.

Coaching Points

1. For a player who is good in the air, play a high ball.
2. For technical players with good ball control, play a precise pass into the space in front or at his body.

Coordinated Movements and Finishing from Crosses in a 2 Zone Game



Objective: We work on organisation and coordinated movements (different runs into the key areas of the penalty area) from a cross or set piece.

Description

Using half a full pitch, we divide the area into 2 halves and have 2 full size goals with goalkeepers. We have a 6 v 6 situation with the outfield players - 1 player from each team starts in zone 2 and the rest start in zone 1.

The practice starts with an orange player's cross from the side, as shown. However, before the cross is played the orange players should be making the following different movements/ runs to finish from the cross:

1. To the near post.
2. To the far post.
3. Near the penalty spot.
4. Covering/waiting for drop down at edge of penalty area.

This practice relies on good delivery and well timed runs to score - a headed goal counts double.

The blue team defend their goal and if they clear it, then try to counter attack and score at the other end. Every time a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, we start again with the orange player's cross.

Attacking on the Flank in an 8 v 8 Corner Zone Game



Objective: Creating a scoring opportunity through the flank.

Description

Using half a pitch we mark out 4 corner zones as shown in the diagram. There is a 5 v 5 situation in the main area. In each corner zone there is a winger. The other players are not allowed to enter these corner zones until the ball is played in there.

The practice starts with a goalkeeper who passes into the main area. The 4 players work the ball out wide. The winger moves to receive the ball within the corner zone and then get a cross into the penalty area - his teammates make runs to finish the attack. A regular goal scores 1 point and a goal from a winger's cross scores 2 points.

The defending team try to win the ball and then pass to their wingers in the corner zones with the same aim.

Coaching Points

1. Always search for the open player.
2. If an area becomes congested, switch play to the other side quickly.

Variation: You can remove the goalkeepers to make finishing attacks easier.

Creating Scoring Opportunities from the Flank in an 8 v 8 Small Sided Game



Description

Using an area 10 yards longer than half a full pitch, we play an 8 v 8 game with full sized goals. Both teams are using a 3-2-2 formation with 1 centre back (5), 2 full backs (2 & 3), 2 central midfielders (6 & 8) & 2 wingers (7 & 11). Most players are positioned in the middle zone, but both wingers of the team that start in possession (orange in diagram) start in the side zones as shown.

The practice always starts one team's goalkeeper and that team's wingers take up positions in the side zones. The team aim to build up play and pass to one of their wingers within the side zone. When they receive, their first touch is free - and then the blue players are allowed to contest the winger inside or outside the zone. The winger has 2 objectives and can choose which one to use depending on the situation:

1. Receive a pass, beat the defender on the outside and then cross into the penalty area (as shown in diagram).
2. Make a movement back (feint to receive to feet) and quickly run in behind to receive - either shoot or cross.

Teammates make supporting runs to finish on goal. Scoring with a header counts double. If the blue team win the ball, they launch a counter attack and try to score. If a team scores or kicks the ball out of play, start again from the other team's goalkeeper.

Coaching Points

1. The wingers need to make a movement in the opposite direction, before then moving to receive - either moving forward and then dropping back to receive or dropping back and then making a run in behind.
2. If playing a pass in behind to the winger, make sure it isn't too predictable.

Combination Play Between the Midfield and Attack in a 6 v 4 (+GK) Game



Description

Using half a full pitch, we play a 6 v 4 (+GK) game. In midfield we have a 2 v 1 situation with 2 orange central midfielders and 1 blue central midfielder. Out wide we have 1 v 1 situations with orange wingers versus blue full backs. Finally, we have a 2 v 1 situation in the centre (orange striker & No.10 versus 1 blue centre back).

The practice starts with the orange midfielders who's aim is to pass to the striker (9) or No.10 who calls for the ball to his feet. This then leaves the other forward open for the orange team to attack. The central midfielders and wingers function as support players from this point.

In the diagram example, the No.10 receives the forward pass and plays it into the path of No.8 who moves forward. At the same time, the striker has made a run in behind to receive in behind and shoot at goal. The 2 wingers also made supporting runs and are passing options in behind the defensive line.

The blue team always start in the same positions and then try to defend their goal, win the ball and then score themselves in one of the small goals on the halfway line.

Winning Moment: 3 sequences are played. The team that manages to score 3 times first, wins a sequence.

Coaching Points

1. The forwards need to be aware of the defender's position at all times so he can make the correct decision.
2. Where is the space? To fully exploit the numerical advantage a final pass should be made early into the space.

Progression: In the second phase of this practice, an additional centre back is added. This increases the difficulty for the forwards who now play within a 2 v 2 situation. There is then more emphasis on the midfielders' support play.

Positional Play and Coordinated Movements in Front of Goal in a 6 v 5 (+GK) Game



Description

In this practice we mark out 2 zones. We have an orange centre back (5) and a central midfielder (8) in the small zone and the No.10, 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9) in the main zone. We have 1 full sized goal with a keeper and 5 blue players defending in a 3-2 formation. Along the line between the zones there are 2 small goals. The forwards try to score in the big goal, whilst the defenders try to win the ball and score in one of the small goals.

The orange team run through a specific sequence to switch the play from one side to the other and then score. You can start by just running through the sequence with passive defenders or without defenders. Depending on the strength of the forwards, the number of defenders can then be increased or decreased once you play with active defenders. The defenders become active once their direct opponent has passed the ball.

1. The centre back (5) passes to the winger (11) who has moved forward and checked back to receive. No.11 passes back to the central midfielder (8) who passes to the striker (9).
2. The striker (9) drops back to retain possession and plays a first time pass into the path of No.8.
3. As the striker (9) has dropped deep, the No.10 makes an advanced run into the created space.
4. No.8 plays out wide to the right winger (7) and now the team have successfully switched the play. The winger's job is to beat the defender and cross the ball into the penalty area.
5. The striker (9) runs to the front post, No.10 runs to the penalty spot, the left winger (11) runs to the far post and the central midfielder (8) moves to the edge of the penalty area.

All players must return to their specific position after a goal except No.5 and No.8 who switch their positions. After 8 sequences, repeat the practice starting from the opposite the other side.

Striker Drops to Receive + Combination Play Between Midfield & Attack in a 6 v 5 (+GK) Game



Objective: To improve passing to the striker (9) who drops deep and the collaboration between the midfielders and the forwards.

Description

Using half a full pitch, we play 6 v 5 (+GK). The orange team have 3 central midfielders (6, 8 & 10), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). The blue team have 2 central midfielders, 2 full backs and 1 centre back.

The orange striker and the blue centre back start within the 'free zone' (10 x 10 yards) where the ball cannot in the first phase. Depending on the qualities of the striker, the coach can increase or decrease the size of the zone.

The practice starts with the orange midfielders as they play the ball around, looking to pass the ball to the striker who must drop out of the 'free zone' to receive. The blue centre back tries to prevent this but cannot leave the zone before the striker does.

Once the striker receives the free zone is cancelled and no longer relevant - the orange team attack and try to score. If the blues win the ball they try to score in the small goals on the halfway line. Any goals scored by the orange striker count double.

Coaching Points

1. The striker needs to maintain eye contact with the player on the ball.
2. The striker also needs to judge the right moment to drop deep and receive the pass.

Forward Play: Coordinated Movements in a 7 v 7 (+GK) Game



Objective: We work with the striker (9) and the No.10 on making coordinated movements (short and long). They create space to receive and then maintain possession for their team.

Description

Using half a pitch we have a 7 v 7 situation. There is a full size goal with a goalkeeper at one end and 2 cone gates on the halfway line. The orange team are in a 1-3-3 formation and the blues are in a 4-3 formation.

The practice starts with a coach passing to the orange team on one side. The striker (9) and No.10 have to both touch the ball before the team can try to score. Passing the ball to these 2 players is the main focus:

1. Pass to the striker (9) who drops back and plays a first time pass back into midfield.
2. The No.10 makes a forward run to take up the striker's position and the team switch the play to the other side. The No.10 then makes a second movement and drops back to receive.
3. As soon as No.10 touches the ball, the orange team are free to attack and try to score past the goalkeeper.

The blue team defend their goal, try to win the ball and then counter attack - to score they must dribble through the cone gates. If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play, start the practice again from the other side.

Winning Moment: We have 10 repetitions starting from the 2 coaches alternately. The team with the most goals wins.

Coaching Points

1. "Where is the space? When your teammate drops, move into the space created."
2. "Anticipate the new situation quickly!"

Build Up Play and Attacking the Space in the Opposition Half in a 7 v 6 (+GK) Game



Objective: We work on retaining possession and building up play + creating goal scoring opportunities by exploiting the space in the opposition's half.

Description

For this practice we use a full pitch up until the edge of the penalty area, as shown. We have a full size goal and goalkeeper at one end and 2 small goals at the other end. A zone is marked out in between the penalty area and the halfway line, which is where all the outfield players start.

The orange team have 1 centre back, 3 central midfielders, 2 wingers and 1 striker. The orange team aim to initially retain possession and then play a pass into the space in the opposition's half. From this point, the zone restrictions are removed and we have 7 v 6 attack. For a goal to count, all the orange players must have moved into the opposition's half. Goals after a long pass count double.

The blue team defend in a 3-3 formation, try to win the ball and then score in one of the 2 small goals. The goalkeeper stays alert and acts as a sweeper for any over hit passes.

Coaching Points

1. Build up patiently, making sure to retain the ball in a limited space.
2. Play the forward pass when possible - if there is space available and a good run is made by a teammate.

Exploiting Space in Behind the Opposition's Defence in an 8 v 8 Small Sided Game



Objective: We work on passing in behind the opposition's defensive line and the timing of the movement.

Description

Using an area 10 yards longer than half a full pitch, we play an 8 v 8 game with full sized goals. We mark out an end zone in line with the penalty area as shown.

The orange team are in a 3-1-3 formation with 1 centre back (5), 2 full backs (2 & 3), 1 central midfielder (8), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). The blue team are in a 4-3 formation with the back 4 and 3 central midfielders.

The practice always starts with the orange team's goalkeeper. The orange team aim to build up play and exploit the space in behind the opposition's defence with a through pass. A player, usually a forward, needs to time their run to receive in behind. Once this happens there are no restrictions in relation to the zones and the players can move freely to support the attack and try to score. In the diagram example, the right winger (7) receives No.8's pass in behind and crosses for the left winger (11) to finish at the back post.

The defending team are not allowed to enter the final zone until the ball is played in there. A goal from the orange striker (9) counts double.

The blue team aim to defend their goal and win the ball. If they do, they then try to score in the opposite goal. If a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play at any time, start again with the orange team's goalkeeper.

Coaching Points

1. There needs to be quick ball circulation and combination play to set the striker (9) free.
2. If you win possession from the opposition, try to play a forward pass in behind the defensive line and into space as quickly as possible.

CHAPTER 8

DEFENDING

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Positional Play in the Defensive Phase

If the opposition have the ball, your whole team will have to be involved in defending. You could choose to press in the opposition's half. In that case you want to play far away from your own goal and win possession quickly. Alternatively, you can choose to be compact and defend in your own half. This can make it very difficult for the opposition to find time and space in the final third.

In both cases it's about defending and the following principles are key to development:

1. At youth level it's sensible to teach your players how to defend collectively in order to win and maintain possession, and not just simply kick the ball away.
2. It is very important to clarify that defending isn't only a job for the defence, as it has to start in the front line with the forwards. The defending tactics shown in this section will be displayed in order from where our defending starts: Attack -> Midfield -> Defence.

When opting for a defensive style of play, you as a coach should be guided by your own vision and the vision of the club. However, it's also wise to take a number of external factors into account. For instance, think about the level of competition that you play at. It could be the case that you have to apply some modifications to a more defensive style of play if your players are competing at a higher level or age group.

Furthermore, you have to pay attention to the force and qualities of the opposition for each match and compare it against your own team's qualities. Finally, you also should consider the objective of the match and possible circumstances relating to the weather and terrain.



Basic Defensive Tactical Principles of the 4-3-3 Formation



Making the pitch small when the opposition have the ball is one of the focal points of our defensive tactics. The following are all very important aspects which the entire team need to master:

1. The 1 v 1 duel.
2. Providing cover for teammates.
3. Pushing up in the centre.
4. Collective (team) reactions e.g. When the ball is on our left side and an opponent beats one of our midfielders in a 1 v 1 duel, we must have a collective reaction to cover, get back into shape and deny the opposition time and space to create opportunities.

The basic principles for the whole team are:

- **Everybody is Responsible for their Direct Opponent:**

The diagram shows 4-3-3 vs 4-3-3. As both teams are playing with 1 striker, each team usually has 1 open player (normally one of the centre backs). The striker (9) therefore, has to learn how to play against 2 opponents. The other players are responsible for their direct opponent, while our free centre back (No.5 in diagram) can provide cover for his teammates.

- **Look to Play a Combination with a Winger (7 or 11) or Striker (9):**

This is important once we have won the ball in the defensive phase. We should look to play forward quickly while the opposition are still unorganised. As most forwards find themselves in 1 v 1 situations, the midfielders should look to link up with the forwards, so that these 1 v 1 situations can be exploited high up the pitch to create goal scoring opportunities.

1 v 1 Situations All Over the Pitch



If the opposition have the same system as us, 1 v 1 situations occur all over the pitch.

Without a real open player, playing football by means of positional play is much more difficult. However, this does not mean that youth players should only play 1 v 1.

Players Provide Cover for Each Other within the Formation



When learning to play football (defending) on a whole pitch, it's important that all players, in every position, are introduced to the principle of covering.

You're responsible for your own direct opponent, but that doesn't mean that you shouldn't help your teammates.

The Role of the Forwards

Preventing the Opposition's Build Up Play



- **Stop the Opposition Building Up Play**

It is important to stop the opposition from building up play during particular moments in the match. The entire team takes part in this, but the main players are the 3 forwards (7, 11 & 9) and the central midfielders (10, 8 & 6).

- **The Striker and Wingers Work Together to Apply Pressure:**

In the diagram example, we show the ball starting with the goalkeeper. The striker (9) has to learn how to block the line between the 2 centre backs in a 2 v 1 situation, making sure to cover both. During this process, he needs to be assisted by both wingers (7 & 11). If the ball is played to the right centre back (4), then our left winger (7) has to help apply pressure and reduce the space. The right winger (11) is then responsible for his opponent (the left centre back No.5), but could perhaps move inside a little bit to block/intercept a potential pass to him.

Pressing High Up in the Centre



A number of basic principles apply when it comes to pushing up in the centre of the pitch when the opposition have possession:

1. The No.10 pushes up to the front line to apply pressure on one of the centre backs.
2. One of our centre backs (No.5 in diagram) pushes up into midfield to maintain the 3 v 3 situation in there.
3. The goalkeeper pushes up to become the 'sweeper' and provide cover if the ball is played in behind.

It's good to explain to your players that there are a few clear situations when they should push up through the centre. Here are some examples:

- When the opposition goalkeeper passes the ball out short to a defender.
- A pass takes a long time to travel from one opponent to another (time to push up collectively).
- A bad pass or a heavy touch when an opposition player is receiving a pass.
- An opponent who is weak in the build up has possession of the ball.

The Role of the Midfield

The midfield can communicate with the 'open' centre back to take over the marking of an oncoming midfielder. You can't ask for too much when it comes to passing on the marking of an opponent, which is different to usual covering. However, the clearest and easiest takeover is from one of our centre backs, who can take over the marking of a central midfielder (No.10 in diagram) who makes a run forward. This is a clear and easy example as player positioning can remain intact (in midfield particularly).

Providing Cover and Taking Over Marking while Pressing as a Team



- Pushing Up Through the Centre:**

No.10 must learn to recognise the moment to apply pressure on one of the centre backs. He must communicate/collaborate with the centre back (No.5) and striker (No.9) e.g. When our No.10 goes forward, the centre back needs to move forward to take over the opposing No.10's marking.

- Following and Marking your Direct Opponent:**

All 3 central midfielders must learn to win their 1 v 1 duel with their direct opponent. Therefore, following and marking your opponent is an important point of attention. Prevent making unnecessary tackles during the duels.

- Providing Cover:**

If the opposition's left centre back has the ball (as shown in the diagram with No.5), then the central midfielder on that side (No.6) has to press his opponent (maybe even get in front of him). No.10 has to be clearly on the inside of his direct opponent, while No.8 lets his opponent go and closes down the space behind No.10 and No.6 - he moves inside and provides cover.

The Role of the Defence

Centre Back Defends in Front of the Back-line (Leaving 3 at Back)



When playing with one centre back in front of the defence (No.5 in diagram), you then play 1 v 1 in the back-line.

The full backs pushing inside is a key element, which needs to be coached for 1 v 1 situations.

Goalkeeper Plays as a Sweeper



The goalkeeper is the 'sweeper'. It's important that the goalkeeper has already learnt to position himself outside the penalty area when the opposition have the ball, as if he's the last open defender behind his defence (sweeper). Many youth coaches agree with this, but yet you don't see it often!

You should encourage a young goalkeeper and give him the confidence to position himself on the edge of the penalty area. Also don't forget to show (him, all players and parents) what it yields. If it goes wrong one time during the judgement of a long pass, then it really shouldn't change anything - this is part of the learning process. Too often you see coaches and goalkeepers lose confidence so they drop deeper and deeper - the coach needs to be positive and persevere with this sweeping tactic as it has great benefits in the long term.

Maintaining Positioning in Midfield



Regardless of the opposition's formation, it's wise to always maintain your own midfield positioning, with the No.10 in the more advanced position.

In this example the No.10 is very advanced so the centre back (5) pushes up to retain a balanced midfield.

Tactical Principles when Playing Against 2 Forwards (3-4-3 v 4-4-2)



If the opposition play with 2 forwards e.g. 4-4-2 formation (with diamond) as shown in diagram, the preference is then to play with 3 defenders in a 3-4-3 formation, as shown in the diagram.

The full backs (2 & 3) come inside to cover/mark the forwards so we often have a centre back open behind the line or in the middle (No.4 in diagram). The second centre back plays in front of his defence, often marking the opposition's No.10. We then get a 3-4-3 formation.

An alternative against 2 forwards is to use a back 4 together in a line. The full backs have to make many decisions to provide cover (horizontally) or move forward to mark players in midfield. This is often too complicated for the players and is not preferred at this age/level.

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Pressing from the Front with the Forwards in a Dynamic Game



Objective

To improve the pressing by the front four players. If these players do not collaborate well when trying to disturb the opposition's build-up, the opposition can easily play a forward pass and push into midfield.

Description

In the area shown, we have 2 small goals at end and use half of the centre circle as a zone at the other end. The orange team have 1 striker (9), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and an attacking midfielder (10). The blues have their back 4, a central midfielder (6) and 1 striker (9).

The practice starts with the coach's pass and the blue team in possession - they try to build up the play using their 5 v 4 numerical advantage. The blue striker (9) must stay within his zone and no other player is allowed in there. If the blue striker (9) receives a pass successfully in the centre circle or the team complete 10 consecutive passes, they score 1 point.

The orange team of 4 press collectively and try to intercept the ball and score in one of the small goals. If the ball goes out of play, then the coach should pass a new ball in to one of the blue centre backs to start again.

Progression

Change to a 2 zone small sided game with large goals and 2 goalkeepers. You can have 5 (+GK) blue players in the first zone vs 4 orange attackers. By means of a dribble or a pass to the striker, the blues can get into the second zone and try to score.

Coaching Points

The Striker (9):

1. When pressing, run into the space between the centre backs so they can't play the ball back to each other.
2. Force them to play the ball out wide.
3. Don't let them dribble the ball past you.

The Left Winger (11):

1. Let the right back open up and move inside diagonally a bit.
2. Prevent the full back or centre back from playing a long pass to the blue striker.
3. Apply pressure on the right back as soon as someone passes the ball to him.
4. Participate in the duel and try to intercept the ball.

The Right Winger (7):

1. Come inside as soon the striker starts pressing.
2. Provide cover to No.9 or No.10.

The Central Midfielder (10)

1. Prevent your direct opponent from receiving the ball - be positioned next to him or in front of him.
2. Leave your marker if it is to intercept the pass to the blue striker.
3. Coach the 3 attackers in front of you.

Pressing High to Prevent Opposition's Build Up in a 6 v 5 (+GK) Small Sided Game



Objective: To work on disturbing the build-up of the opposition, to try and win the ball high up the pitch.

Description

Within half a full pitch, the blue team have a goalkeeper, the back 4 and 1 central midfielder (6). The orange team have 3 central midfielders (6, 8 & 10), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9). We mark out a halfway line which effects the game's scoring.

The blue team's goalkeeper starts the practice and the blue team try to build up play, break through the orange team's press and then finally score in the empty goal.

The orange team press high up in the opposition's half ('High Pressing Zone'), try to win the ball and then score past the goalkeeper.

Winning Moment: The first team to score 6 goals wins the game. If the orange team win the ball in the opposition half and then score, the goal counts double.

Coaching Points

1. Press using curved runs (and body shape) to force opposition players in the direction you want them to go.
2. Force the opponent to go inside like the winger (7) does to the blue full back in the diagram. The other players (9, 10 & 11) are then able to push very high up the pitch.
3. Don't commit too early and let the opponent beat you too easily.
4. Keep pressure on the ball and mark the potential receivers of the next pass.

Pressing High Up to Prevent Opposition's Build Up in an 8 v 8 Small Sided Game



Objective: We work on pressing high up the pitch to block the build up play of our opponents.

Description

In this 8 v 8 small sided game we use the area in between the 2 penalty areas as shown.

The orange team are in a 3-1-3 formation with 1 centre back (5), 2 full backs (2 & 3), 1 central midfielder (8), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker. The blue team are in a 4-3 formation with the back 4 and 3 central midfielders.

The practice always starts with the blue team's goalkeeper. The blue team try to build up play and score. The aim for the orange team is to apply high pressure in the opposition's half and disturb their build up. They want to block forward passes, force the ball inside and try to intercept the ball, before then scoring.

If the orange team win the ball in the blue team's half and then score, the goal counts double.

The blue team aim to break through the pressure. They focus on trying to exploit the space the orange team leave in behind by pressing high up the pitch.

Providing Cover and Taking Over Marking while Pressing in the Midfield Area (3 Zone Practice)



Description

In the area shown, we divide the pitch into 3 zones. Each team has 1 centre back (5) in an end zone and 3 central midfielders in the middle zone. In this example the blue team start with the ball and their aim is to play through the centre and dribble the ball across the end line. If the orange team win the ball, they then try to dribble the ball across the opposite line.

The practice starts when the coach passes to one of the centre backs. At this moment one of the central midfielders (No.10 in diagram) must move forward to close him down. This leaves an opposing central midfielder free of marking - so the orange centre back (5) moves forward to take over the marking of blue No.10, as shown. From this moment there are no restrictions in relation to the zones and all the players can move freely.

Either the blue team are able to play through the pressure and dribble across the line (1 point) or the orange team win the ball and try to do the same. If a point is scored or the ball goes out of play, always start again with the coach's pass to a centre back.

Coaching Points

1. Close in on the opponent after he receives the ball.
2. Coach the player in front of you (this is key to successfully taking over marking of an opponent).

Collective Movement of the Back 4 to Provide Cover & Keep Compact in a 4 (+GK) v 5 Practice



Objective: To work on the collective movement of the defence - keep close distances and shift across as a unit to prevent dangerous 1 v 1 situations developing (quickly get from one side of the pitch to the other).

Description

In the area shown we have 4 orange defenders and 1 goalkeeper + 2 blue central midfielders (8 & 10), 2 wingers and 1 striker. The deepest central midfielder (8) is not allowed to dribble the ball across the end line (or score) and is limited to 2 touches.

The central midfielder (8) starts with a pass and the blue team try to move the ball at speed, create space out wide and dribble across the end line (1 point). They then try to score past the goalkeeper for an extra point.

The orange team have 1 centre back (No.5) who plays in front and focusses on marking blue No.10. The other orange players (1 centre back and 2 full backs) work as a unit to keep a good line and shift across together, denying their opposition space to get round or behind them and forcing the play back inside.

We emphasise using collective pressing to win the ball from the opponents. If the orange team gain possession, they can then try to dribble the ball over the opposite end line (1 point).

Coaching Points

1. Keep moving in relation to where the ball is.
2. If the ball goes to the opposition's right winger, then our left back closes him down. If the ball goes to the opposition's left winger, then our right back closes him down.

3. Close the space for the winger, take away the speed from his dribble and then try to win the ball.
4. Coach the defender who's stepping out.
5. Stand open so you can always see both the ball and your man.
6. In the diagram example the opposition's right winger (7) receives. The left back (3) closes him down and the centre back shifts across. In this situation, the right back (2) coaches the centre back and shifts across to provide cover.
7. Assess how far you have to go across.
8. Coach the players as to whether they should enter a duel with the striker (if he receives the ball) or remain in position, and keep him in front of you.

Pressing and Shifting Across to Provide Cover in Defence in a Small Sided Game



Objective: We work with our defenders to make sure they react quickly and shift across to cover/defend when the ball is on the other side of the pitch or if there is danger through the centre.

Description

In this progression of the previous practice, we use half a full pitch but make the area a little narrower, as shown. We have 2 full size goals with goalkeepers and play a 5 v 6 small sided game. The orange team have 2 centre backs (4 & 5) and 2 full backs (2 & 3). The blue team are in a 2-3 formation with 2 central midfielders (limited to 2 touches), 2 wingers (7 & 11) and 1 striker (9).

The practice starts with the blue team's goalkeeper and he passes to one of the central midfielders. This is affected by the orange centre back No.5 who plays in front of the defence - he moves forward to press and forces the play to one side. The blue team build up play at speed and try to create space out wide or in the centre to shoot and score past the goalkeeper.

The orange back 3 (1 centre back and 2 full backs) work as a unit to keep a good line and shift across together, denying their opposition space to get round or behind them and forcing the play back inside. We emphasise using this collective pressing to win the ball from their opponents. If they gain possession, they can then try to counter attack and score in the opposite goal.

You can start with a 4 v 5 small sided game and progress to use more players.

Coaching Points

1. The full back needs to shift across and provide a cover for the centre back if the ball is on the other side.
2. For each situation, indicate how far the full backs have to push inside.
3. Take over the marking of the striker if the centre back has to step out e.g. if the centre back has to cover the other full back when the winger beats him.
4. The goalkeeper should coach his back line throughout:
Who needs to step out? How far does the full back have to come inside?
5. The goalkeeper should also stay alert to provide cover for the defenders.
6. After winning possession, emphasise the need for quick counter attacks.

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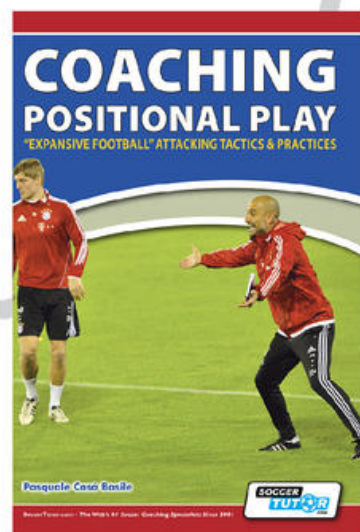
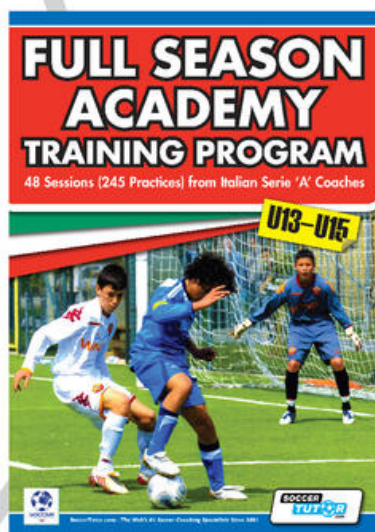
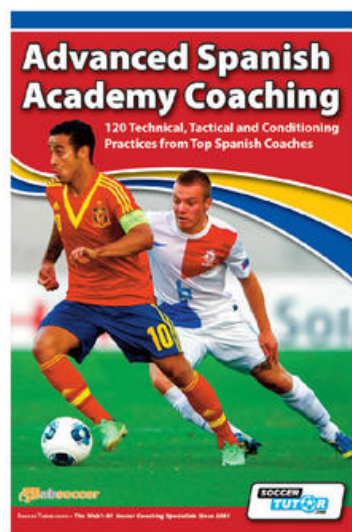


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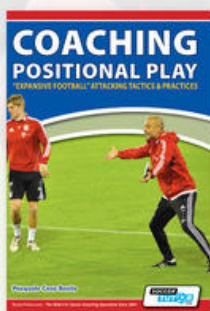
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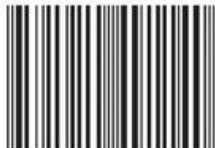
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